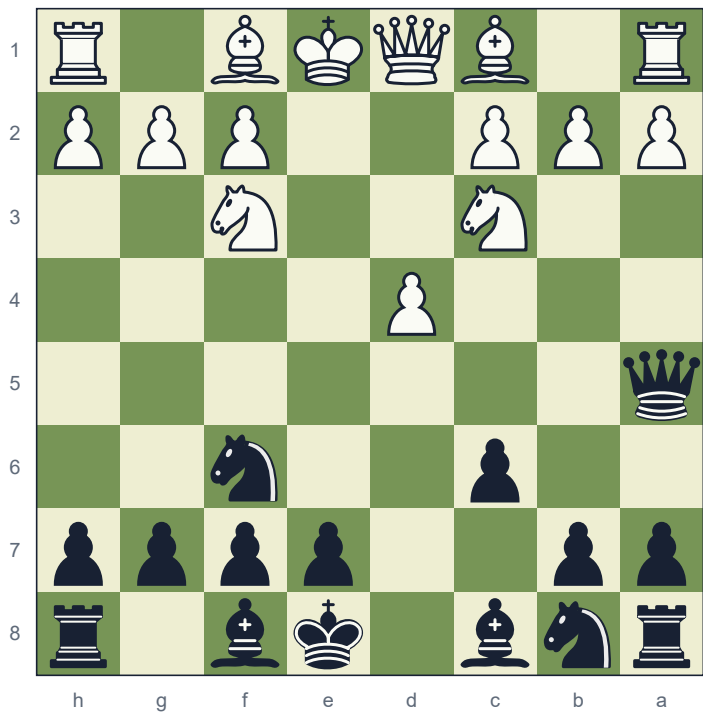


Scandinavian Defense

A complete practical curriculum from the ground up

After 1.e4 d5 Black immediately challenges the center. The main repertoire uses 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3 Qa5, followed by development, ...c6 and ...e6 when appropriate. White gains time attacking the queen; Black must spend the remaining tempi carefully.



The reference position - White to move

YOUR PERSPECTIVE

Black is at the bottom of every diagram. Coordinates remain explicit and all pieces stay upright.

WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

26 opening branches, six middlegame laboratories, 48 exercises with explained answers, and a 12-week practice plan. Each subject also appears in one combined volume.

START HERE

Read this booklet first. Then learn one line from each family in Booklet 01. Use 02 for plans, 03 for practice positions, 04 for retrieval and 05 for study schedules and reference.

How to use this course

YOUR FIRST PASS

Use a real or digital board. Read the foundations, then learn only the first line of each opening family. Play slow practice games before trying to remember every variation. A useful opening lesson ends with a decision you can explain, not a string of moves you can recite.

YOUR SECOND PASS

Return to the branch your opponent actually played. Replay it from move one and stop before each move by your side. Name the threat, two plausible replies and the reason for your choice. Check the printed continuation only after committing to an answer.

YOUR THIRD PASS

Use the middlegame laboratories and exercise book. These are original illustrative positions and engine-assisted continuations, not attributed master games. Switch colors in training so you experience the opponent's space, defensive resources and attacking chances.

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This is a broad practical curriculum from basic rules to common opening decisions, middlegames and typical transitions. Chess has too many legal branches for a finite course to exhaust. The course teaches a decision process for unfamiliar replies and marks alternatives, warnings and entry-route boundaries explicitly.

The board and the object of the game

COORDINATES

Files are a through h from White's left to right. Ranks are 1 through 8 from White's side toward Black. A square such as e4 has one file letter and one rank number. White has a light square at the near right corner, h1. Black-oriented diagrams reverse the coordinate display, not the movement rules.

URNS AND CHECK

White moves first; the players alternate one move each. A move may not leave your own king attacked. Check means that the king is attacked; answer by moving the king, capturing the attacker or blocking a line attack when possible. A knight check cannot be blocked.

CHECKMATE AND STALEMATE

Checkmate means the player to move is in check and has no legal reply. Stalemate means the player has no legal move but is not in check; it is a draw. Before announcing mate, examine every king move, capture and possible block. Kings are never actually captured.

MATERIAL IS A GUIDE

For beginner decisions, a pawn is roughly 1, a knight or bishop 3, a rook 5 and a queen 9. These are rough comparisons, not a scoring rule. A king has no exchange value. Activity, safety, passed pawns and immediate tactics can outweigh a small material difference.

How the pieces move

ROOK AND BISHOP

A rook moves along a rank or file. A bishop moves diagonally and stays on its starting square color. Neither can jump over any piece. A sliding piece controls only as far as the first occupied square on each ray; do not count an attack through your own pawn.

QUEEN AND KNIGHT

A queen combines rook and bishop movement. A knight moves two squares in one direction and one at right angles, changing square color. The knight may jump over pieces. A knight on f3 can move to d2, d4, e1, e5, g1, g5, h2 or h4 if the destination and king-safety rules allow.

KING

A king moves one square in any direction and cannot enter an attacked square. The kings cannot stand next to each other. A pinned enemy piece can still restrict the king's legal squares; the rules about attacked squares are more subtle than whether that enemy piece could legally move away from its own king.

PAWN

White pawns move toward higher rank numbers; Black pawns toward lower. A pawn moves one square straight ahead into an empty square, or two from its starting rank if both squares are empty. It captures one square diagonally forward. It cannot move backward or capture straight ahead.

Castling, promotion and en passant

CASTLING

Castling moves the king two squares toward a rook and places that rook on the square the king crossed. The king and that rook must never have moved, the intervening squares must be empty, and the king must not be in check or cross or land on an attacked square. A rook being attacked does not by itself prevent castling.

RIGHTS DO NOT RETURN

If a king or rook moves out and back, the relevant castling right is still lost. A king moved to f1 in the King's Gambit must coordinate its rooks another way. In queenless positions the loss of castling may be less serious, but the legal right remains lost.

PROMOTION

A pawn reaching the last rank must promote to a queen, rook, bishop or knight of its color. It need not choose a previously captured piece. A second queen is legal. Underpromotion can avoid stalemate or create a knight fork, so inspect the exact position before always choosing a queen.

EN PASSANT

Immediately after an opposing pawn advances two squares from its starting rank and lands beside your pawn on your fifth rank, you may capture it as though it had advanced one square. The opportunity lasts only for your next move. The capture is illegal if removing those pawns exposes your own king to check.

Reading moves and navigating branches

ALGEBRAIC NOTATION

K means king, Q queen, R rook, B bishop and N knight. Pawns have no piece letter: e4 is a pawn move. Bc4 means a bishop moves to c4. Nxe5 captures on e5. exd5 is an e-file pawn capturing on d5. A plus sign is check; # is checkmate; O-O is kingside castling and O-O-O queenside castling.

WHICH PIECE MOVED

If two identical pieces can legally reach the same square, notation distinguishes them: Nbd2 means the knight from the b-file; R1e2 means the rook from rank 1. The board, not the notation alone, determines which capture or check is legal. Promotion is written e8=Q, with + or # when appropriate.

MOVE NUMBERS

1.e4 e5 is White's first move and Black's first reply. A line beginning 7...Nf6 starts with Black's seventh move. All main opening lines in this course begin at the initial position; laboratory continuations display their starting diagram and exact move number.

ONE LINE IS NOT FORCED

An example to move ten is one route through the position. It is not a claim that every reply is compulsory. The authored anchor and its illustrative continuation are distinguished. Each line has an ID that also appears in the PGN files and exercises.

Your thinking routine on every move

1. INSPECT THE LAST MOVE

Ask what the opponent's move changed. Did it attack a piece, unmask a bishop, release a rook file, threaten mate or leave something undefended? A remembered opening move is only a candidate until it survives this inspection.

2. EXAMINE FORCING MOVES

Check all checks, serious captures and direct threats for both sides. Calculate the opponent's best reply, not the reply you hope for. Stop the line at a position you can assess: material, king safety and the resulting pawn structure.

3. GENERATE CANDIDATES

Usually compare two or three useful moves: one forcing move, one developing or improving move, and one central response if relevant. In a cramped position ask which exchange or pawn break creates room. In an attacking position ask whether the center can open against your king.

4. BLUNDER CHECK

Before moving, visualize the new position. Is your queen or another piece loose? Have you removed a defender or opened a diagonal to your king? Can the opponent answer with a check, fork or intermediate capture? A ten-second check often saves more points than memorizing another opening branch.

Center, development and time

OCCUPY AND INFLUENCE

Pawns on d4 and e4 occupy central space; bishops and knights can influence those squares from a distance. A restrained setup needs a plan to challenge the opponent's center. Space becomes useful when it gives your pieces safe squares and restricts the opponent.

DEVELOPMENT

Bring knights and bishops into useful play, protect the king and connect the rooks. Avoid moving the same piece repeatedly without a concrete gain. An exception must be explained: a queen retreat in the Scandinavian or a knight escape in the King's Gambit can be compulsory.

A TEMPO

A tempo is one move of useful time. Attacking a queen while developing often gains time, but a check that helps the opponent develop can fail to do so. Count actual useful moves and threats instead of assuming every attack is a gain.

OPENING THE CENTER

If your king is safer and your pieces are ready, opening files can exploit a development lead. If your king is exposed, central exchanges may be dangerous. A closed center often allows maneuvering or a wing attack, but first verify that the opponent cannot open it with a pawn break.

Pawn structures and planning vocabulary

BREAK AND TENSION

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure: c4 against d5 or ...c5 against d4. Tension exists when pawns can capture each other but neither side has committed. Before exchanging, ask which pieces become active, which file opens and which pawn becomes weak.

CHAIN AND BASE

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually supporting pawns. In a white d4-e5 chain, d4 is the base and e5 the head. An attack on either end may work, but the calculation differs: ...c5 usually challenges d4, while ...f6 challenges e5.

WEAK SQUARES AND OUTPOSTS

A square is a useful outpost when a piece can occupy it securely and create meaningful pressure, often because enemy pawns cannot chase it. An outpost with no targets may be less valuable than a flexible central piece. Check whether exchanges eliminate its support.

FILES, DIAGONALS AND LEVERS

A file without pawns is open; one with no pawn of your color is half-open for you. A fianchetto bishop can be excellent on an open diagonal and restricted behind blocked pawns. A lever changes that reality. Name the pawn move that makes your plan possible.

Playing, recording and analyzing a game

CHOOSE A USEFUL TIME CONTROL

For course practice use at least 15 minutes with an increment, or a longer control if available. Blitz is useful for pattern recognition after the basic decisions are learned. It is a poor substitute for calculating an unfamiliar sharp opening carefully.

ANALYZE YOURSELF FIRST

After the game, mark the first unfamiliar position and write your candidates without an engine. Identify the first important mistake, not only the final blunder. Separate opening memory, tactical calculation, strategic judgment and time-management errors.

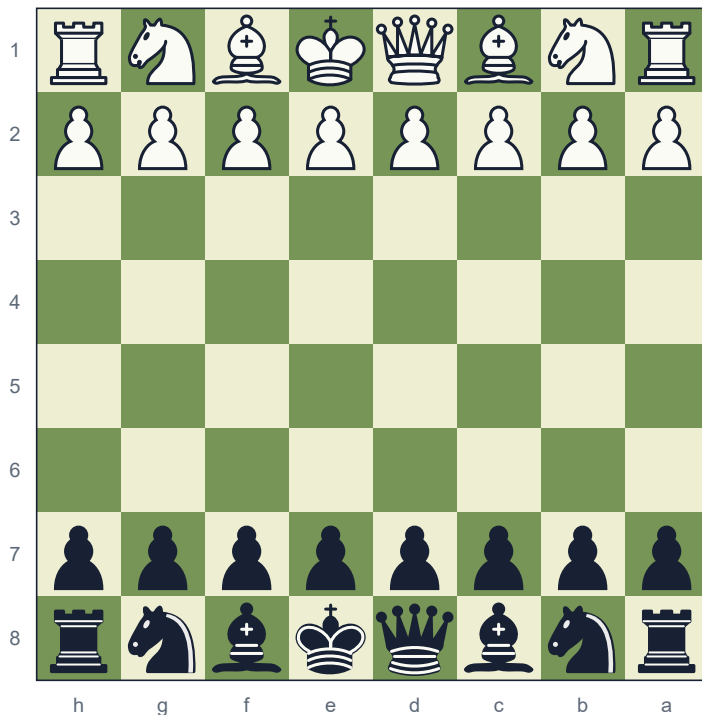
THEN USE THE TOOLS

Compare the game with the matching line ID. Use an engine to test forcing variations and examine a stronger defensive reply. An engine number is evidence from a finite search, not a verbal explanation. Write one sentence that tells you what to do differently next time.

BUILD A SMALL ERROR NOTEBOOK

Keep the position, your move, a better candidate, the opponent's key reply and one lesson. Revisit it after one day, three days, a week and a month. Add the position to your repertoire only when you can explain it without the answer visible.

Read the diagram before the moves



White to move

A RELIABLE FIRST SCAN

Find both kings, name the side to move and locate all pawns in the center. Then inspect checks, captures and direct threats.

ORIENTATION

Your course side is at the bottom. On a Black-oriented board, files read h to a along the bottom; pawns still move according to their color and rank numbers.

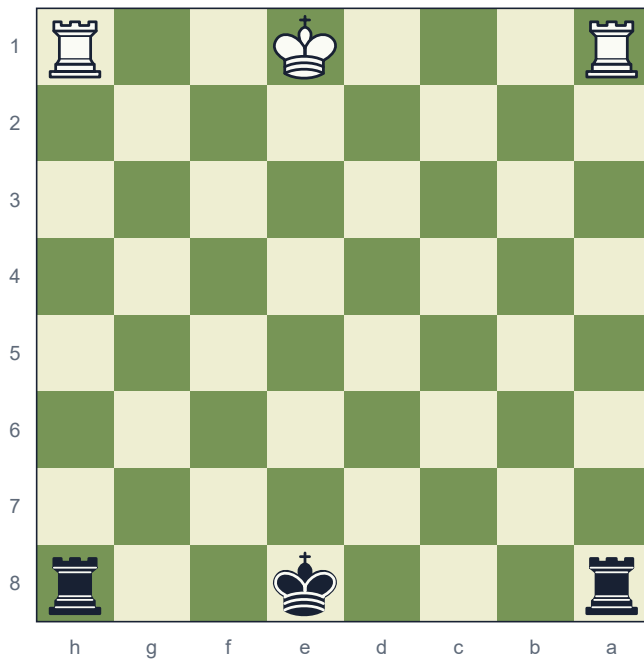
PRACTICE WITHOUT MOVING

Find e4, d5, f7 and b2. Name the piece that begins on each of b1, c1, f8 and g8. From the initial position, count White's legal pawn moves and knight moves: 16 pawn moves and 4 knight moves.

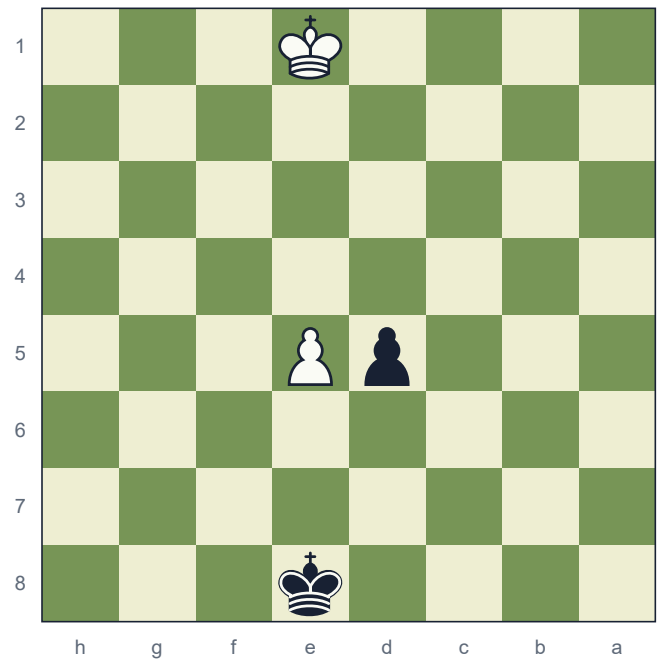
ANSWER THE REAL POSITION

A board caption always states whose move it is and whether the king is in check. You may not ignore check to finish development. In the initial position, bishops and rooks are blocked by friendly pieces.

Castling and en passant on a board



White to move - castling geometry



White to move - en passant available

LEFT: CASTLING GEOMETRY

With the rights recorded in this teaching position, White may castle O-O or O-O-O. The king crosses f1 or d1 and lands on g1 or c1; the rook lands on f1 or d1. Empty squares alone are not enough in a real game: check previous king/rook moves and attacked king squares.

RIGHT: IMMEDIATE EN PASSANT

Black has just played ...d7-d5. White can play exd6 en passant: the white pawn lands on d6 and the black pawn is removed from d5. If White plays another move, the special capture is no longer available.

TRAINING QUESTION

Why can a knight jump over a piece but a bishop cannot? Why can a rook be attacked during legal castling while the king cannot cross an attacked square? Explain the movement rule before using it in an opening.

Your first moves, explained

1... D5

Changes central space and pawn contacts. Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension before choosing the next piece plan.

2... QXD5

The queen captures a pawn on d5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

3... QA5

Places the queen on a5, attacking knight on c3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

4... NF6

Develops the king knight toward e4 and d5. Its location also blocks some long-diagonal bishop attacks, but makes it a possible target of e5.

5... C6

Places the pawn on c6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

BEFORE YOU MEMORIZE

The reference route is one example. Reconstruct it, then change one opposing move and explain why the next automatic setup move might need to change.

Repertoire map / 1

THE ...QA5 CORE REPERTOIRE

Start with SC-01. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

SC-01 The classical development route

Develop the bishop before locking it in.

SC-02 White uses Qe2 and long castling

The king choice changes the race.

SC-03 White castles short early

An open e-file is a development deadline.

SC-04 White puts the bishop on d3

Respect the bishop diagonal before weakening king cover.

SC-05 White develops quietly with Be2

Use the quiet phase to finish development.

SC-06 White fianchettoes

Long diagonals become dangerous when the center clears.

Repertoire map / 2

ACTIVE WHITE SYSTEMS AND QUEEN SAFETY

Start with SC-07. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

SC-07 White attacks Bf5 with Ne5

Two attacked pieces can turn a pawn push into a tactic.

SC-08 White pushes g4 against the bishop

Compare the bishop's whole escape route.

SC-09 An immediate Bd2 hits the queen

Every c3-knight move may uncover a queen attack.

SC-10 The b4 pawn offer

Queen safety can be worth more than retaining a gambit pawn.

SC-11 White advances d5 early

A wedge must be challenged or blockaded deliberately.

SC-12 White plays Bc4 before Nf3

Compare exact piece positions before calling a transposition.

Repertoire map / 3

WHITE AVOIDS THE MAIN ROUTE

Start with SC-13. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

SC-13 White advances with 2.e5

The Scandinavian queen plan belongs to the exchange structure.

SC-14 White defends with 2.Nc3

A structural concession needs active pieces in return.

SC-15 White offers the Blackmar-Diemer

Against a gambit, make the extra pawn easy to live with.

SC-16 White plays 2.Nf3

Defend with development when possible.

SC-17 White recaptures space with 3.d4

A queen needs an escape route even before it is attacked.

SC-18 White chooses 3.Nf3

Use the time White gives you to develop.

SC-19 White attacks the queen with 3.c4

A pawn tempo also changes the pawn structure.

SC-20 White uses 2.d3

Queenless king safety is a different calculation.

Repertoire map / 4

OPTIONAL QUEEN AND KNIGHT RECAPTURES

Start with SC-21. Then add the remaining branches one at a time. The IDs connect this map, the theory booklet and the PGN files.

SC-21 Optional ...Qd8 repertoire

A safe queen still leaves a development debt.

SC-22 Optional ...Qd6 repertoire

The queen's square determines which knight jumps matter.

SC-23 Optional 2...Nf6: recover with a knight

Different recapture, different development plan.

SC-24 Against 3.c4 after ...Nf6

Choose a gambit knowingly, with a follow-up.

SC-25 Portuguese-style development

Provoking a weakness is useful only if you can use it.

SC-26 Warning: the queen blunder

A check does not suspend the opponent's legal captures.

The ...Qa5 core repertoire

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-01 - Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo.

RECOGNITION TEST

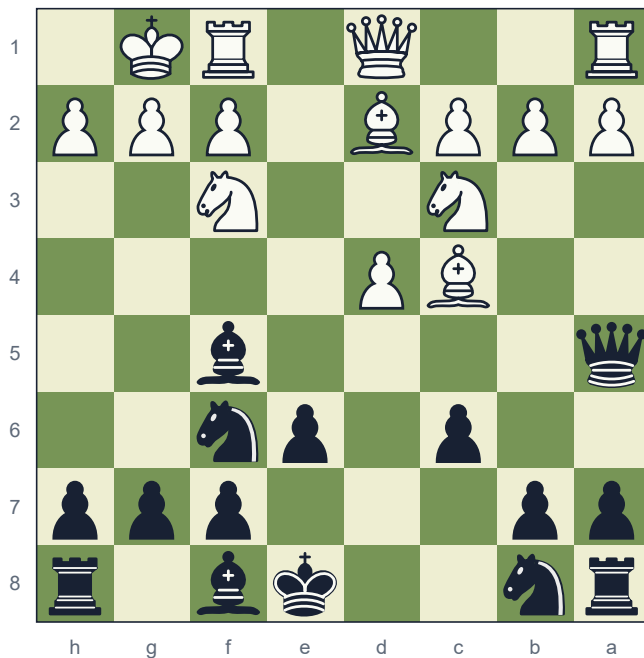
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-01 / The classical development route

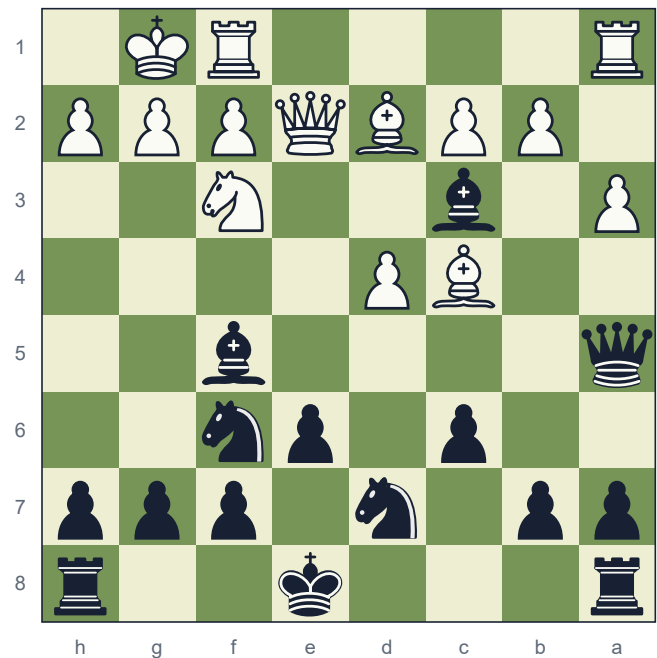
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Bd2 e6 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bb4 10. a3 Bxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo.

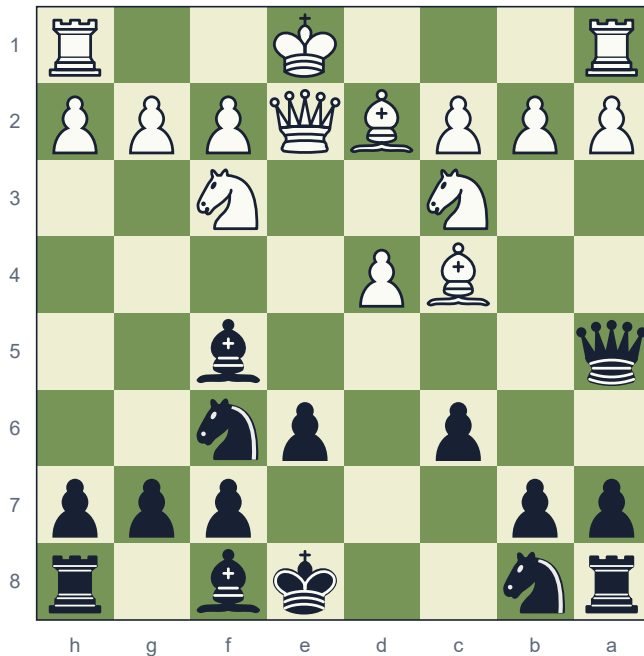
REMEMBER Develop the bishop before locking it in.

SC-02 / White uses Qe2 and long castling

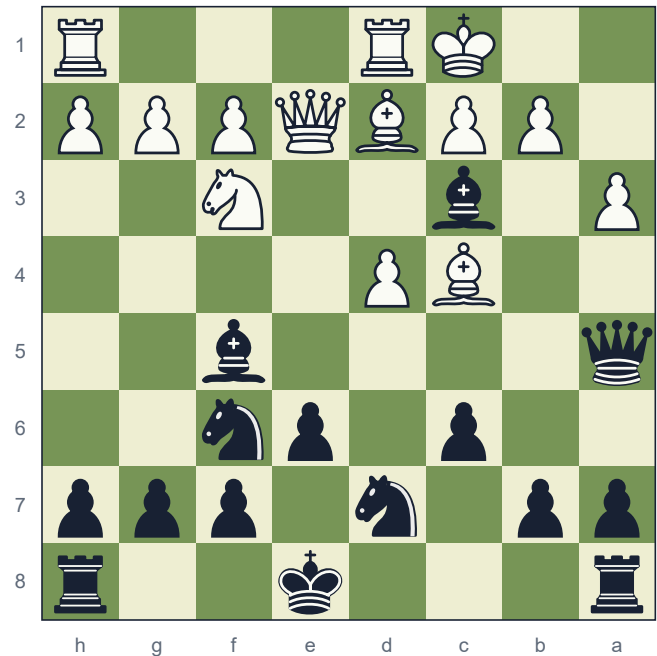
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Bd2 e6 8. Qe2 Bb4 9. a3 Nbd7 10. O-O-O Bxc3

Authored anchor ends after 8... Bb4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Qe2 prepares long castling and increases central pressure. ...Bb4 develops with a concrete relation to the c3 knight rather than immediately making another pawn move.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development and decide whether the queen should retreat before castling. If kings go to opposite wings, count attack tempi rather than following a fixed pawn storm.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can play O-O-O and advance the kingside pawns. Opening the center while your own king remains on e8 can be dangerous.

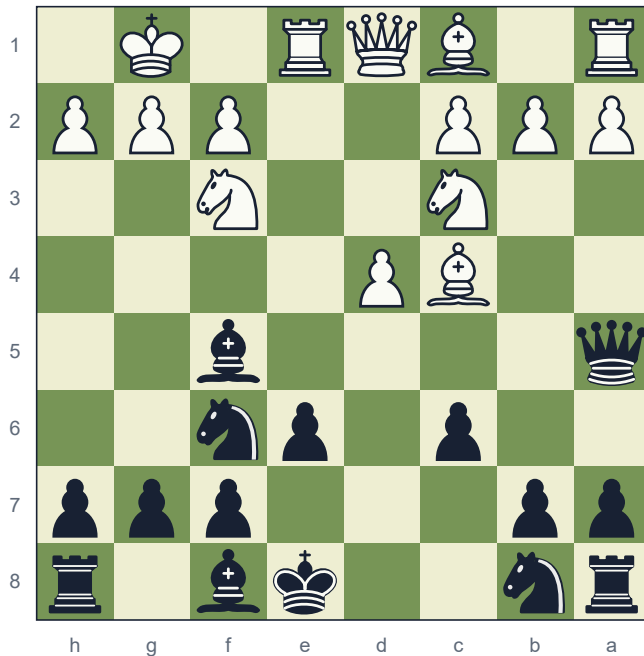
REMEMBER The king choice changes the race.

SC-03 / White castles short early

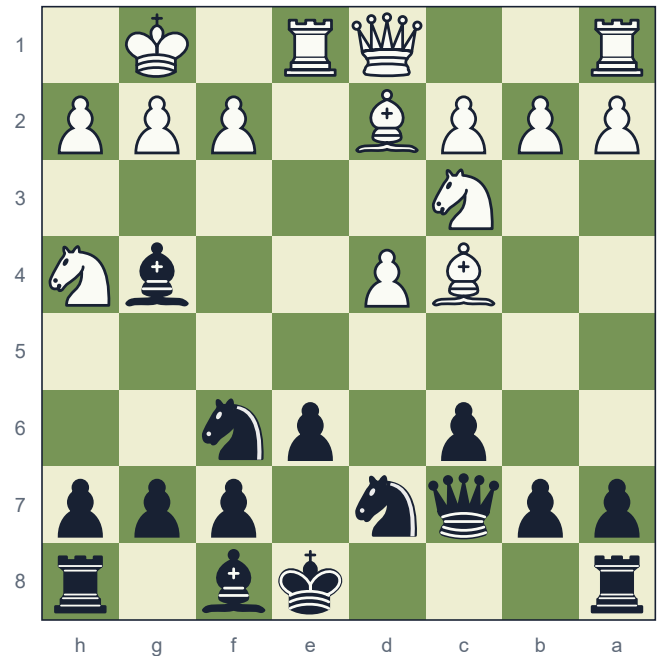
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. O-O e6 8. Re1 Nbd7 9. Bd2 Qc7 10. Nh4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 8... Nbd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Re1 creates pressure on the e-file while Black is still developing. The black king and queen bishop must be coordinated before the center opens.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Be7 or ...Bb4 when safe, then castle. Check whether e6 is pinned or overworked before recapturing in the center.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

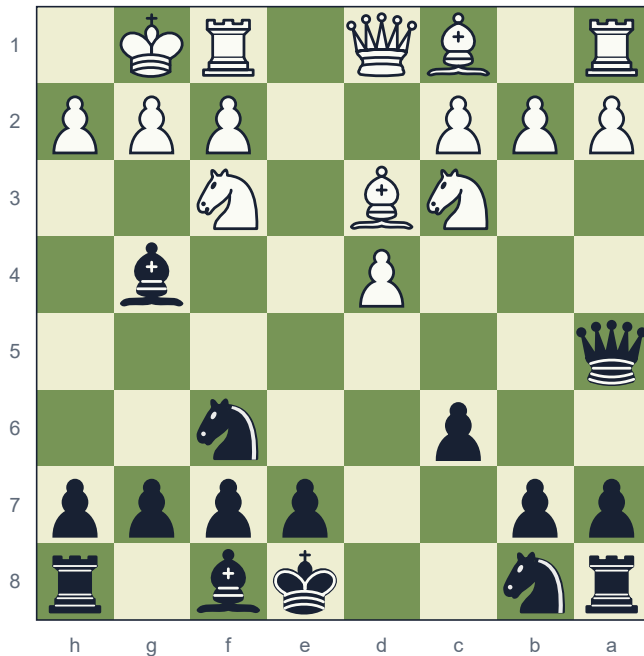
REMEMBER An open e-file is a development deadline.

SC-04 / White puts the bishop on d3

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bd3 Bg4 7. O-O e6 8. h3 Bh5 9. Bf4 Qd8 10. Re1 Bd6

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bd3 aims at h7 and supports central control. ...Bg4 develops actively against Nf3, reducing one possible supporter of e5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nbd7 and the king bishop, then choose king safety. If ...Bxf3 is considered, compare White's recapture and the resulting bishop pair.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Bxh7+ motifs depend on the king position and supporting pieces. Do not create a hook with ...h6 or ...g6 without checking the attacking consequences.

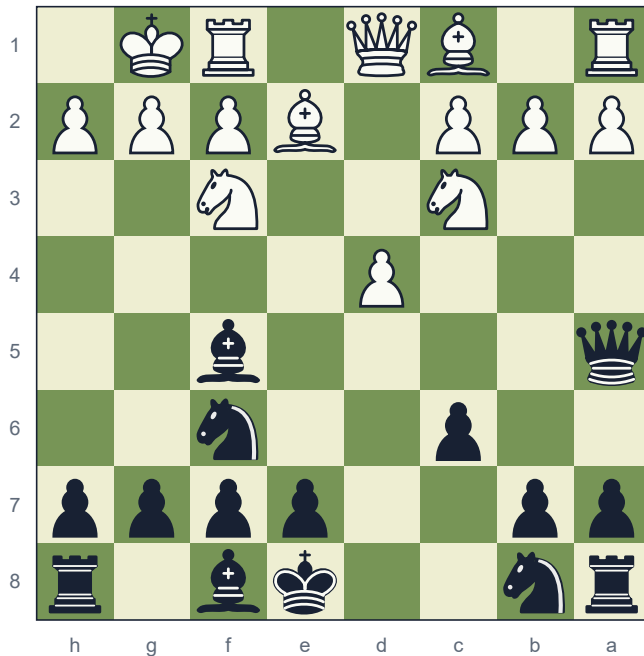
REMEMBER Respect the bishop diagonal before weakening king cover.

SC-05 / White develops quietly with Be2

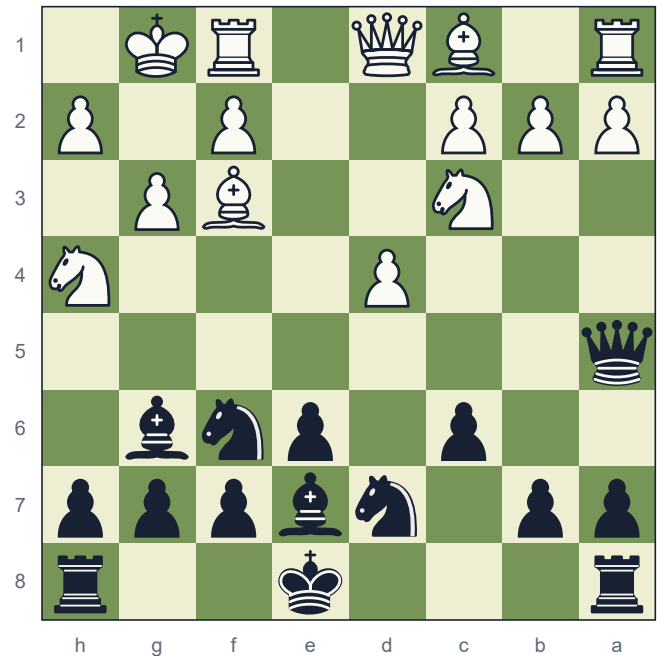
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Be2 Bf5 7. O-O e6 8. Nh4 Bg6 9. g3 Be7 10. Bf3 Nbd7

Authored anchor ends after 7... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White chooses modest development instead of immediate bishop pressure on f7. Black can complete a sound formation while retaining central counterplay.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nbd7 and ...Be7, castle, then seek a justified pawn break. Exchanging one pair of pieces often helps the side with less space.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Quiet development may prepare Ne5 or Nh4. Do not drift into several queen moves just because there is no immediate attack.

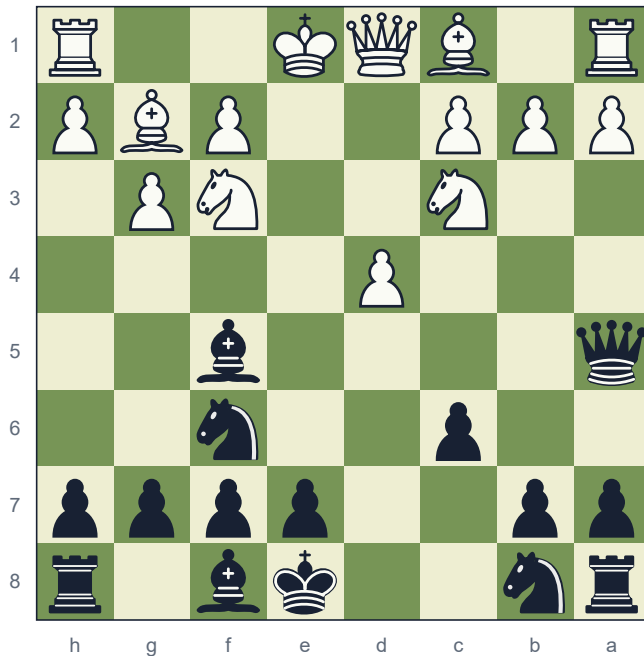
REMEMBER Use the quiet phase to finish development.

SC-06 / White fianchettoes

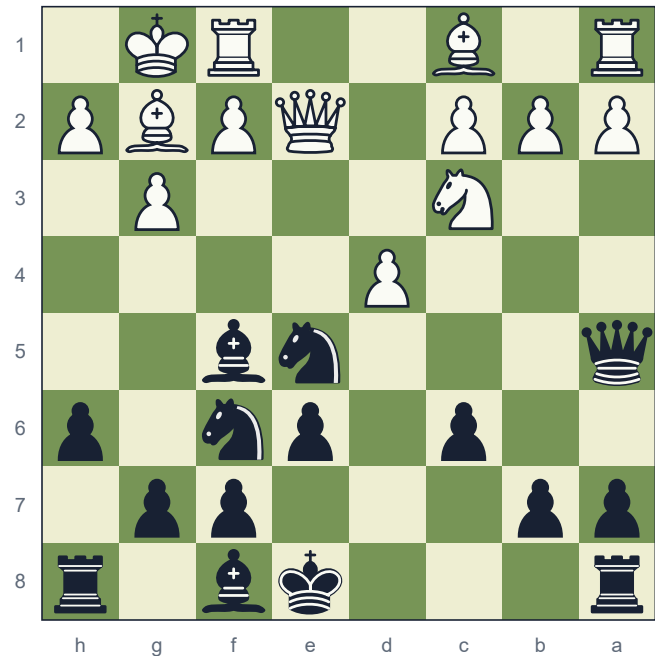
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. g3 Bf5 7. Bg2 e6 8. O-O h6 9. Ne5 Nbd7 10. Qe2 Nxe5

Authored anchor ends after 8. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The g2 bishop puts long-term pressure on the center and queenside. Black should develop while monitoring when the diagonal becomes open.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Place the king bishop and knight, castle safely and contest d5. ...h6 can preserve Bf5 only if its time cost and king-safety effects are acceptable.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can exchange central pawns and expose b7. A queen on a5 does not defend every queenside target.

REMEMBER Long diagonals become dangerous when the center clears.

Work through SC-01

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... NBD7

Develops the queen knight while keeping the c-pawn free and adding influence over e5 and c5.

9... BB4

Places the bishop on b4, attacking knight on c3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... BXC3

The bishop captures a knight on c3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5. Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Active White systems and queen safety

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-07 - ...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White may play g4 against Bf5. The bishop needs a safe square and the queen may become a second tactical target.

RECOGNITION TEST

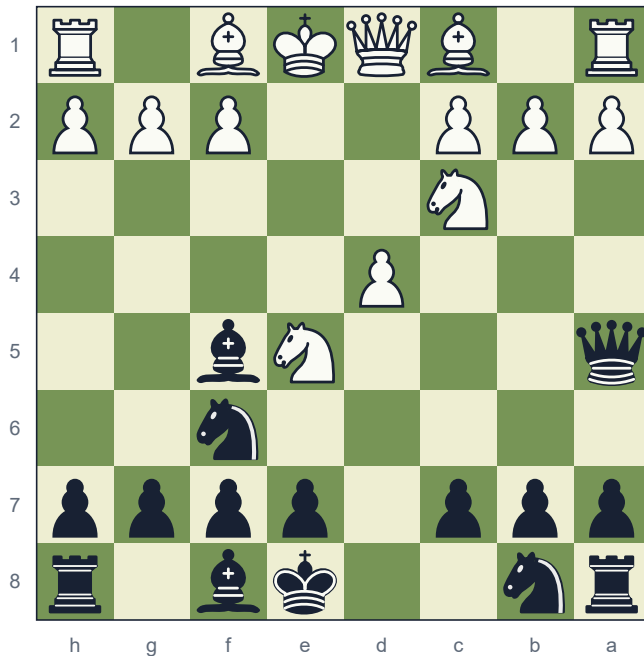
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-07 / White attacks Bf5 with Ne5

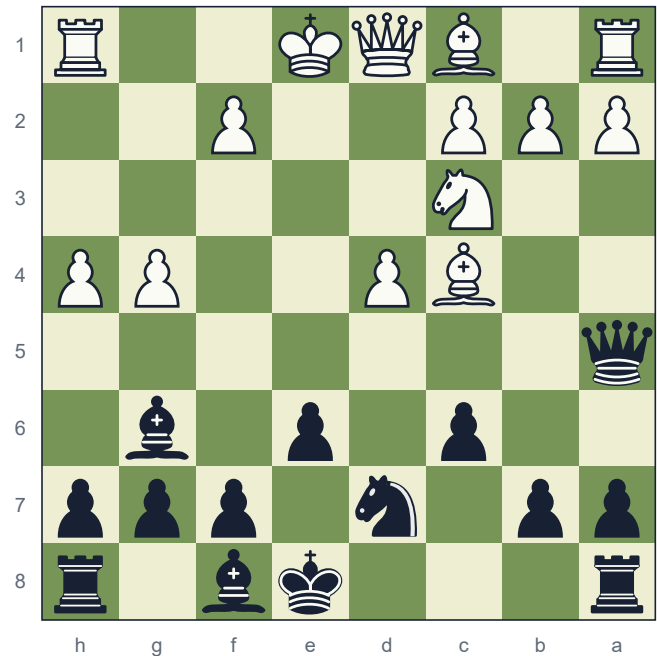
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 Bf5 6. Ne5 c6 7. Bc4 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Nxd7 Nxd7

Authored anchor ends after 6... c6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may play g4 against Bf5. The bishop needs a safe square and the queen may become a second tactical target.

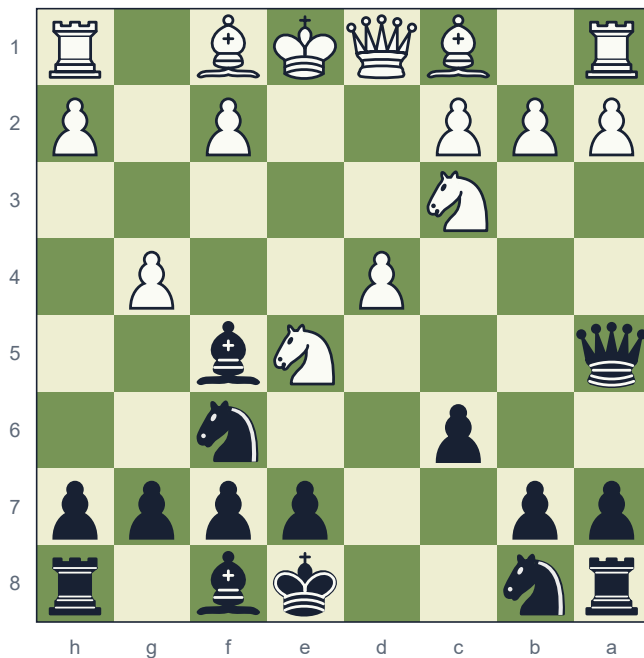
REMEMBER Two attacked pieces can turn a pawn push into a tactic.

SC-08 / White pushes g4 against the bishop

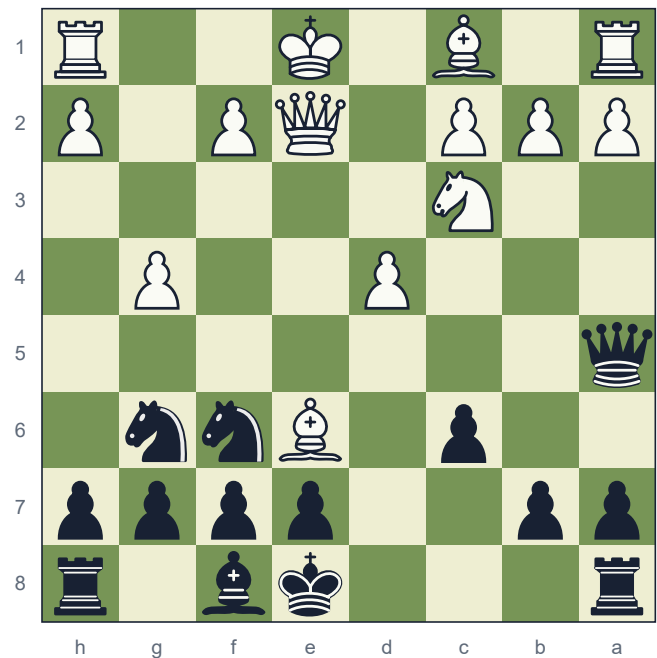
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 Bf5 6. Ne5 c6 7. g4 Be6 8. Bc4 Nbd7 9. Bxe6 Nxe5 10. Qe2 Ng6

Authored anchor ends after 7... Be6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and inspect the center before counterattacking the advanced pawns. Keep the queen safe from discovered attacks as White's knight moves.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

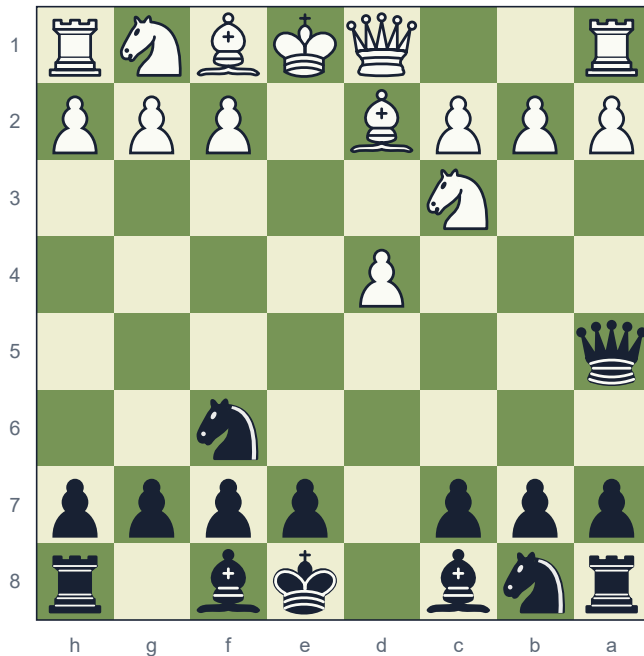
REMEMBER Compare the bishop's whole escape route.

SC-09 / An immediate Bd2 hits the queen

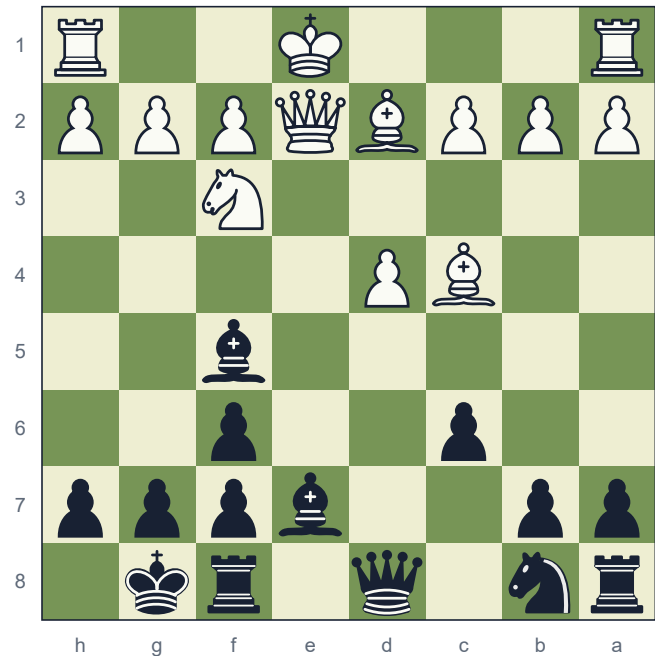
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. Bd2 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Nd5 Qd8 8. Nxf6+ exf6 9. Qe2+ Be7 10. Nf3 O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5... c6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Bd2 creates a potential discovered attack along the d2-a5 diagonal when Nc3 moves. ...c6 supplies a retreat and limits Nb5.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Watch every move of Nc3: it can reveal an attack on the queen. Develop ...Bf5 and ...e6 only after checking the queen's actual safety.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Nd5 or Ne4 can be both a central move and a discovered queen attack. A familiar setup does not exempt you from that calculation.

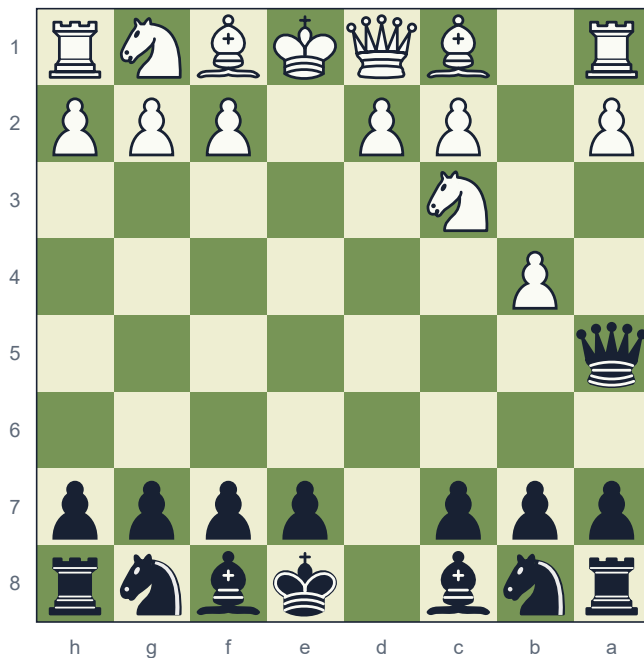
REMEMBER Every c3-knight move may uncover a queen attack.

SC-10 / The b4 pawn offer

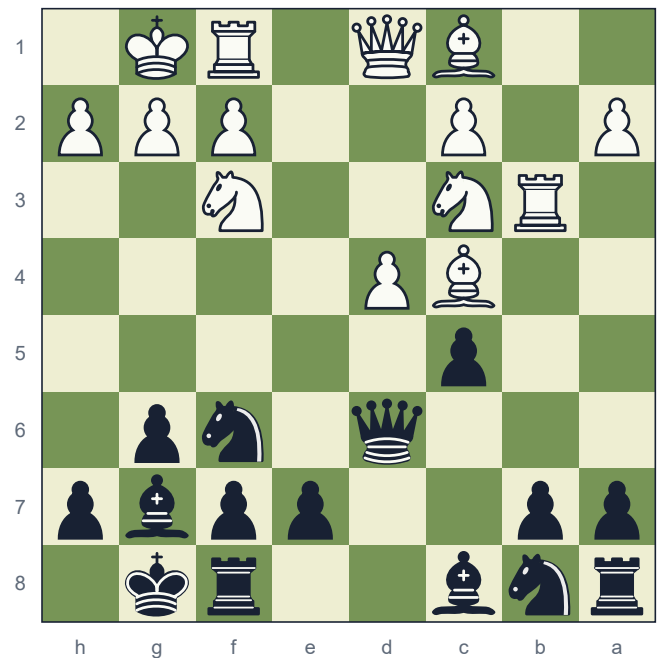
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. b4 Qxb4 5. Rb1 Qd6 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. d4 g6 8. Bc4 Bg7 9. O-O O-O 10. Rb3 c5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Qxb4. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black can accept the offered pawn, but the queen now faces a series of developing attacks. This is a concrete branch that deserves calculation before practical use.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Find safe queen squares and develop quickly. Return the extra pawn if that gets the king safe and prevents the queen being trapped.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Rb1, Nb5 and developing bishops may gain tempi. Counting only the extra pawn ignores the cost of the queen's excursion.

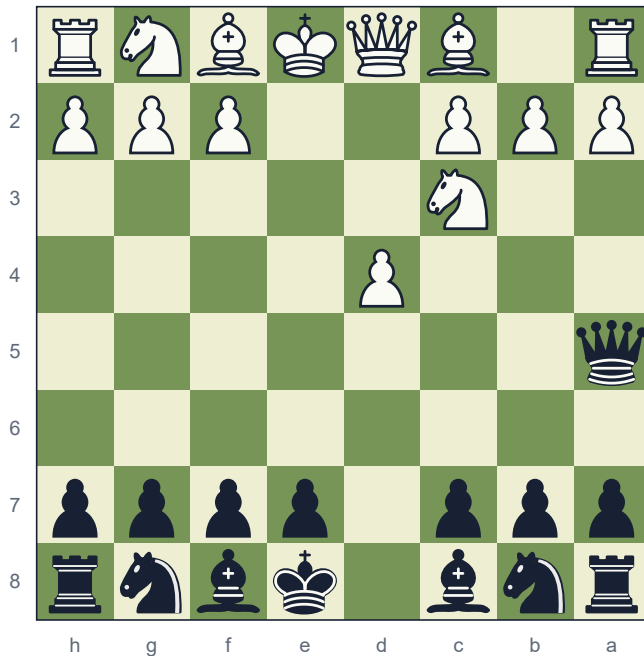
REMEMBER Queen safety can be worth more than retaining a gambit pawn.

SC-11 / White advances d5 early

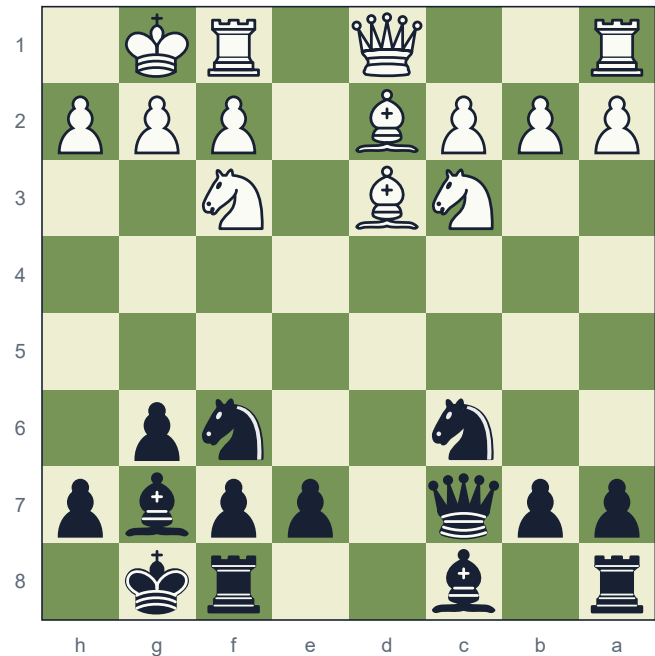
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. d4 Nf6 5. d5 c6 6. Bd2 Qc7 7. dxc6 Nxc6 8. Nf3 g6 9. Bd3 Bg7 10. O-O O-O

Authored anchor ends after 5. d5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The advanced d-pawn gains space and restricts Black's queen knight. Black must challenge the wedge or develop around it.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Examine ...c6 and the resulting dxc6 recapture. Seek active development with a clear route for the queen and the f8 bishop.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can support the pawn and gain further space. A slow sequence of waiting moves may leave Black permanently cramped.

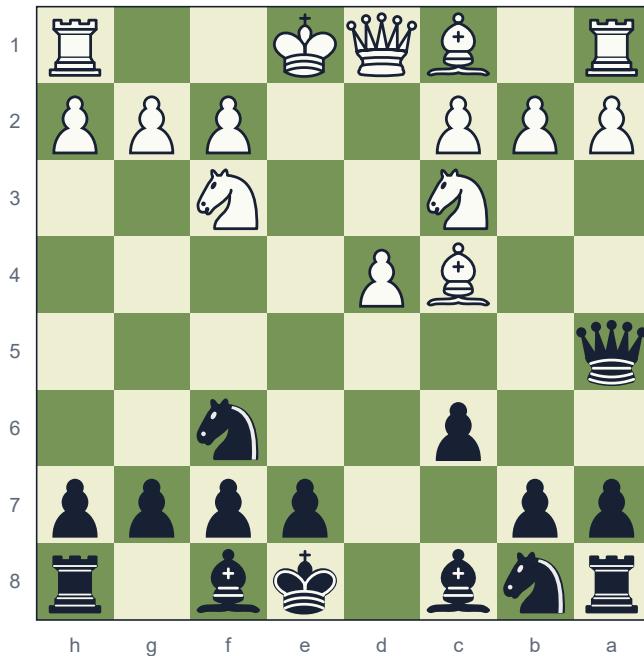
REMEMBER A wedge must be challenged or blockaded deliberately.

SC-12 / White plays Bc4 before Nf3

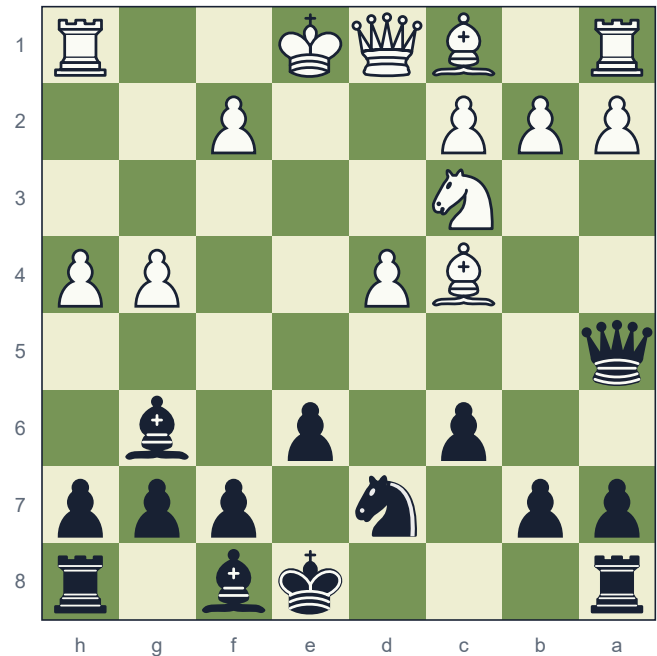
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qa5 4. Bc4 Nf6 5. d4 c6 6. Nf3 Bf5 7. Ne5 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Nxd7 Nxd7

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The early bishop makes f7 pressure visible sooner, but the position can transpose to the main route after Nf3. Black should recognize the transposition without ignoring immediate checks.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7, checking whether a bishop or knight sacrifice on f7 has real support. Castle once the position is ready.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

An early bishop move can combine with a fast queen move. Do not capture an apparently loose central pawn without considering checks.

REMEMBER Compare exact piece positions before calling a transposition.

Work through SC-07

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... BG6

Places the bishop on g6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... NBD7

Places the knight on d7, attacking knight on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... NXD7

The knight captures a knight on d7. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight. Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7 when safe, or exchange the active knight if that improves coordination. Keep the queen away from discovered attacks.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

White avoids the main route

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-13 - White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

RECOGNITION TEST

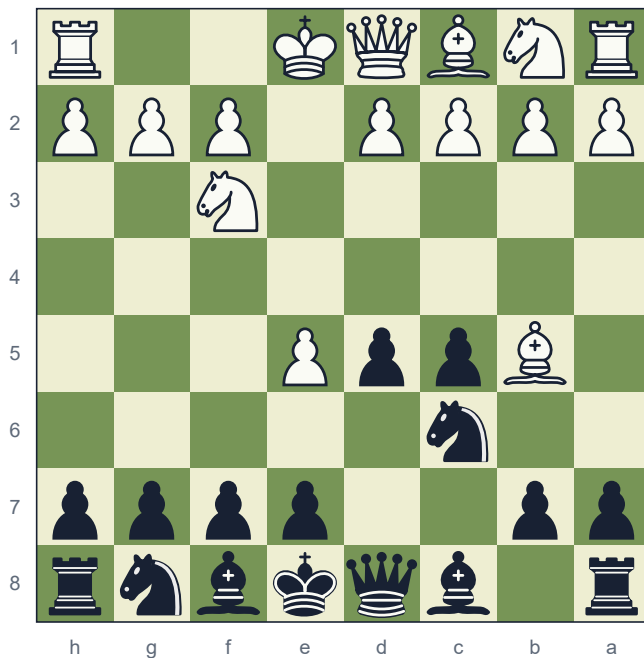
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-13 / White advances with 2.e5

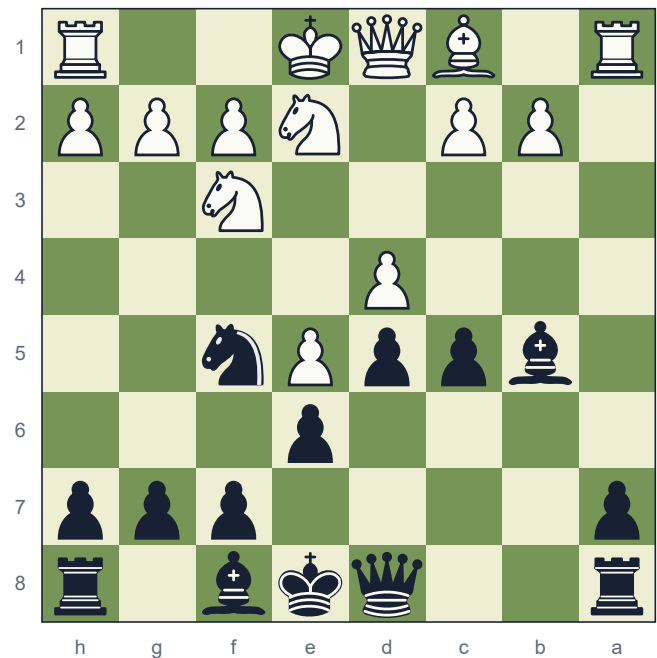
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. e5 c5 3. Nf3 Nc6 4. Bb5 Bd7 5. Bxc6 Bxc6 6. d4 e6 7. Nc3 Ne7 8. Ne2 Nf5 9. a4 b5 10. axb5 Bxb5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bd7. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

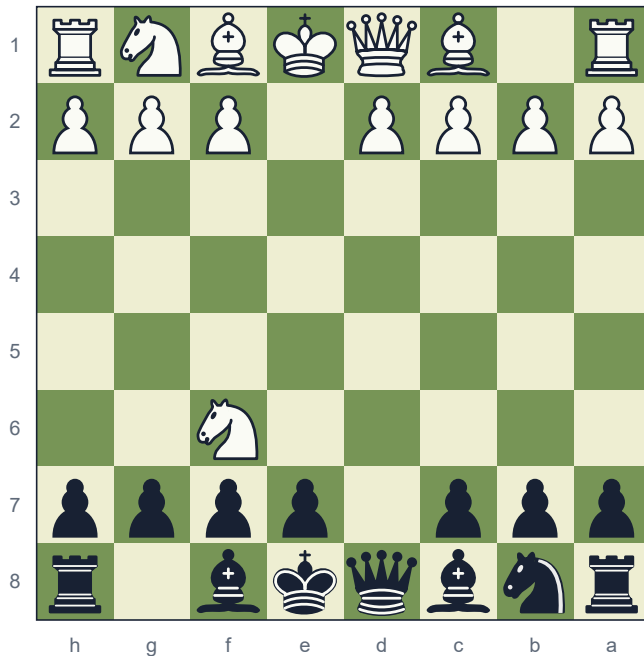
REMEMBER The Scandinavian queen plan belongs to the exchange structure.

SC-14 / White defends with 2.Nc3

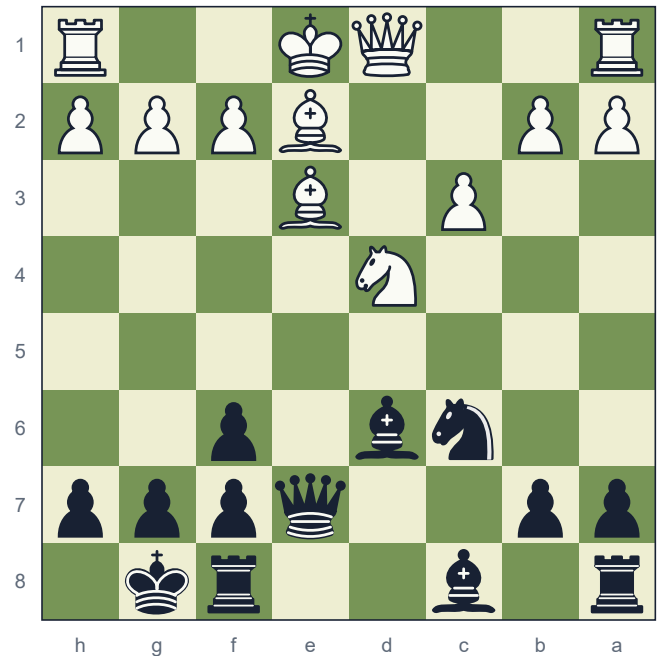
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. Nc3 dxe4 3. Nxe4 Nf6 4. Nxf6+ exf6 5. d4 Bd6 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2 c5 8. Be3 cxd4 9. Nxd4 Nc6 10. c3 Qe7

Authored anchor ends after 4... exf6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move - in check



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black exchanges the central pawn and accepts doubled f-pawns in return for development and open lines. The position has its own structure and is not a ...Qa5 line.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops actively, castle safely and consider ...c5. The bishop pair and central access can compensate for imperfect pawn shape.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can target the f-pawns in an endgame. Do not exchange active bishops automatically while keeping only the structural weakness.

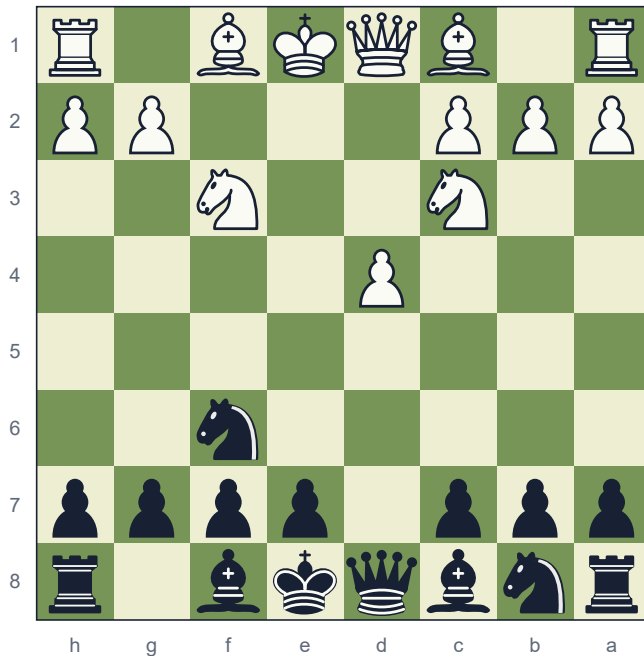
REMEMBER A structural concession needs active pieces in return.

SC-15 / White offers the Blackmar-Diemer

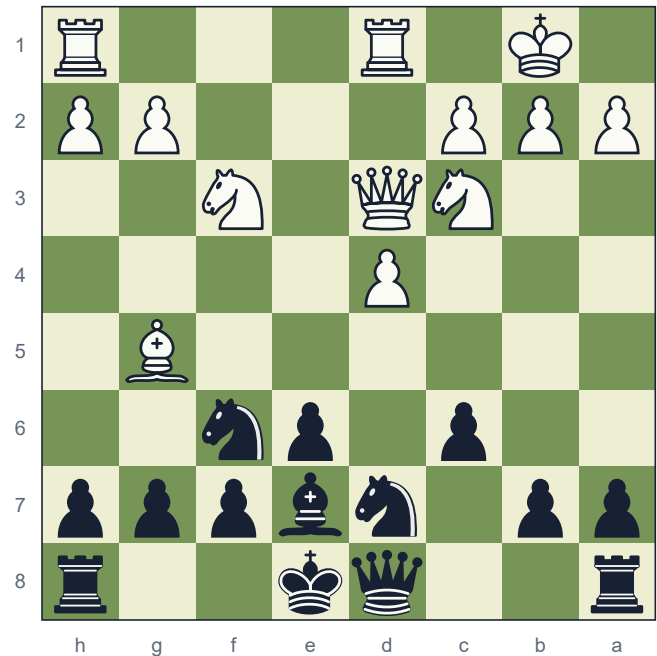
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. d4 dxe4 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. f3 exf3 5. Nxf3 Bf5 6. Bd3 Bxd3 7. Qxd3 c6 8. Bg5 e6 9. O-O-O Nbd7 10. Kb1 Be7

Authored anchor ends after 5... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White offers a pawn for development and open attacking lines. ...Bf5 develops before ...e6 and makes the extra material easier to defend.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Finish development, castle when safe and return the pawn if necessary to neutralize the initiative. Keep f7 and the central files under observation.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger.

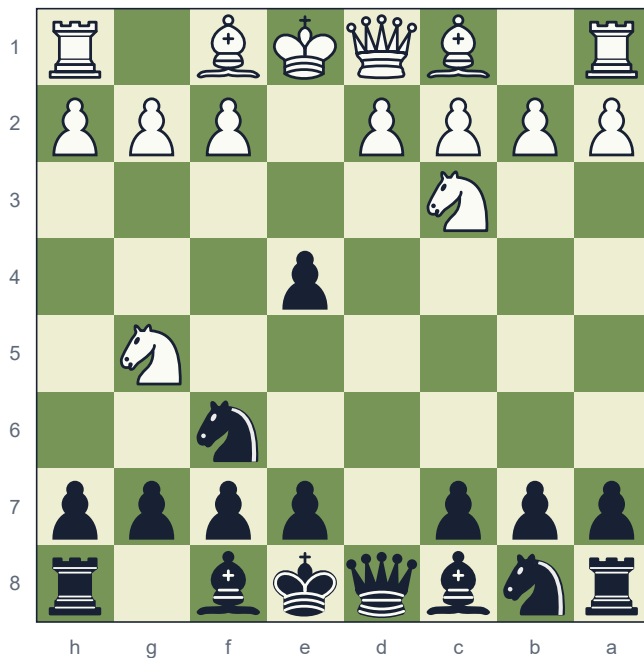
REMEMBER Against a gambit, make the extra pawn easy to live with.

SC-16 / White plays 2.Nf3

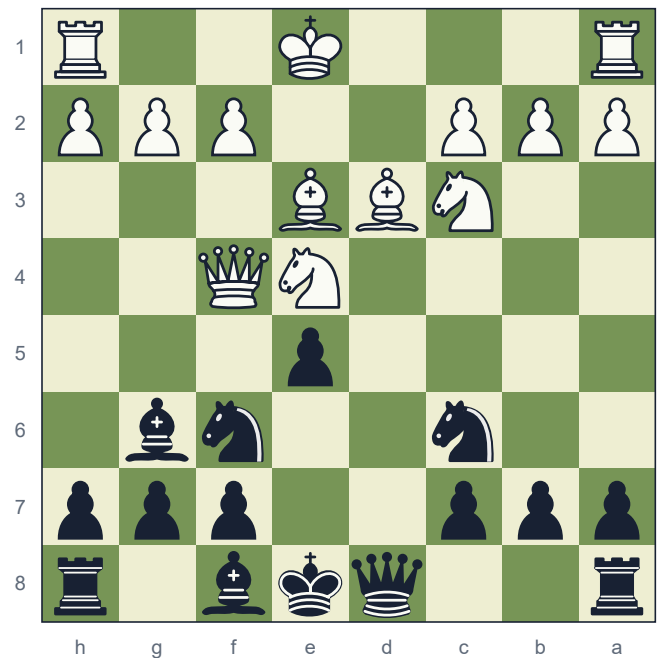
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. Nf3 dxe4 3. Ng5 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. d3 Bg4 6. Qd2 exd3 7. Bxd3 Nc6 8. Qf4 Bh5 9. Nge4 Bg6 10. Be3 e5

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black accepts the central pawn and develops with support for e4. White attacks quickly with knights and hopes to recover material with tempi.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...e6 and the king bishop, checking tactical pressure on f7. If the pawn costs too much time to hold, return it for safe development.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Nxf7 and threats against the queen can appear. The e4 pawn is not a prize worth losing castling or a piece.

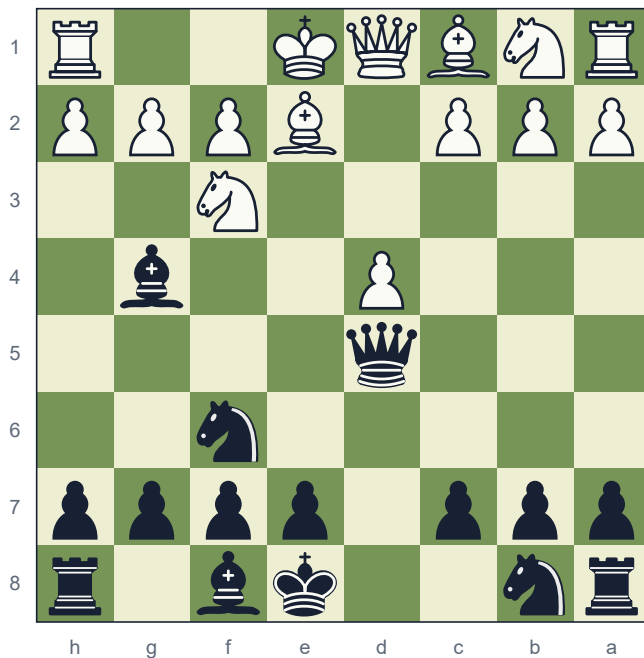
REMEMBER Defend with development when possible.

SC-17 / White recaptures space with 3.d4

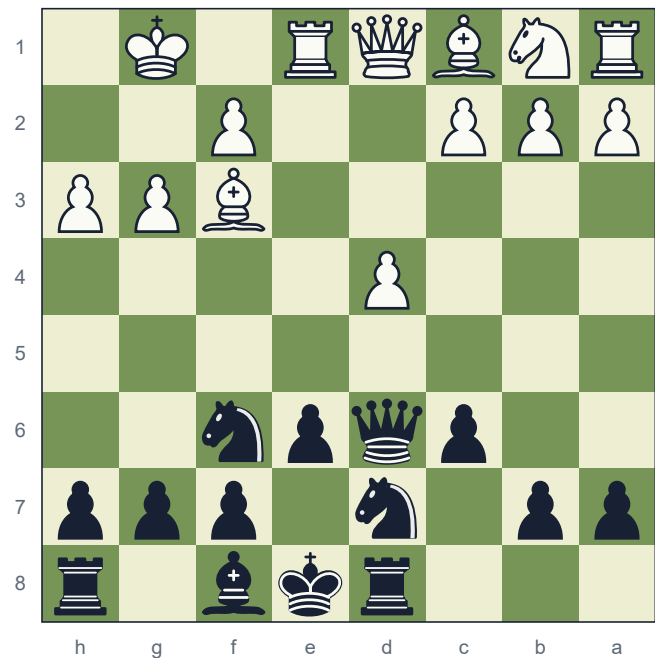
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. d4 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bg4 5. Be2 e6 6. h3 Bxf3 7. Bxf3 Qd6 8. O-O c6 9. g3 Nbd7 10. Re1 Rd8

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White does not attack the queen immediately. Black develops the knight and bishop, keeping the queen flexible rather than committing to a retreat without a threat.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop ...Nc6 or ...Nbd7 according to the center and castle safely. Notice if Nc3 later gains a tempo with a discovered threat.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can play c4 to chase the queen while supporting d4. Keep safe retreat squares before making a pawn commitment.

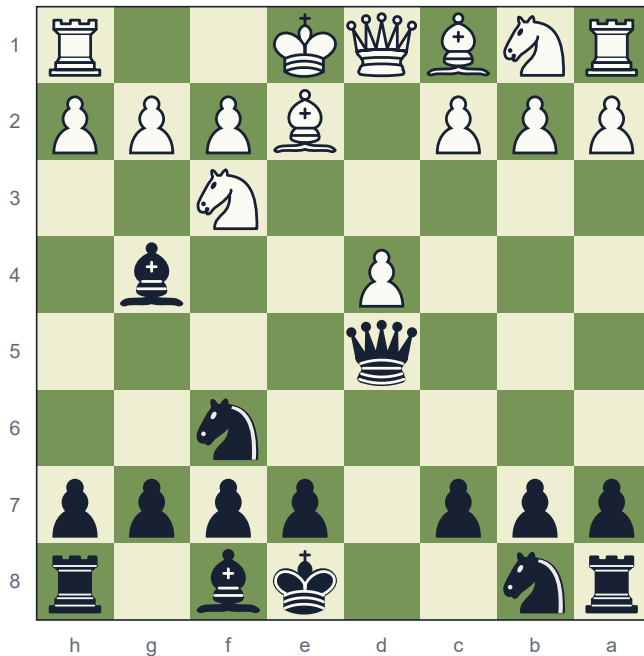
REMEMBER A queen needs an escape route even before it is attacked.

SC-18 / White chooses 3.Nf3

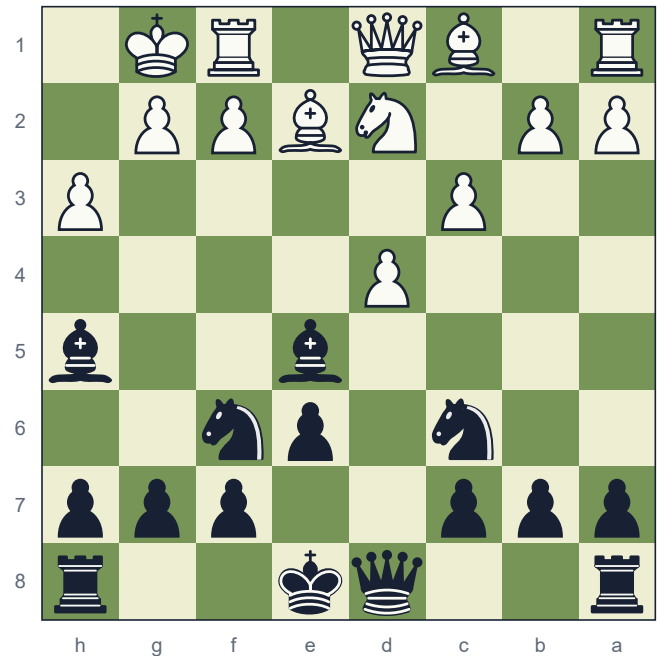
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. d4 Bg4 5. Be2 e6 6. O-O Nc6 7. c3 Qd8 8. h3 Bh5 9. Nbd2 Bd6 10. Ne5 Bxe5

Authored anchor ends after 6. O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

White postpones Nc3 and c4 while developing. Black can use the time to bring pieces out, but must not assume the queen can remain central forever.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Complete development and answer a future c4 or Nc3 with a safe queen retreat. Compare the bishop exchange on f3 before surrendering the bishop pair.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

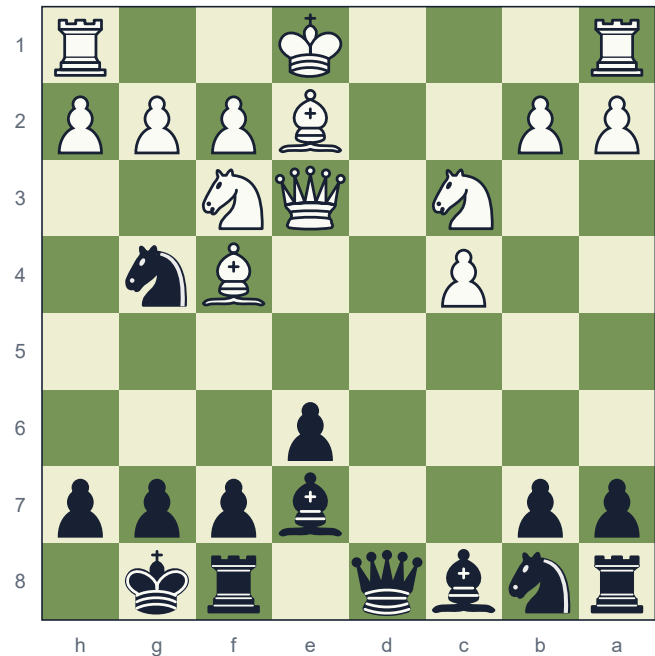
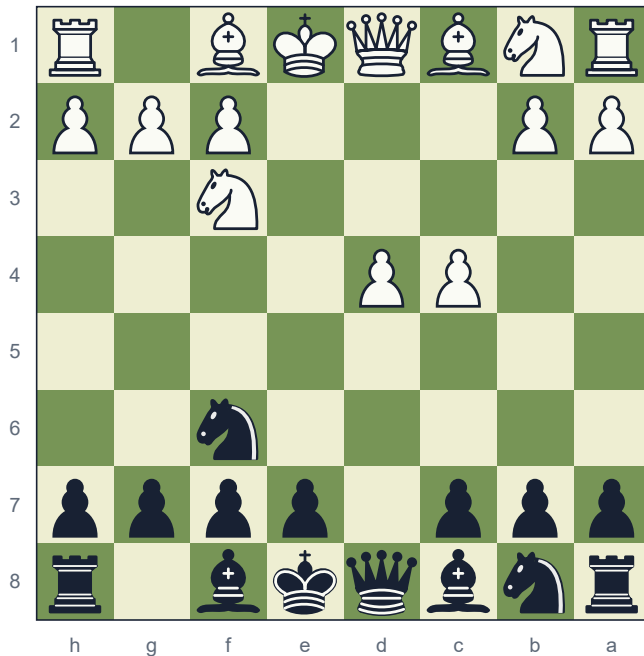
REMEMBER Use the time White gives you to develop.

SC-19 / White attacks the queen with 3.c4

COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. c4 Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 e6 6. Nc3 c5 7. Be2 cxd4 8. Qxd4 Be7 9. Bf4 O-O 10. Qe3 Ng4

Authored anchor ends after 5... e6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The c-pawn move gains a queen tempo but leaves d4 as a possible long-term target. Black retreats safely and develops.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the bishops and seek ...c5 or ...Bb4+ when appropriate. Study an isolated d-pawn structure if central exchanges leave White with one.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position.

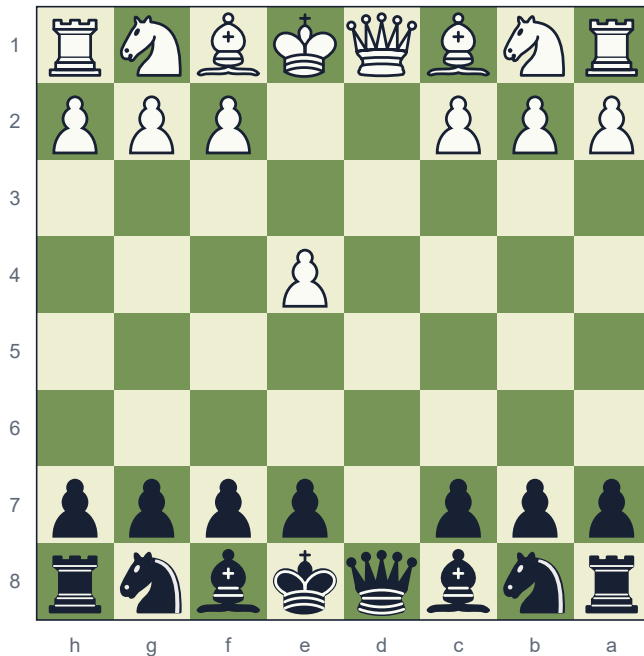
REMEMBER A pawn tempo also changes the pawn structure.

SC-20 / White uses 2.d3

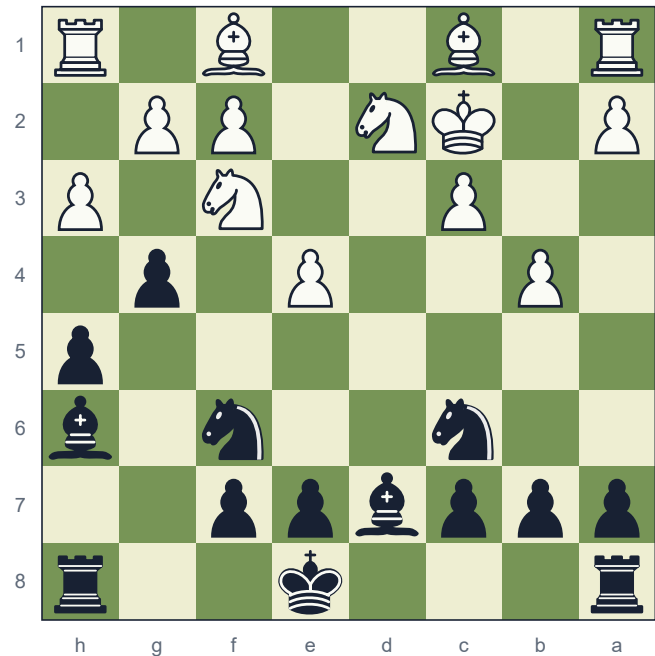
COURSE STUDY LINE

1. e4 d5 2. d3 dxe4 3. dxe4 Qxd1+ 4. Kxd1 Nc6 5. Nd2 Nf6 6. c3 g5 7. Kc2 h5 8. h3 Bh6 9. Ngf3 Bd7 10. b4 g4

Authored anchor ends after 4. Kxd1. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The early exchange permits a queen trade and removes White's castling rights. With queens gone, the centralized white king is less exposed than it would be in a middlegame.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop rapidly and target e4 if it is weak. Use the king-safety lead as a development opportunity rather than expecting a mating attack without queens.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can consolidate with Bd3 and Ke2. Do not overestimate a lost castling right in a simplified position.

REMEMBER Queenless king safety is a different calculation.

Work through SC-13

7... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

8... NF5

Places the knight on f5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... B5

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

10... BXB5

The bishop captures a pawn on b5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure. Develop the king side and decide whether ...e6 or ...Bg4 best fits White's setup. Attack the pawn chain rather than automatically bringing the queen out.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

Optional queen and knight recaptures

HOW TO STUDY THIS FAMILY

First reconstruct the main branch from the initial position. Explain the central structure, each side's king safety and the most urgent threat. Then compare the alternatives one at a time.

MAIN BRANCH

SC-21 - Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position.

A PRACTICAL PLAN

Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

THE OPPONENT GETS A VOTE

White can use Ne5 or d5 while Black is still developing. The queen's safety alone does not solve the space problem.

RECOGNITION TEST

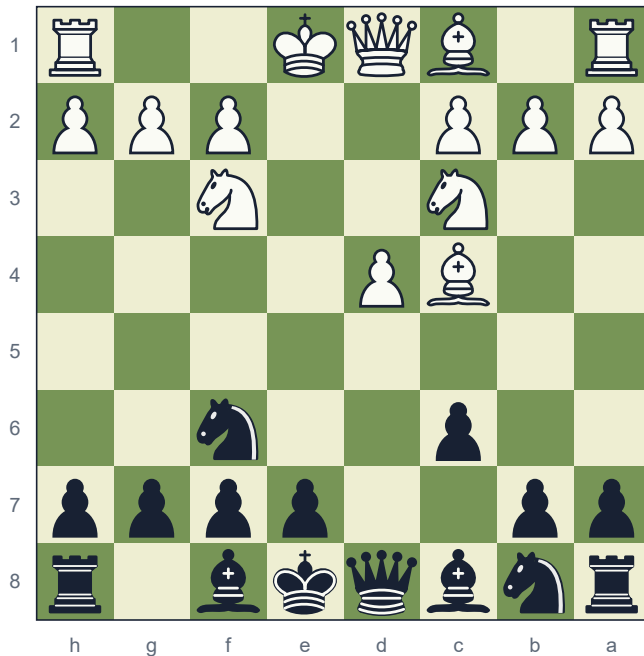
For each alternative, name the move that changes the plan. If you cannot identify that decision, return to the board rather than memorizing the last three moves.

SC-21 / Optional ...Qd8 repertoire

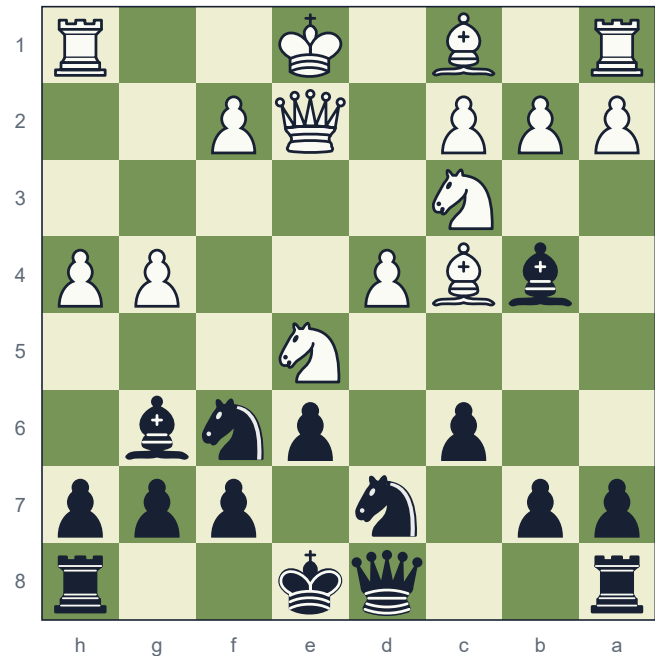
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Ne5 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4 Nbd7 10. Qe2 Bb4

Authored anchor ends after 6... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can use Ne5 or d5 while Black is still developing. The queen's safety alone does not solve the space problem.

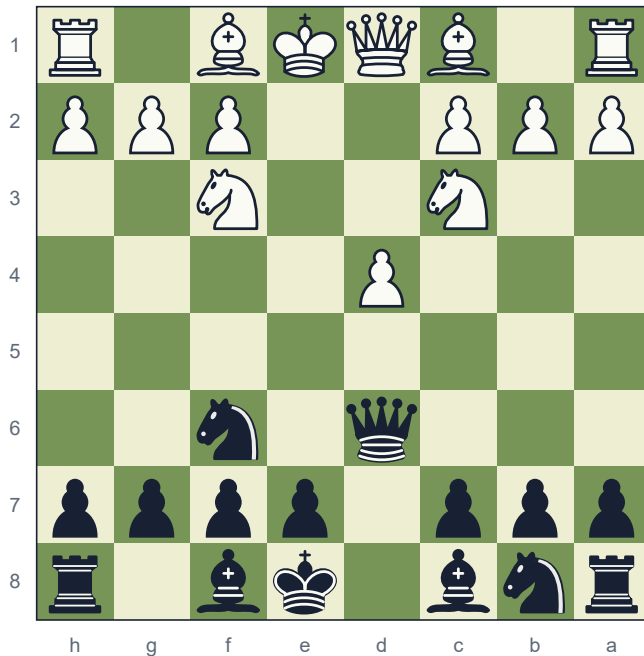
REMEMBER A safe queen still leaves a development debt.

SC-22 / Optional ...Qd6 repertoire

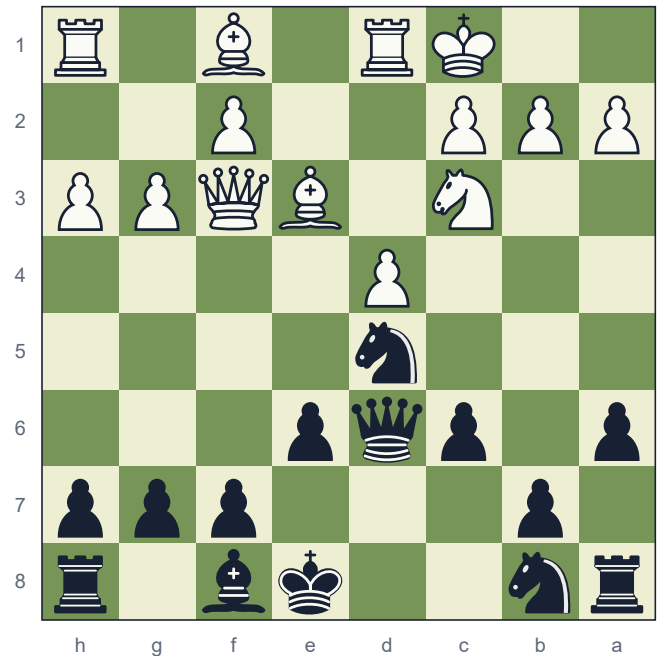
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd6 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 a6 6. g3 Bg4 7. h3 Bxf3 8. Qxf3 c6 9. Be3 e6 10. O-O-O Nd5

Authored anchor ends after 5... a6. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen on d6 supports the center but can be targeted by Ne4, Bf4 or later central moves. ...a6 keeps Nb5 under control.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop with a clear plan for ...b5 or ...Nc6 when appropriate. Decide on the queen bishop before fixing the e-pawn.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

Every pawn tempo delays king safety. White can build pressure quickly if the queen and king both remain exposed.

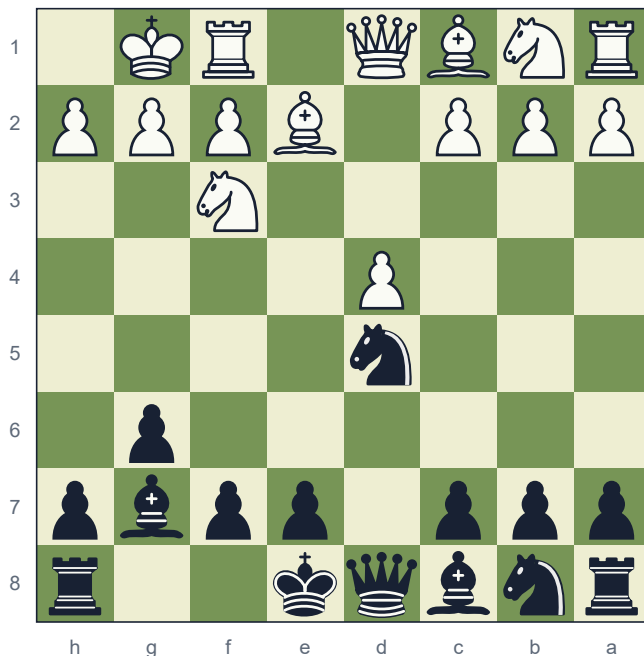
REMEMBER The queen's square determines which knight jumps matter.

SC-23 / Optional 2...Nf6: recover with a knight

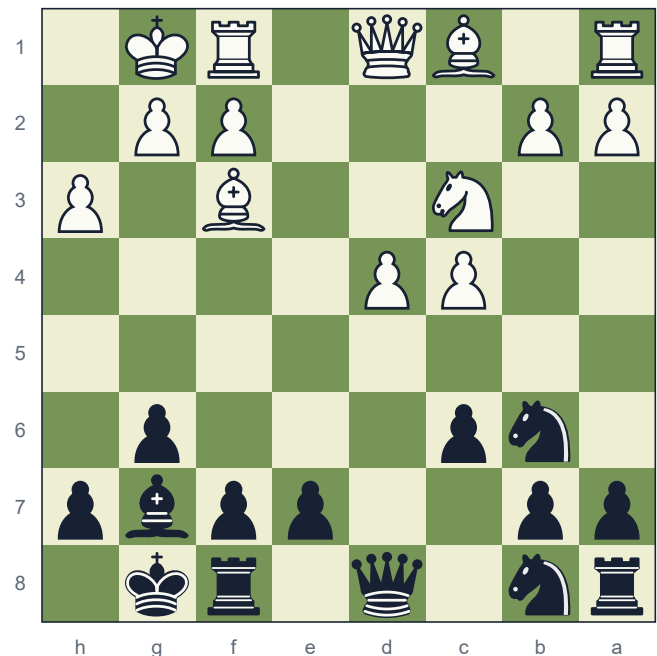
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. d4 Nxd5 4. Nf3 g6 5. Be2 Bg7 6. O-O O-O 7. c4 Nb6 8. Nc3 Bg4 9. h3 Bxf3 10. Bxf3 c6

Authored anchor ends after 6... O-O. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black delays recapturing and then uses the knight. The fianchetto creates a different repertoire from the queen-recapture Scandinavian.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop the queen knight and challenge d4 with ...c5. Keep the d5 knight safe from c4 and central exchanges.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may gain tempi with c4. A knight recapture avoids queen attacks but does not eliminate attacks on the recapturing piece.

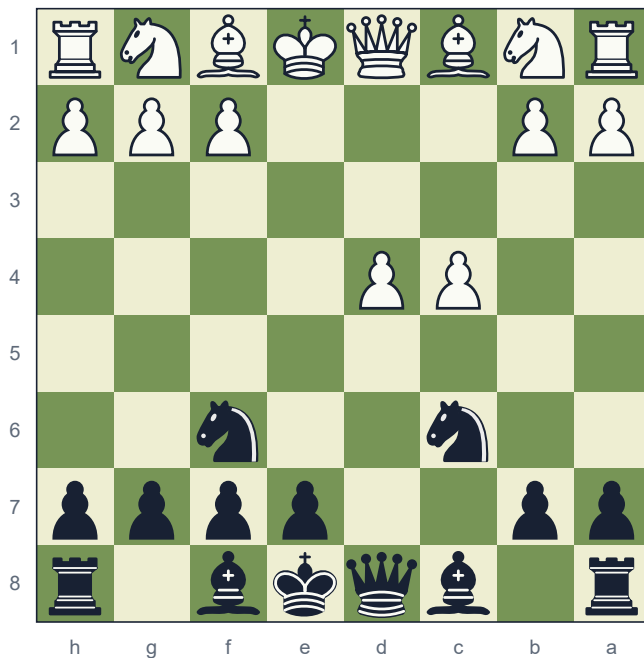
REMEMBER Different recapture, different development plan.

SC-24 / Against 3.c4 after ...Nf6

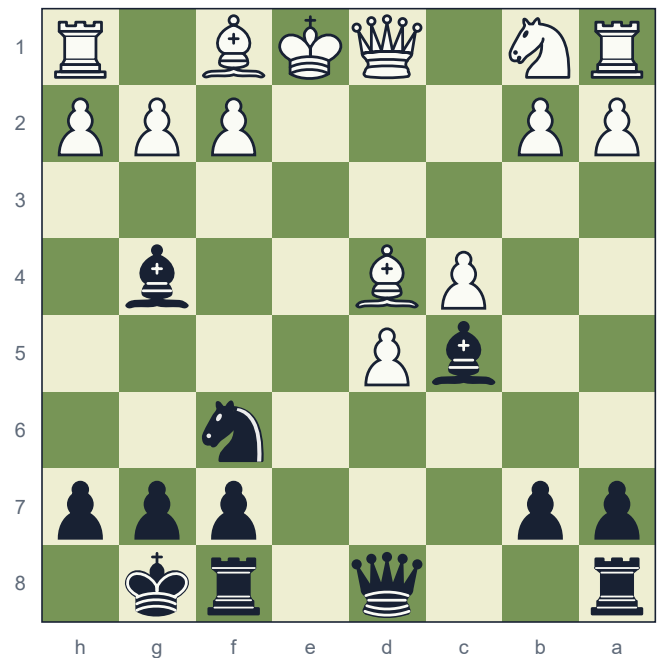
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. c4 c6 4. dxc6 Nxc6 5. d4 e5 6. d5 Bc5 7. Be3 Nd4 8. Nf3 O-O 9. Nxd4 exd4 10. Bxd4 Bg4

Authored anchor ends after 5... e5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black offers a second pawn to gain development and central activity. This is an optional gambit branch requiring exact calculation, not part of the main ...Qa5 course repertoire.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Develop actively and look for central pressure rather than trying to regain the pawn with slow moves. Compare this risk with the direct queen-recapture repertoire.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White can consolidate extra material. A gambit is not justified by development alone if no concrete pressure follows.

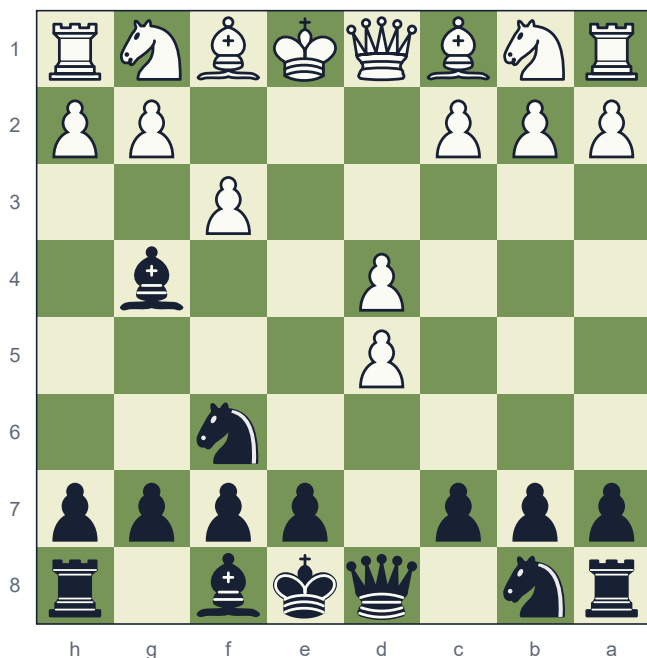
REMEMBER Choose a gambit knowingly, with a follow-up.

SC-25 / Portuguese-style development

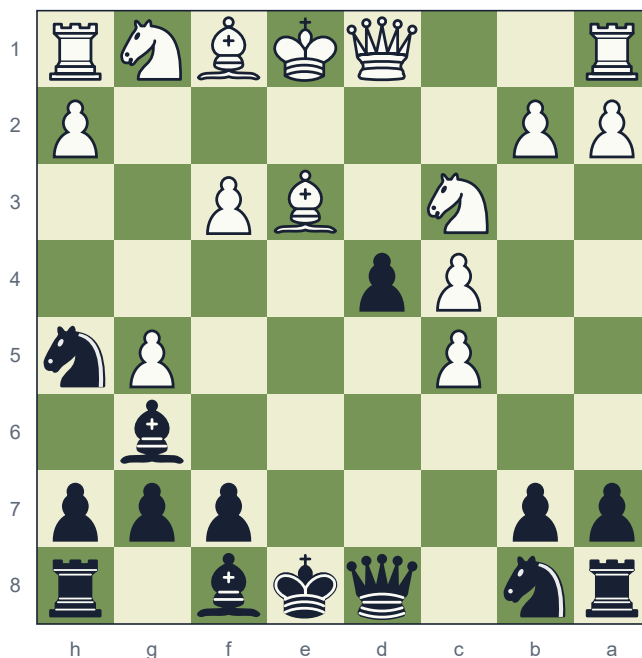
OPTIONAL BRANCH

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Nf6 3. d4 Bg4 4. f3 Bf5 5. g4 Bg6 6. c4 e6 7. Nc3 c5 8. Be3 exd5 9. g5 Nh5 10. dxc5 d4

Authored anchor ends after 4... Bf5. Later moves are one engine-assisted illustration.



Before your decision - Black to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THIS BRANCH

Black delays recapturing again to develop the bishop and provoke f3. White gains a center but has weakened dark squares.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Calculate central blows and develop rapidly. The bishop retreat must preserve activity while the d5 pawn remains unresolved.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

White may hold the pawn and build a powerful center. Treat this as advanced optional material after mastering the main repertoire.

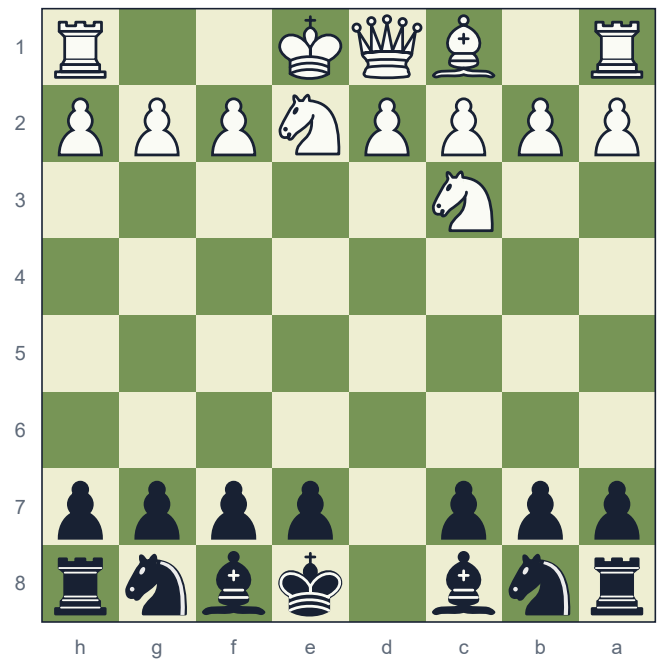
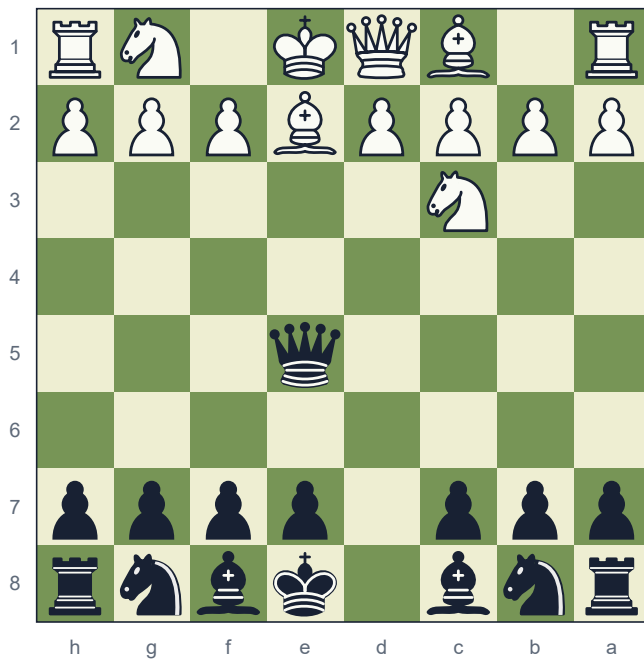
REMEMBER Provoking a weakness is useful only if you can use it.

SC-26 / Warning: the queen blunder

WARNING LINE - study the mistake

1. e4 d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qe5+ 4. Be2 Qxe2+ 5. Ngxe2

The anchor is the complete printed sequence.



WHY THIS BRANCH

The queen's check does not make a capture on e2 safe. White's g1 knight can recapture, and Black has lost the queen for a bishop.

PLAN FROM THIS BRANCH

Reconstruct the legal knight move and explain why a check was not a shield. In real games, retreat the queen rather than continuing an unsound raid.

OPPONENT RESOURCE

A forcing-looking sequence can still end with the attacking queen trapped or exchanged at a huge loss.

REMEMBER A check does not suspend the opponent's legal captures.

Work through SC-21

7... E6

Supports a restrained central formation and opens one bishop diagonal while possibly blocking another. Plan the later pawn break.

8... BG6

Places the bishop on g6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

9... NBD7

Places the knight on d7, attacking knight on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

10... BB4

Places the bishop on b4, attacking knight on c3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

EXPLAIN THE POSITION

Returning the queen avoids repeated queen attacks but concedes a clear developing tempo. This is an optional alternative, not a move to mix into an existing ...Qa5 position. Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

PRACTICE TASK

Replay this branch without looking. Stop at the first move you cannot explain. Then play the endpoint for ten moves against a partner or engine, switching sides for a second game. Judge your decisions, not just the result.

The queen-tempo budget



SC-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The early queen recapture costs time when White develops with an attack. Black accepts that cost for a clear central structure, but cannot afford unrelated queen excursions.

HOW TO DECIDE

Before every queen move, list White's next attacks from pawns, knights and bishops. Choose a square with a safe follow-up route and spend subsequent moves developing.

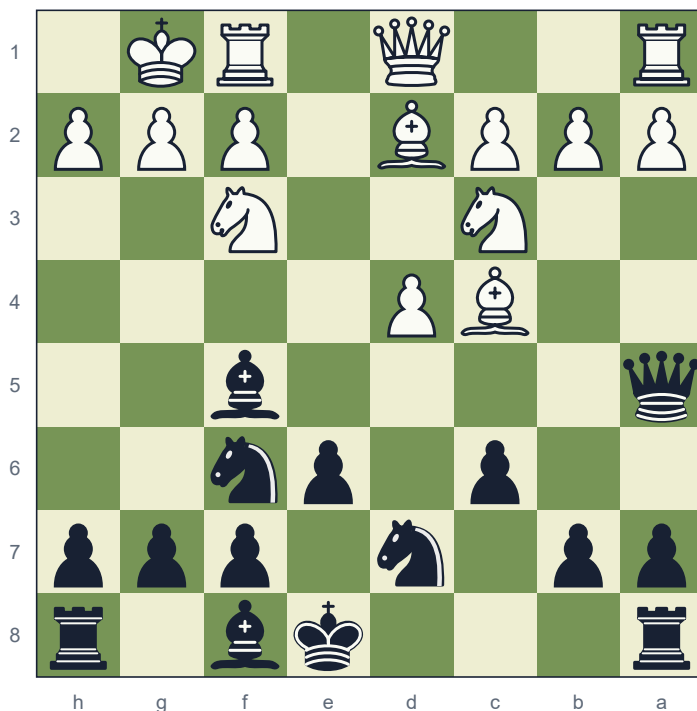
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Nc3, Bd2, c4, Nb5 and discovered attacks can combine. A queen that has a legal square now may have no comfortable square one move later.

BOARD DRILL

At each main-line diagram, name two potential queen attacks and a legal escape route.

Why ...c6 and ...e6 are useful



SC-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

...c6 restrains Nb5 and may open c7 as a queen retreat. ...e6 supports central squares and releases the f8 bishop, but can restrict the c8 bishop if played too early.

HOW TO DECIDE

Develop Bf5 or Bg4 when safe before fixing ...e6. Then connect the rooks and prepare a break rather than letting the pawn triangle become a passive shell.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can use d5, Ne5 or an open e-file to exploit slow development. Pawn stability is not a substitute for active pieces.

BOARD DRILL

Reconstruct the main route and explain the job of each pawn move without saying only that it is theory.

The discovered attack behind Nc3



SC-09 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

With Bd2 and Qa5, the c3 knight can move away and uncover a bishop attack along d2-c3-b4-a5. A knight move may therefore have two separate threats.

HOW TO DECIDE

When Nc3 moves, trace the diagonal immediately. Check whether ...c6 gives a safe queen retreat and whether the knight's new square attacks another piece.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Nd5, Ne4 or Nb5 may gain a decisive tempo. Focusing only on the knight's destination misses the bishop behind it.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the Bd2 branch and name all legal c3-knight moves that reveal the bishop line.

The light-squared bishop decision



SC-04 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Developing the c8 bishop actively is one of Black's main resources. Exchanging it for Nf3 can reduce e5 pressure but gives White the bishop pair.

HOW TO DECIDE

Compare the recapture and resulting pawn structure before ...Bxf3. If preserving the bishop, identify a safe retreat after h3, g4 or Nh4.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can chase the bishop while gaining space. A bishop on g6 may face h4-h5; a bishop on h5 can be restricted by g4.

BOARD DRILL

Play one endpoint with ...Bxf3 and another preserving the bishop. Compare e5 control and king safety.

Central breaks release the position



SC-05 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

Black often has less space, so a well-timed ...c5 or ...e5 is the route to activity. The break must be supported by development and king safety.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate captures, advances and maintaining tension. Identify the file that opens and which rook reaches it first. If an isolated pawn results, assess its activity and weakness.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can open the center before Black castles. A thematic break can be a tactical mistake when the queen or king is exposed.

BOARD DRILL

In a main-line endpoint, prepare one break with a useful piece move and state the best white response.

Opposite-side castling



SC-02 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

If White castles long and Black short, both players may attack with pawns. The winner is often decided by concrete tempi and central counterplay, not by who pushes more pawns.

HOW TO DECIDE

Count how many moves each side needs to open a file near the opposing king. Check whether a central exchange gains a tempo or exposes your own king first.

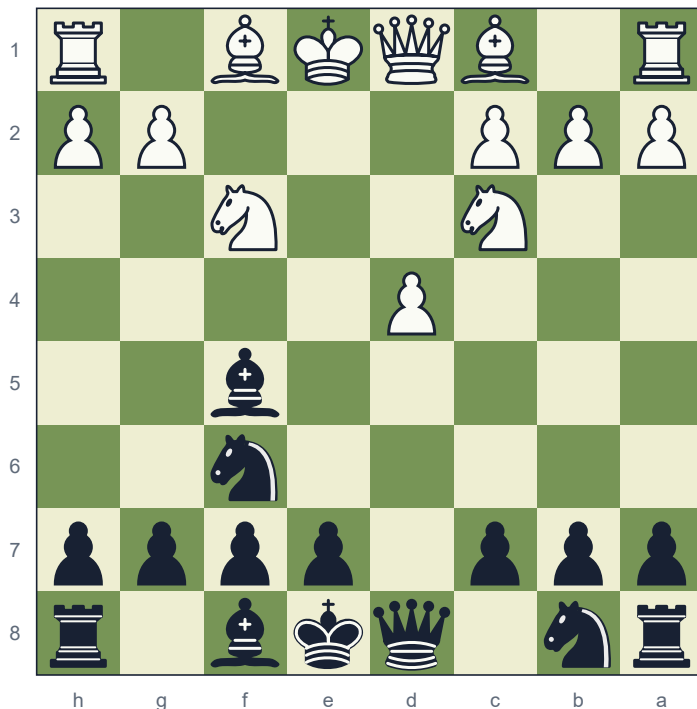
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White's g4-h4 advances can hit Bf5 while preparing an attack. Black's queen must avoid becoming a tactical target in the race.

BOARD DRILL

At a long-castling branch endpoint, write a three-move attacking plan for each side and test the first move for checks and captures.

Defending the Blackmar-Diemer initiative



SC-15 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

An extra pawn can be useful if Black develops and keeps the king safe. Trying to preserve every pawn while White brings all pieces into the attack is a common practical failure.

HOW TO DECIDE

Develop with defense when possible, count pressure on f7 and compare returning material to exchange an attacker. A queen trade can be valuable if it removes the initiative.

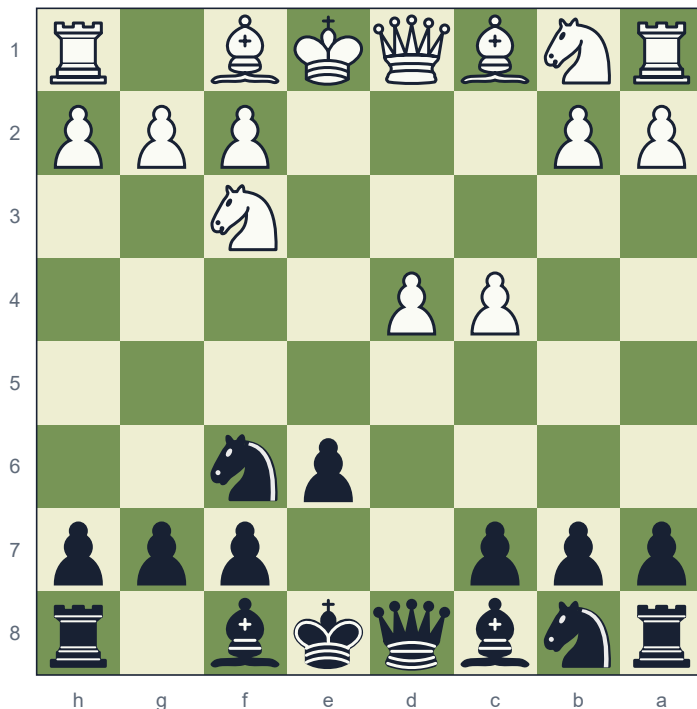
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may use Ne5, Bc4 and Qe2. The strongest threat may be a developing move rather than an immediate capture.

BOARD DRILL

Play the gambit endpoint with the goal of completing development. Do not make a second pawn capture unless you can justify its time cost.

Scandinavian endgame targets



SC-19 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

The opening can lead to a white isolated d-pawn, a black e6-c6 structure or doubled black f-pawns in sidelines. Each structure calls for different exchanges.

HOW TO DECIDE

Against an isolated pawn, blockade and trade active attacking pieces when appropriate. With doubled f-pawns, retain activity and avoid a passive pawn-only ending without checking it.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White's space and bishop pair can outweigh a nominal pawn weakness. A blockade square must be secure and useful.

BOARD DRILL

Identify the actual pawn weakness at an endpoint, then name a piece trade that would help and one that would hurt.

Loose pieces and forks



SC-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



SC-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



SC-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



SC-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

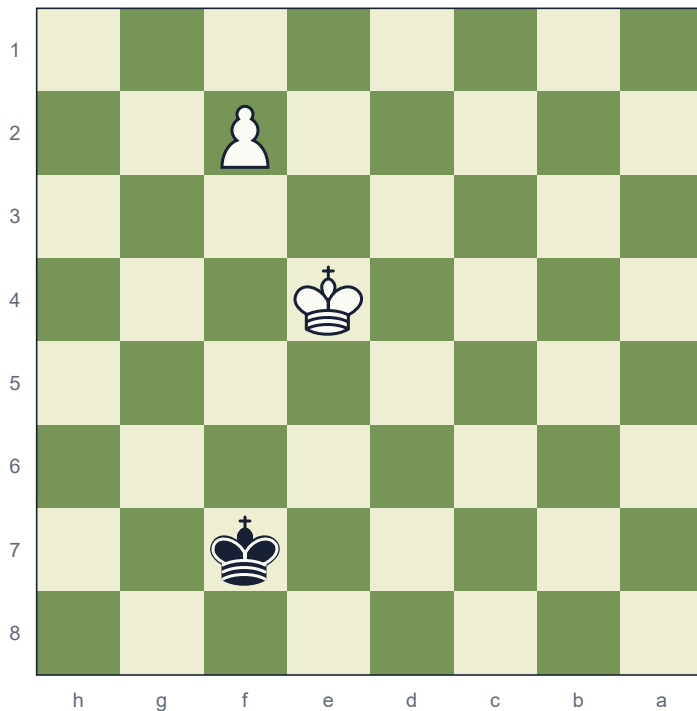
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

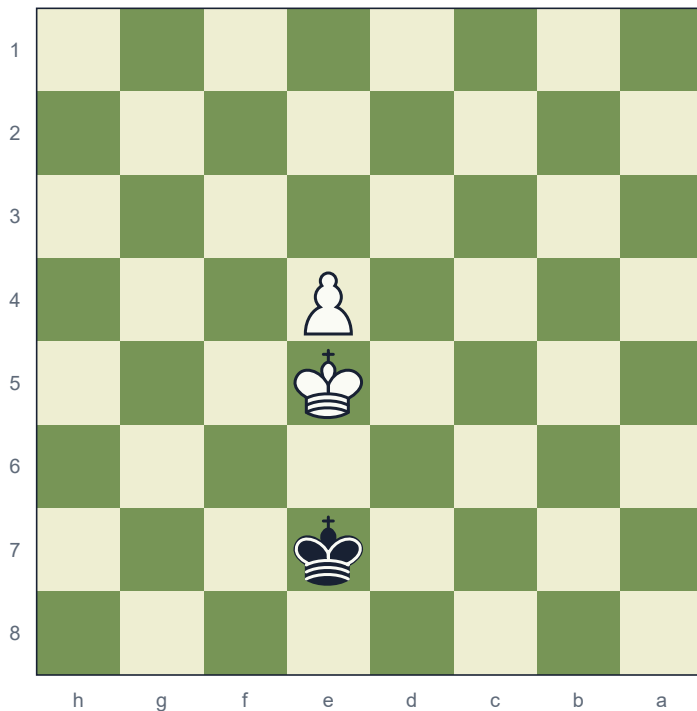
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

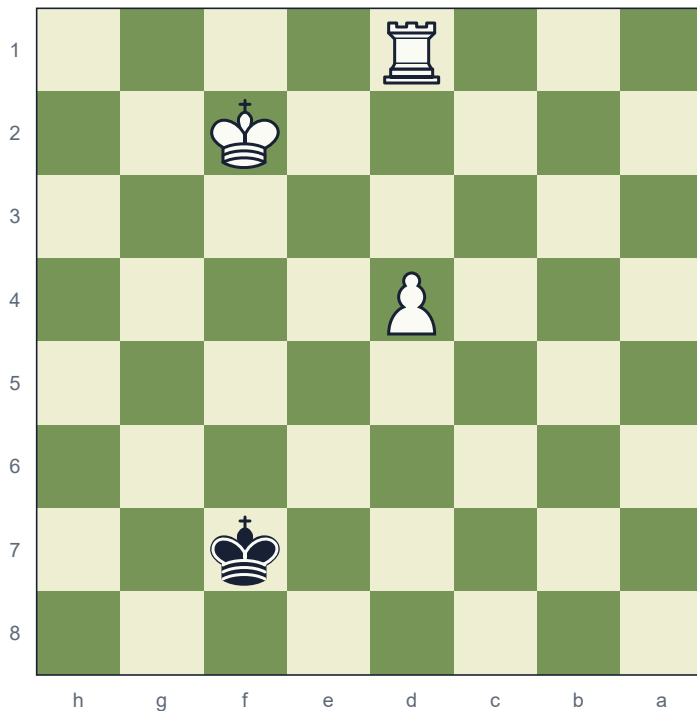
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

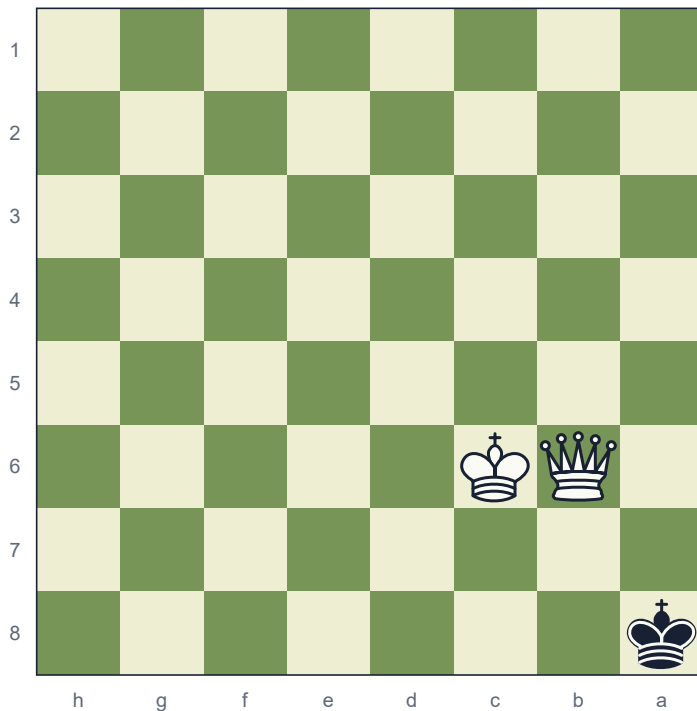
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

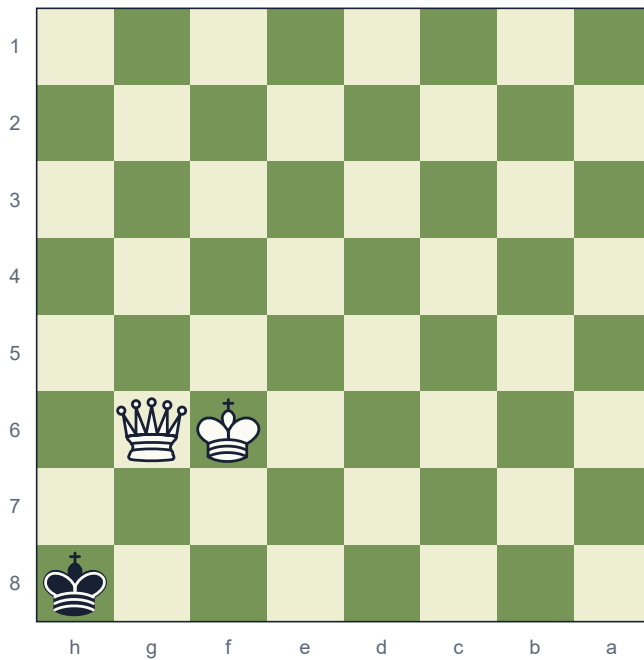
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

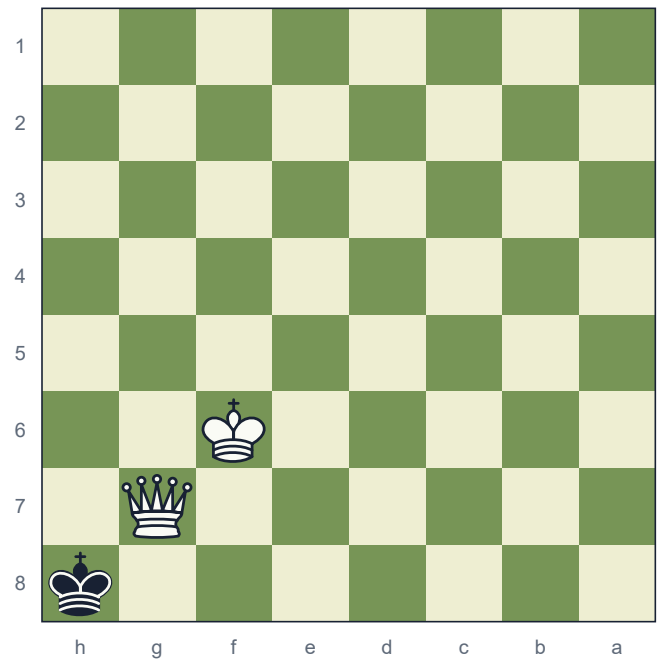
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

The opening can lead to a white isolated d-pawn, a black e6-c6 structure or doubled black f-pawns in sidelines. Each structure calls for different exchanges.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.

How the six laboratories work

ORIGINAL ILLUSTRATIVE PLAY

These are original engine-assisted study continuations from this course's positions. They are not historical master games and no invented players or tournament results are assigned. The continuations reach roughly move twenty and stop for further practice.

THINK BEFORE REVEALING

At each checkpoint, name the opponent's threat, compare two candidates and calculate a forcing reply. Use a board to replay the sequence. The engine comparison supplies concrete evidence, while the opening explanation supplies a plan.

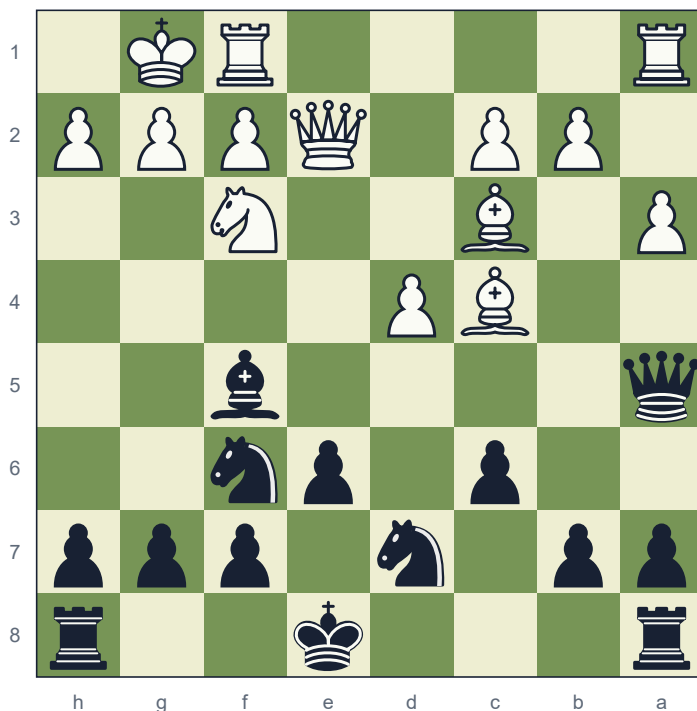
MORE THAN ONE GOOD MOVE

Close engine scores do not establish a unique answer. The finite search can prefer a different move when run longer. Accept another candidate if you can support it with a sound variation and a coherent explanation.

PRACTICE FROM BOTH SIDES

Play each starting position twice, switching colors. Record the first decision you could not explain and compare it with the branch lesson after the game.

SC-LAB-01 / The classical development route



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

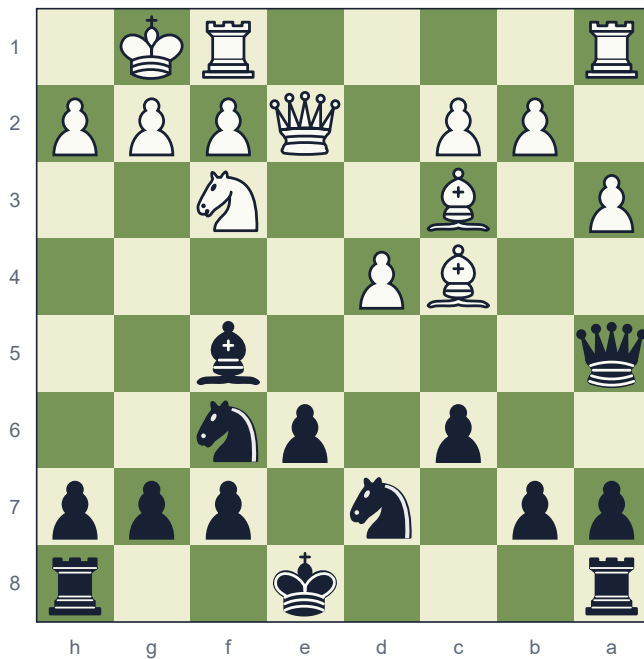
White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

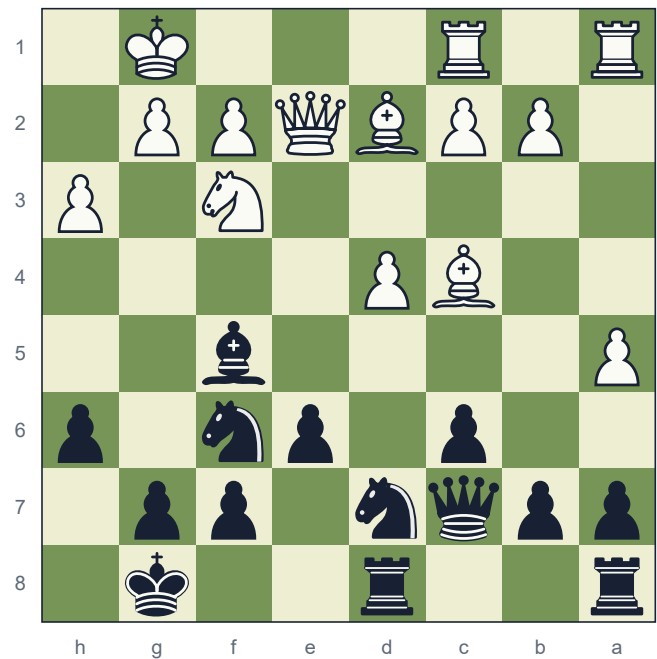
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-01 / play and explain 1

11... Qd8 12. a4 O-O 13. a5 Qc7 14. h3 h6 15. Bd2 Rfd8 16. Rfc1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... QD8

Places the queen on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... QC7

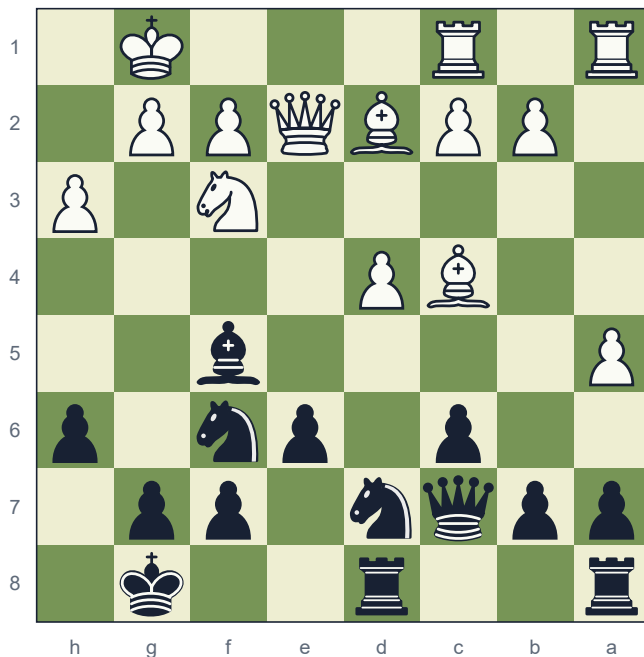
Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

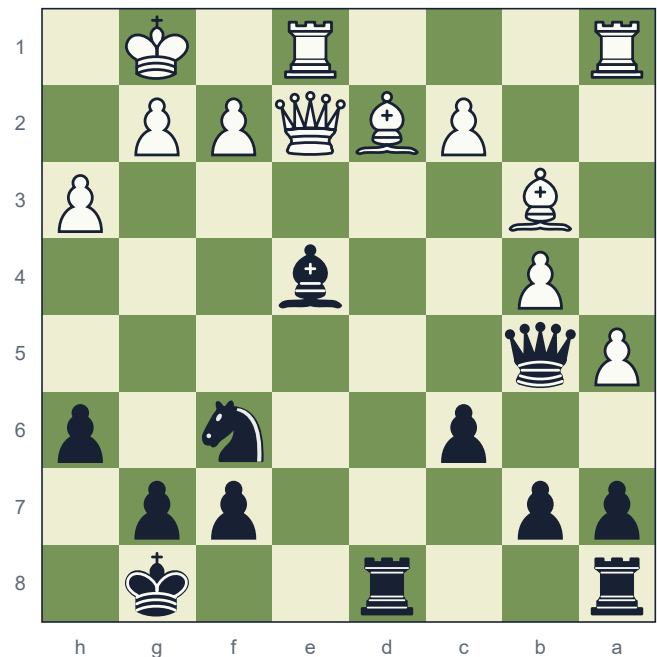
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-01 / play and explain 2

16... Be4 17. b4 e5 18. Nxe5 Nxe5 19. dxe5 Qxe5 20. Bb3 Qb5 21. Re1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... BE4

Places the bishop on e4, attacking knight on f3. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

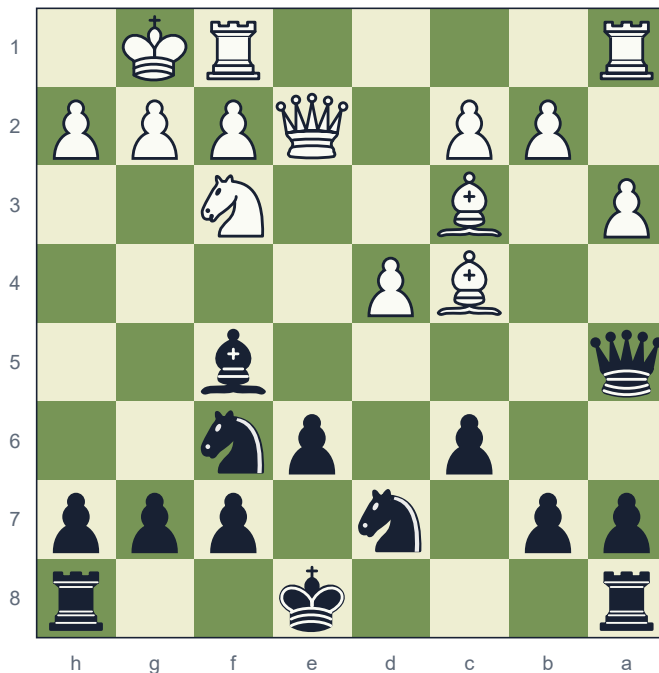
18... NXE5

The knight captures a knight on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qd8 and Qc7. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QD8

11... Qd8 12. b4 Be4 13. a4 O-O 14. a5 b5 15. Bd3 Search estimate: -0.39 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QC7

11... Qc7 12. Nh4 Bg6 13. a4 a5 14. Rfd1 Nd5 15. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.42 from Black's perspective.

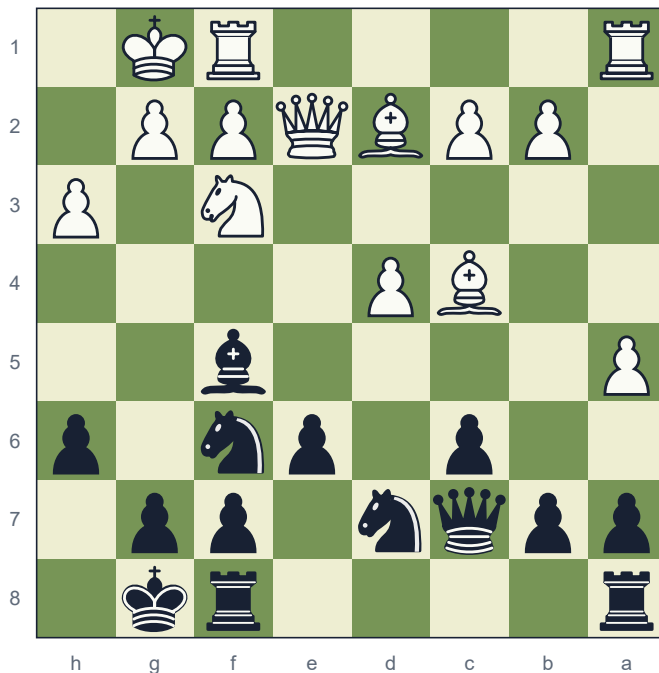
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rfd8 and Rac8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RFD8

15... Rfd8 16. Rfc1 Search estimate: -0.48 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RAC8

15... Rac8 16. Rfc1 c5 17. a6 b6 18. Bb5 Rfd8 19. dxc5 Search estimate: -0.48 from Black's perspective.

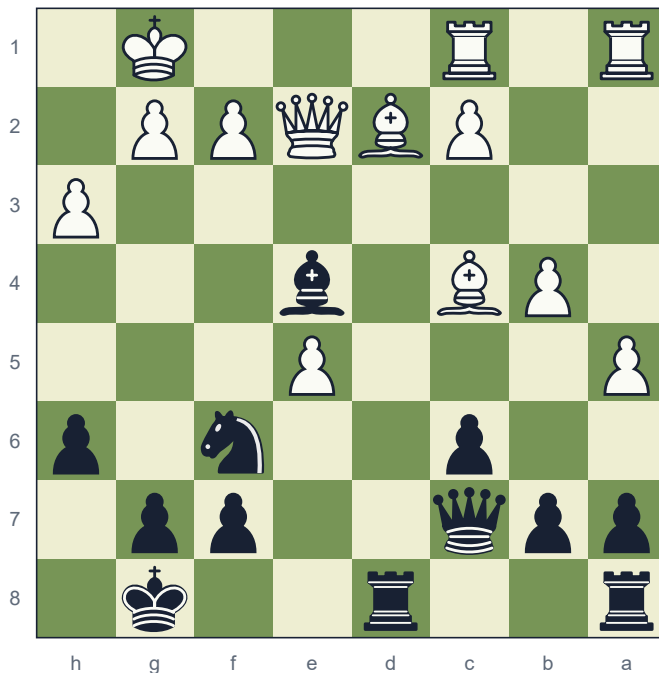
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-01 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qxe5 and Rxd2. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QXE5

19... Qxe5 Search estimate: -0.37 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RXD2

19... Rxd2 20. Qxd2 Qxe5 21. Re1 Qb2 22. Rad1 Qxc2 23. Qxc2 Search estimate: -3.66 from Black's perspective.

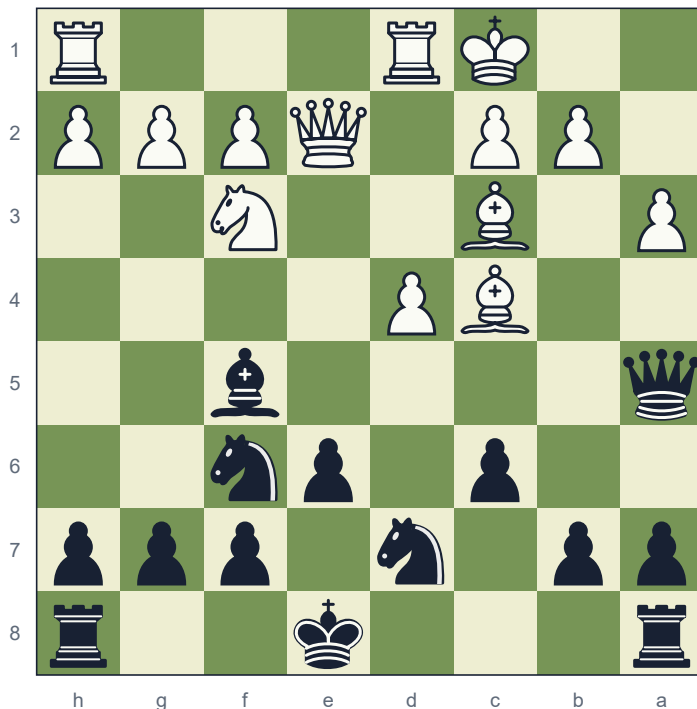
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The queen captures a pawn on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / White uses Qe2 and long castling



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Qe2 prepares long castling and increases central pressure. ...Bb4 develops with a concrete relation to the c3 knight rather than immediately making another pawn move.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

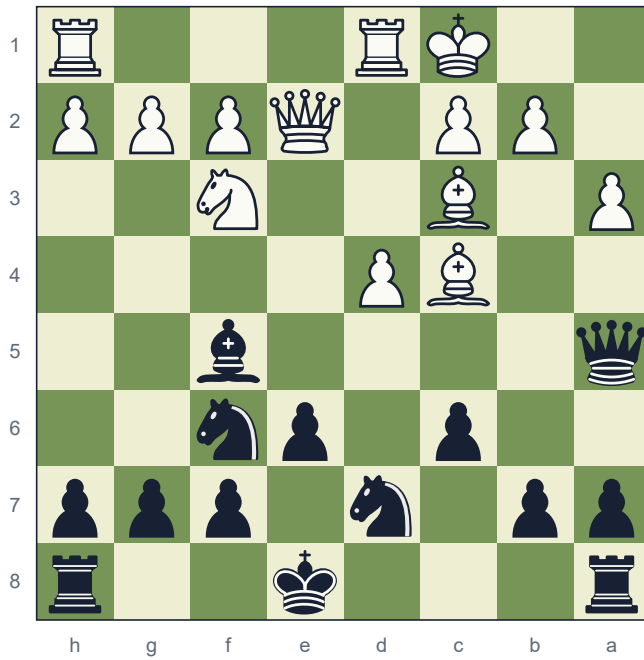
White can play O-O-O and advance the kingside pawns. Opening the center while your own king remains on e8 can be dangerous. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

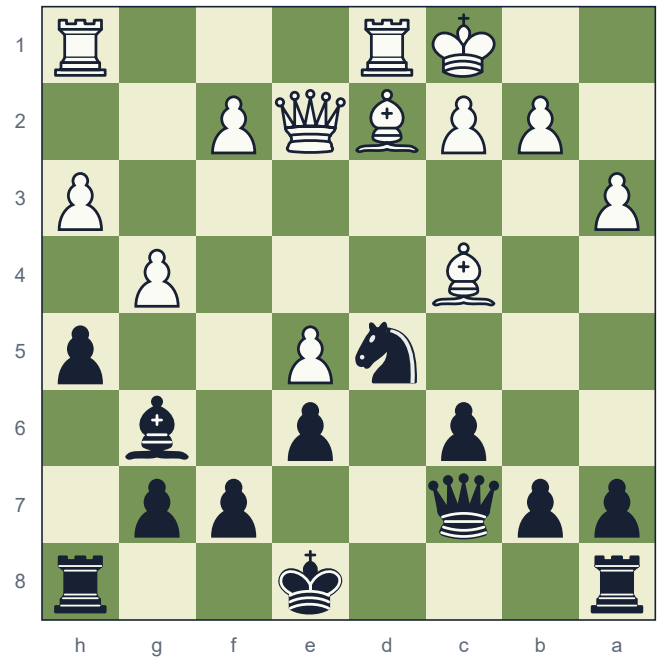
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-02 / play and explain 1

11... Qc7 12. Ne5 Nd5 13. g4 Nxe5 14. dxe5 Bg6 15. Bd2 h5 16. h3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... Qc7

Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... NXE5

The knight captures a knight on e5. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

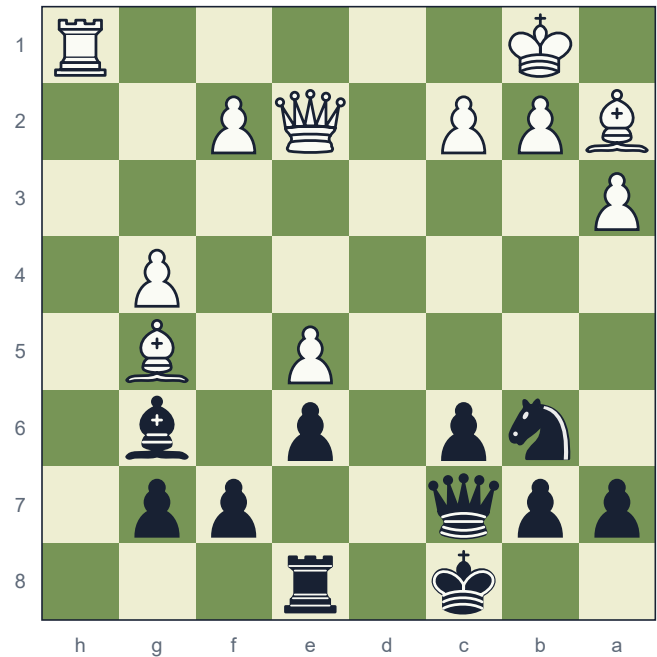
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-02 / play and explain 2

16... hxg4 17. hxg4 Rxh1 18. Rxh1 O-O-O 19. Bg5 Re8 20. Kb1 Nb6 21. Ba2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... HXG4

The pawn captures a pawn on g4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

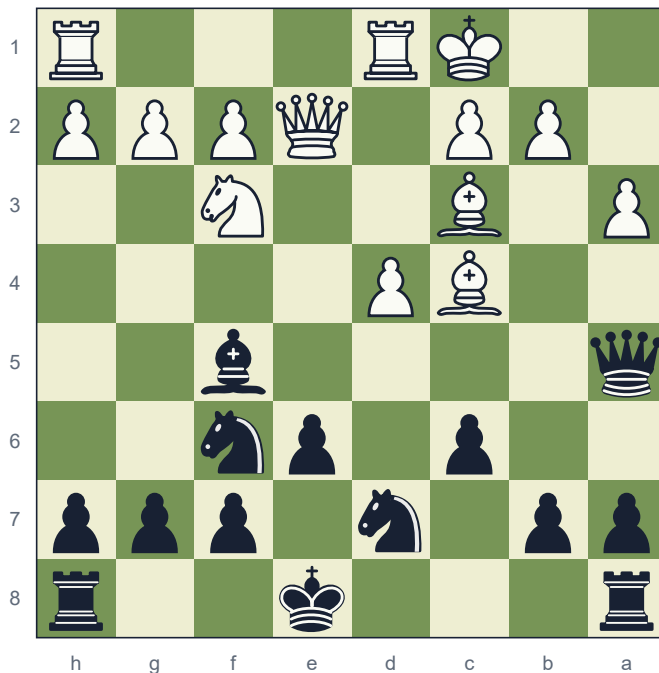
18... O-O-O

Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qc7 and Qd8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QC7

11... Qc7 12. Ne5 Nxe5 13. dxe5 Nd5 14. g4 Bg6 15. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.60 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE QD8

11... Qd8 Search estimate: -0.86 from Black's perspective.

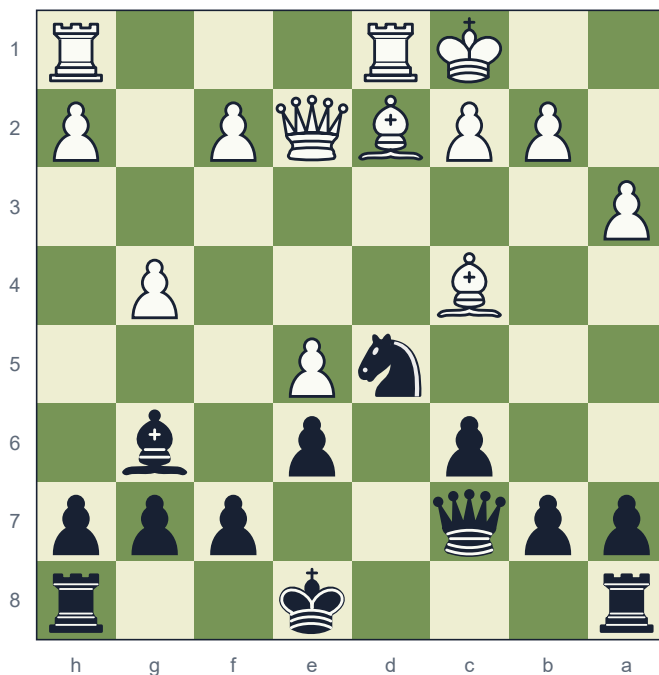
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

h5 and O-O-O. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE H5

15... h5 16. h3 O-O-O 17. f4 hxg4 18. hxg4 Rxh1 19. Rxh1 Search estimate: -0.28 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE O-O-O

15... O-O-O Search estimate: -0.31 from Black's perspective.

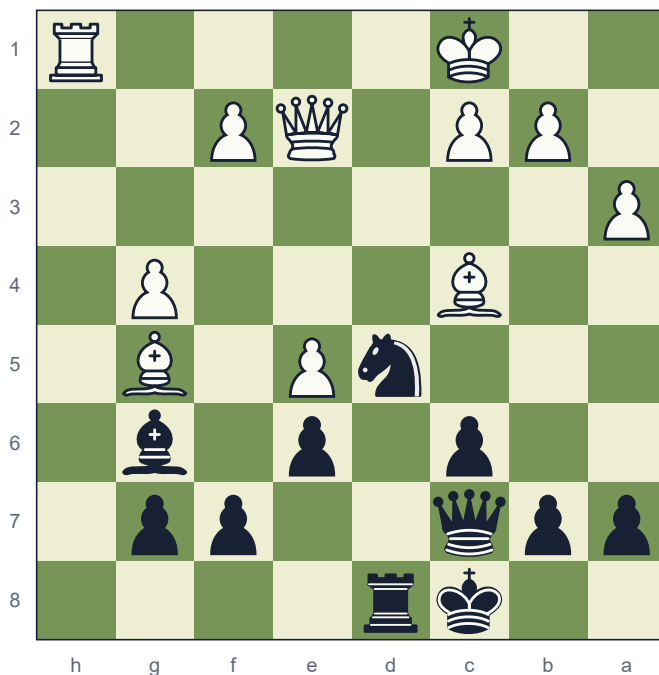
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-02 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Re8 and Rg8. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king c8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE RE8

19... Re8 20. Bb3 Search estimate: -0.33 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE RG8

19... Rg8 20. f3 a6 21. Ba2 b5 22. f4 Re8 23. Rf1 Search estimate: -0.41 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on the e-file. It can support central pawns or pressure the opposing center after exchanges.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / White pushes g4 against the bishop



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

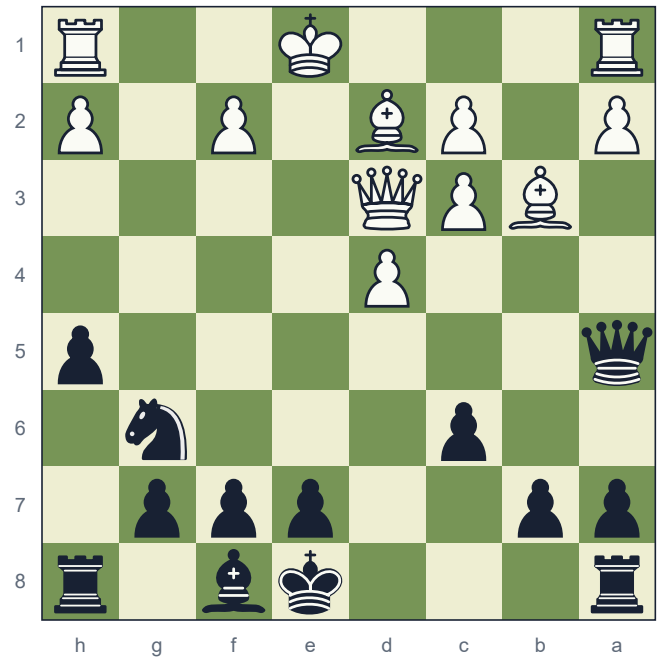
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-03 / play and explain 1

11... h5 12. g5 Nd5 13. Bd2 Nxc3 14. Qd3 Nh4 15. g6 Nxg6 16. bxc3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... H5

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

13... NXC3

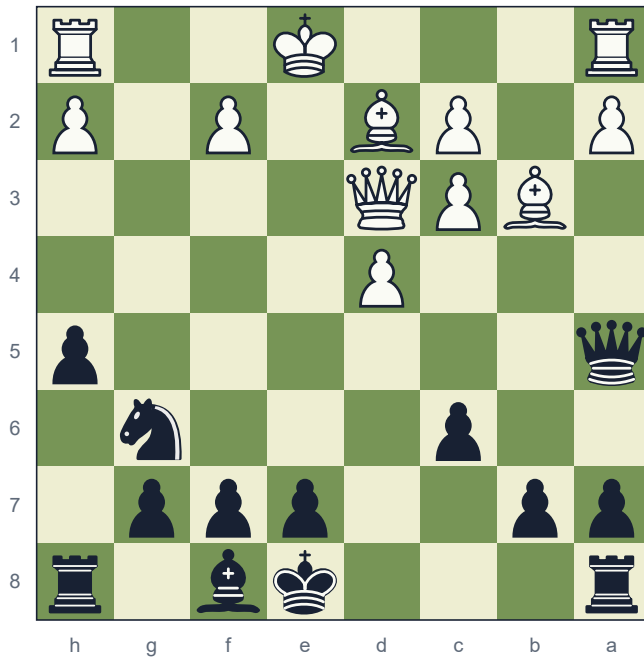
The knight captures a knight on c3. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

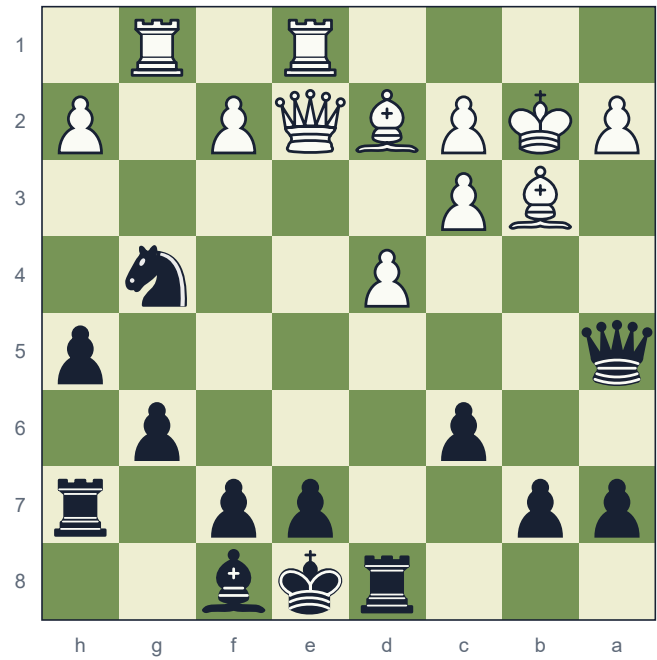
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-03 / play and explain 2

16... Rd8 17. Rg1 Ne5 18. Qe2 Ng4 19. O-O-O g6 20. Rde1 Rh7 21. Kb2



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... RD8

Places the rook on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

18... NG4

Places the knight on g4. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

h5 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE H5

11... h5 12. g5 Nd5 13. Bxd5 cxd5 14. O-O Nh4 15. g6 Search estimate: -0.26 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

11... e6 12. Bd2 Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

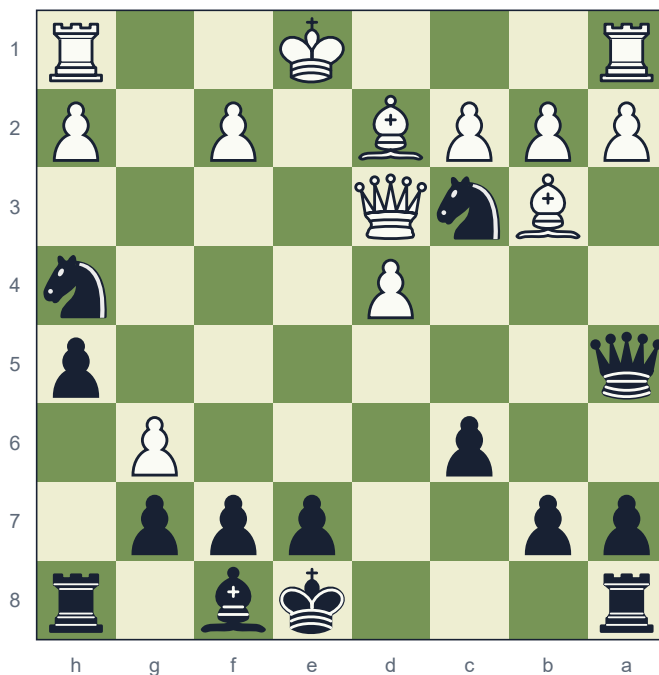
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxg6 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXG6

15... Nxg6 16. bxc3 Rd8 17. Rg1 Ne5 18. Qh3 Nd7 19. O-O-O Search estimate: -0.27 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

15... e6 16. Bxc3 Search estimate: -0.49 from Black's perspective.

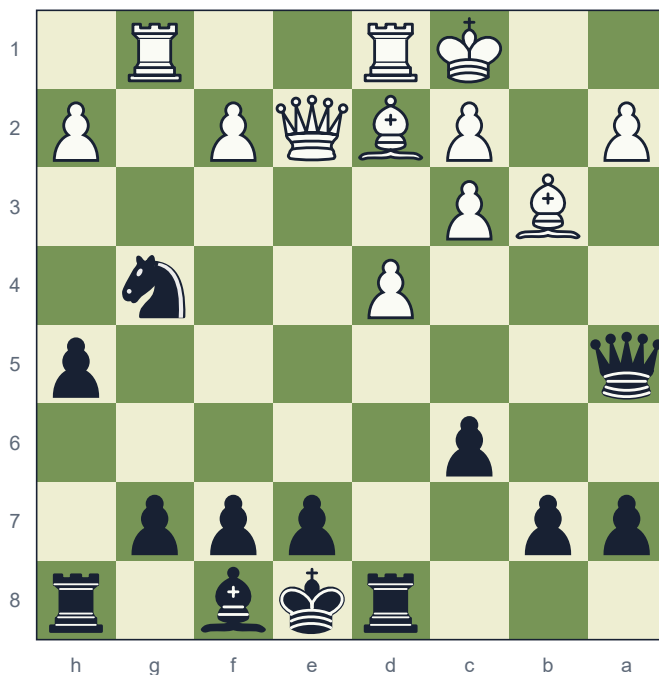
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a pawn on g6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-03 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

g6 and e6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king c1; central-file pawns c2, f2, c3, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE G6

19... g6 20. Rde1 Rh7 21. Kb2 Nh6 22. h3 Nf5 23. c4 Search estimate: +0.09 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE E6

19... e6 20. Kb1 Qa6 21. Qf3 Nf6 22. Bg5 Be7 23. c4 Search estimate: +0.03 from Black's perspective.

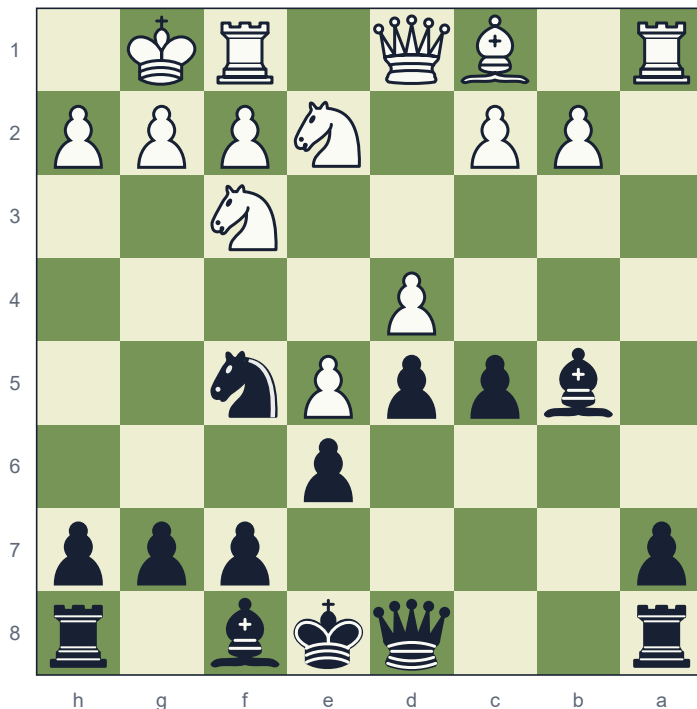
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Prepares a fianchetto and changes the long diagonal. Check the bishop and corner rook before assuming the next developing move is safe.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / White advances with 2.e5



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

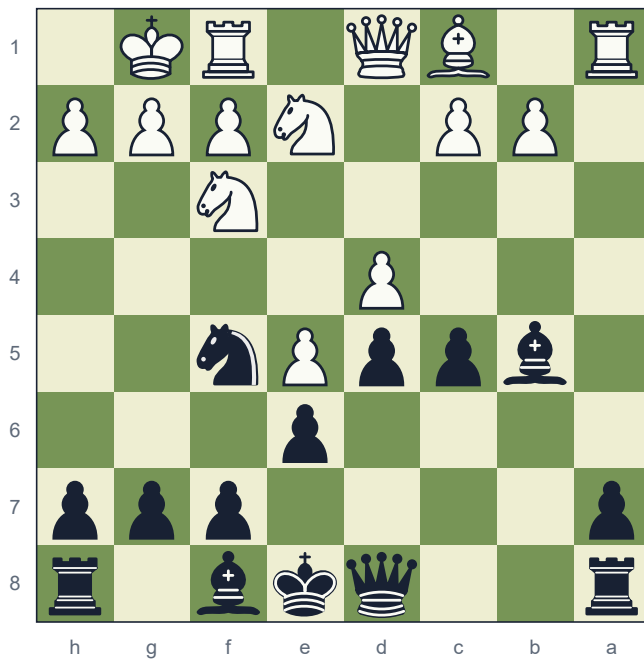
White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

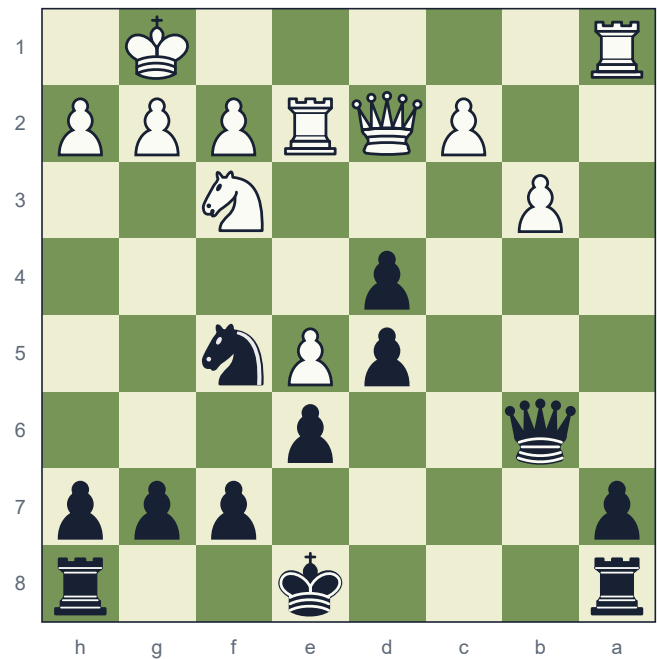
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-04 / play and explain 1

11... cxd4 12. Re1 Bb4 13. Bd2 Bxd2 14. Qxd2 Bxe2 15. Rxe2 Qb6 16. b3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... CXD4

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

13... BXD2

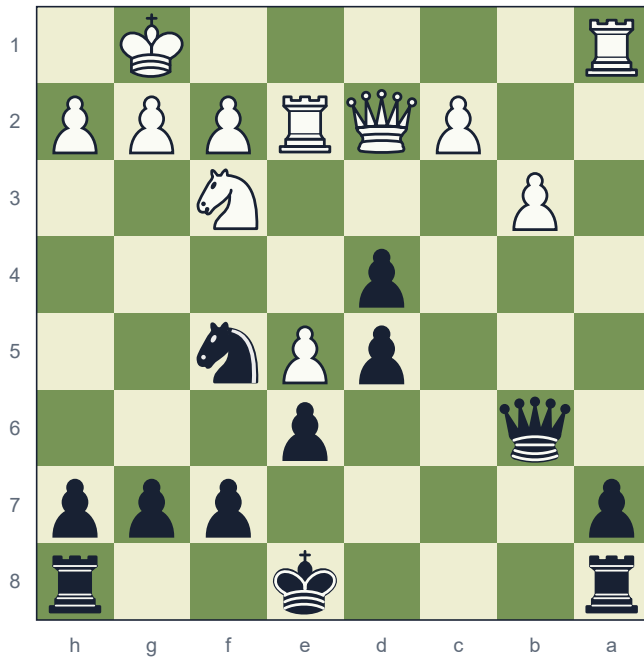
The bishop captures a bishop on d2. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

REASSESS

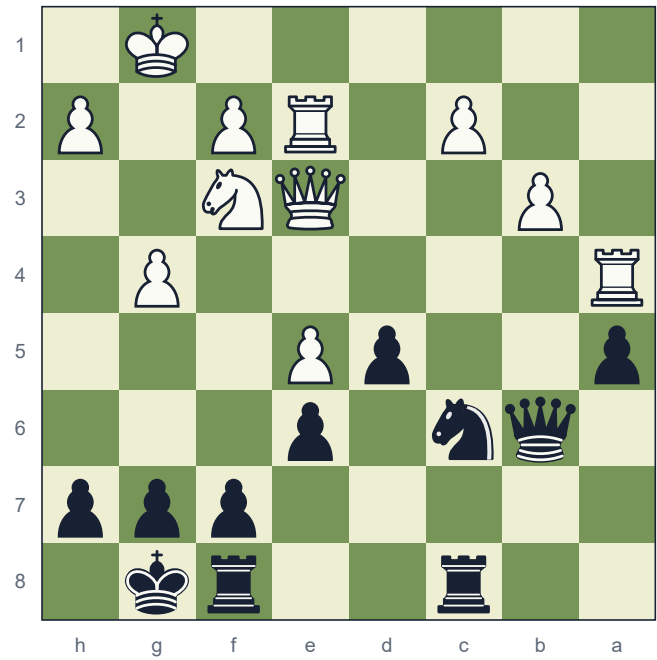
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-04 / play and explain 2

16... Rc8 17. Ra4 O-O 18. g4 Ne7 19. Nxd4 Nc6 20. Nf3 a5 21. Qe3



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... RC8

Places the rook on c8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

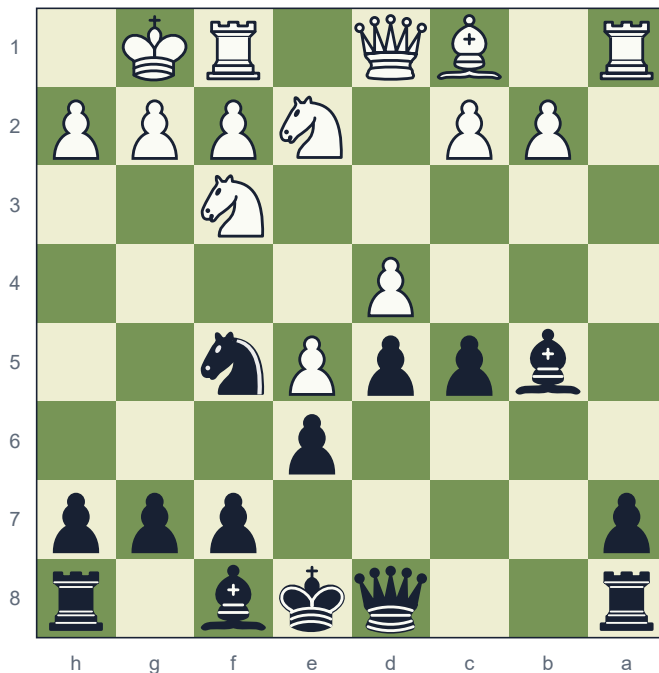
18... NE7

Develops the king knight while keeping the f-pawn flexible. It may support a central break or move toward g6 or c6 if safe.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

cx d4 and Be7. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns c5, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE CXD4

11... cxd4 12. Re1 Bb4 13. Bd2 Bxe2 14. Rxe2 Bc5 15. Ba5 Search estimate: +0.40 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BE7

11... Be7 Search estimate: +0.20 from Black's perspective.

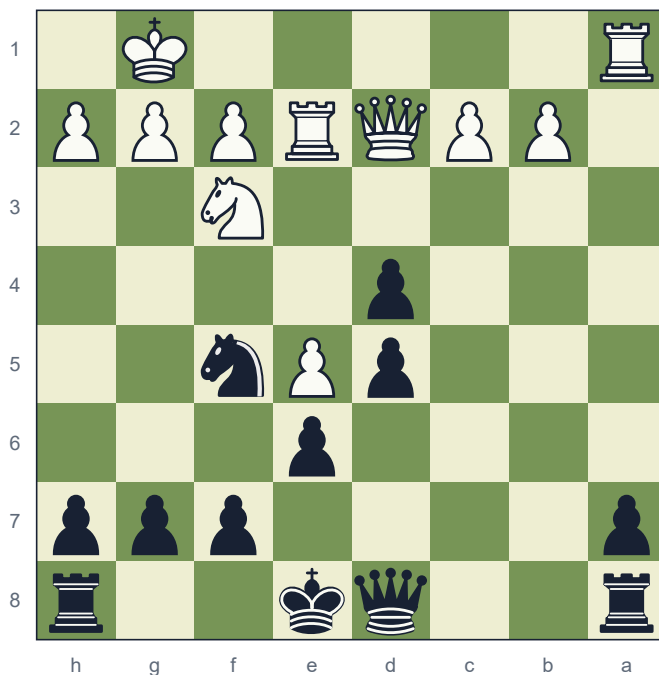
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Qb6 and O-O. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d4, d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE QB6

15... Qb6 16. b3 Search estimate: +0.23 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE O-O

15... O-O 16. Nxd4 Search estimate: +0.23 from Black's perspective.

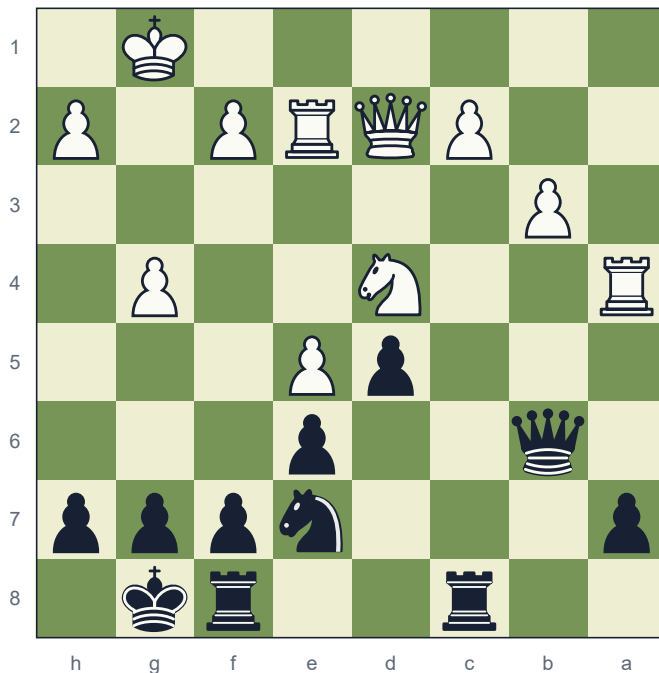
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the queen on b6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-04 / decision 3



COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nc6 and h6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, e5. Black king g8; central-file pawns d5, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NC6

19... Nc6 20. Nf3 a5 21. Qe3 Qxe3 22. Rxe3 h6 23. h4 Search estimate: +0.22 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE H6

19... h6 20. h4 Search estimate: +0.09 from Black's perspective.

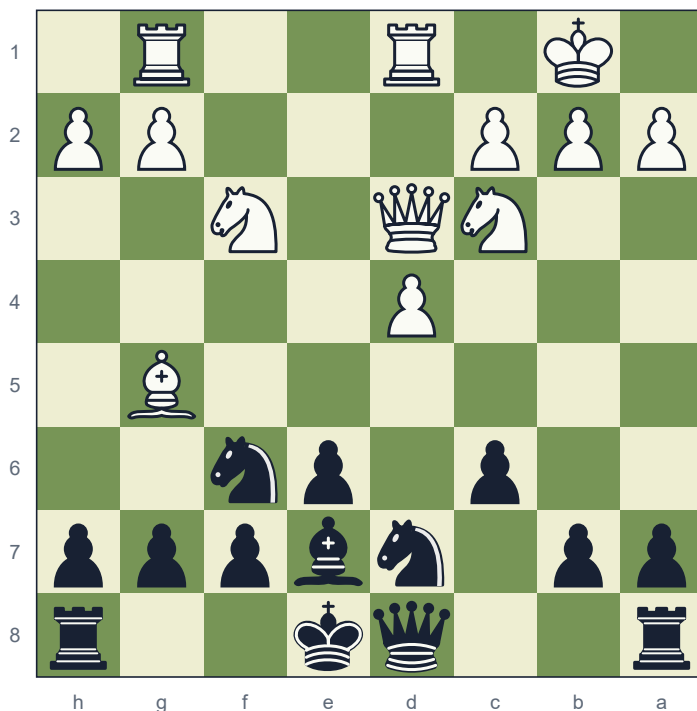
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the knight on c6, attacking knight on d4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / White offers the Blackmar-Diemer



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

White offers a pawn for development and open attacking lines. ...Bf5 develops before ...e6 and makes the extra material easier to defend.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

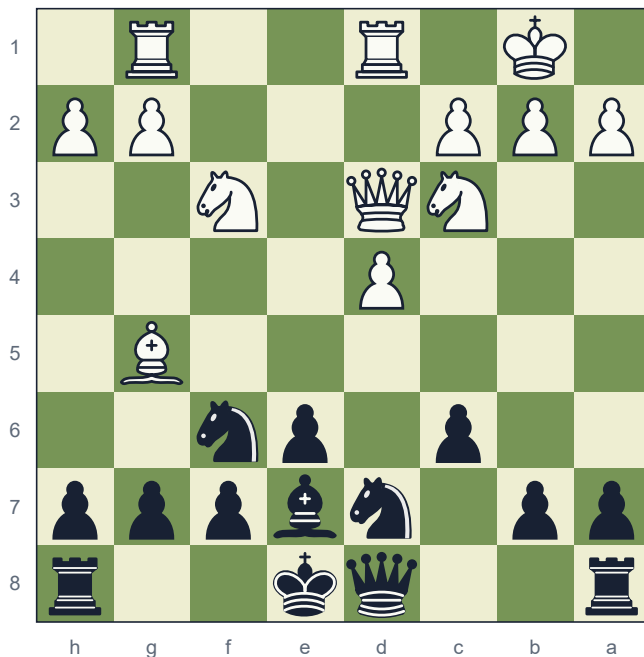
White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

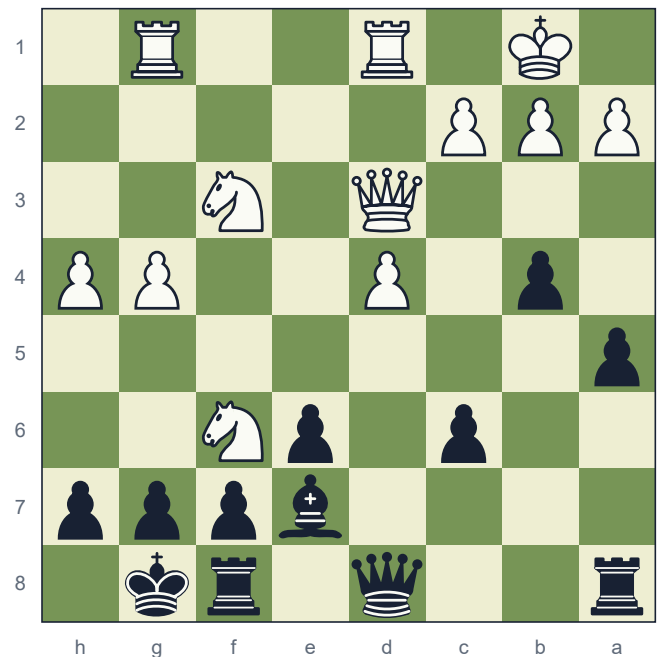
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-05 / play and explain 1

11... b5 12. g4 b4 13. Ne4 O-O 14. h4 a5 15. Bxf6 Nxf6 16. Nxf6+



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move - in check

11... B5

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

13... O-O

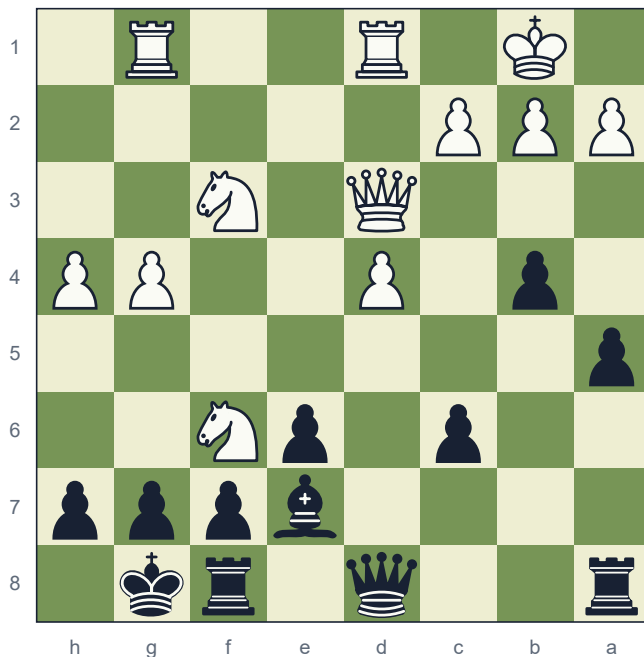
Moves the king toward shelter and brings a rook toward the center. Check the resulting open lines before assuming the king is safe.

REASSESS

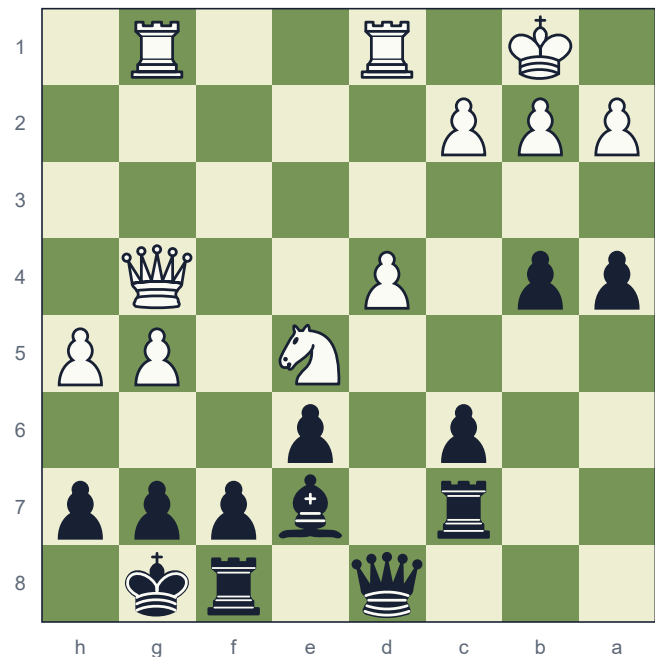
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-05 / play and explain 2

16... Bxf6 17. g5 Be7 18. Ne5 Rc8 19. Qe2 Rc7 20. Qg4 a4 21. h5



Before this segment - Black to move - in check



After this segment - Black to move

16... Bxf6

The bishop captures a knight on f6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

18... Rc8

Places the rook on c8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

b5 and Ng4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE B5

11... b5 Search estimate: +0.52 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NG4

11... Ng4 12. Bxe7 Qxe7 13. Rde1 O-O-O 14. a3 h6 15. Qe2 Search estimate: +0.34 from Black's perspective.

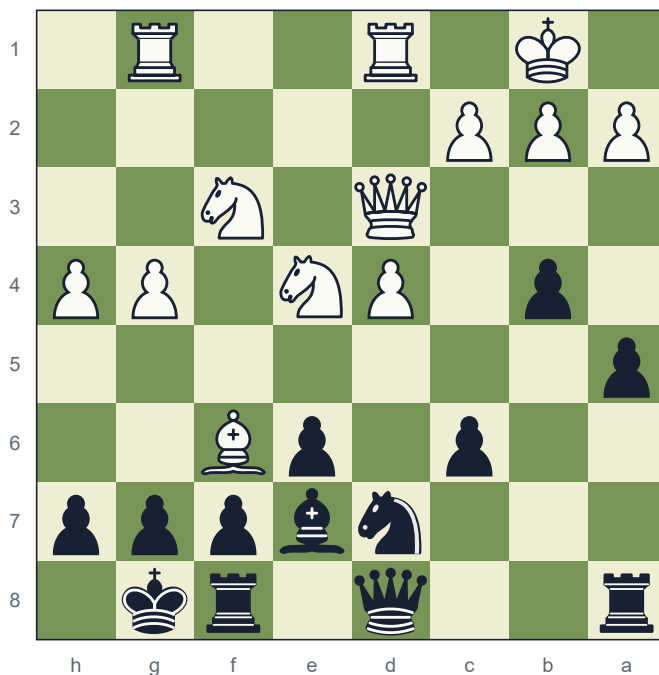
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Nxf6 and Bxf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE NXF6

15... Nxf6 16. Nxf6+ Bxf6 17. g5 Be7 18. Ne5 Rc8 19. Qe2 Search estimate: +0.57 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF6

15... Bxf6 16. g5 Search estimate: +0.08 from Black's perspective.

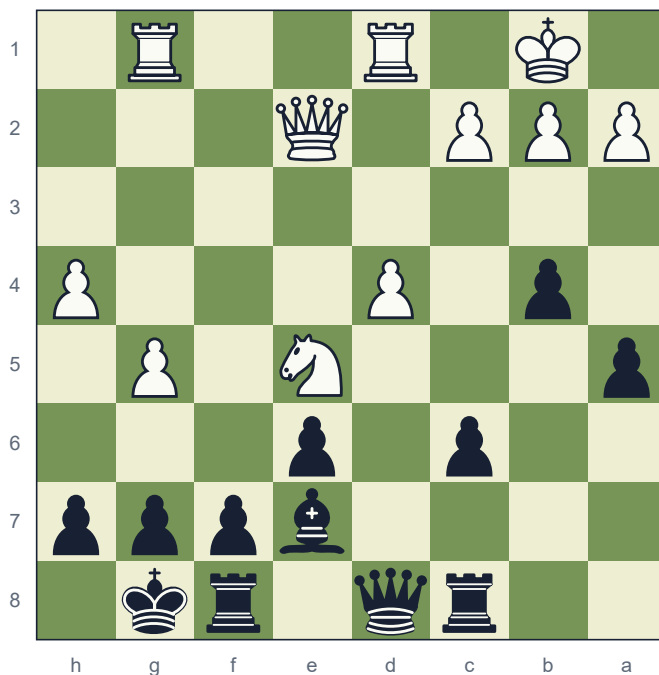
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

The knight captures a bishop on f6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-05 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Rc7 and a4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE Rc7

19... Rc7 Search estimate: +0.72 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE A4

19... a4 20. Qa6 a3 21. Nxc6 Qd7 22. Nxe7+ Qxe7 23. h5 Search estimate: +0.46 from Black's perspective.

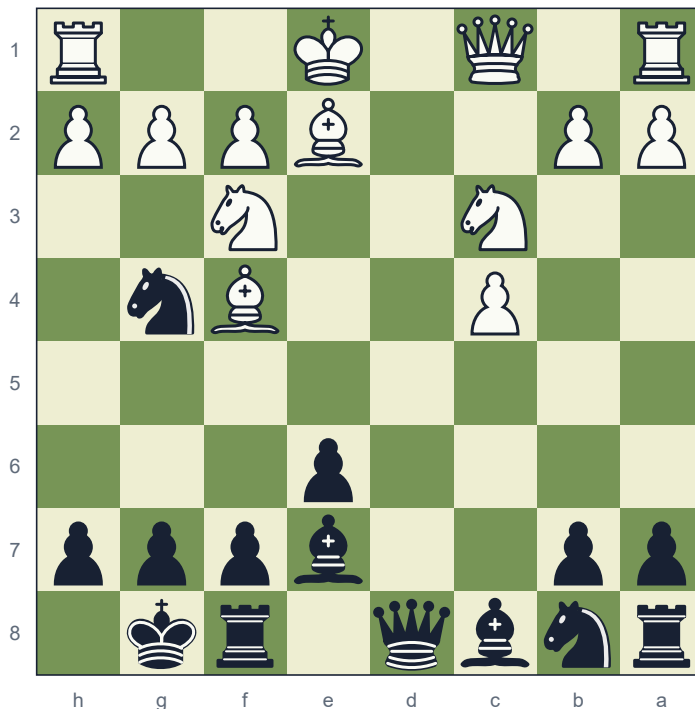
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the rook on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / White attacks the queen with 3.c4



Laboratory start - Black to move

OPENING BACKGROUND

The c-pawn move gains a queen tempo but leaves d4 as a possible long-term target. Black retreats safely and develops.

READ THE CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

OPENING CONCERN TO RECHECK

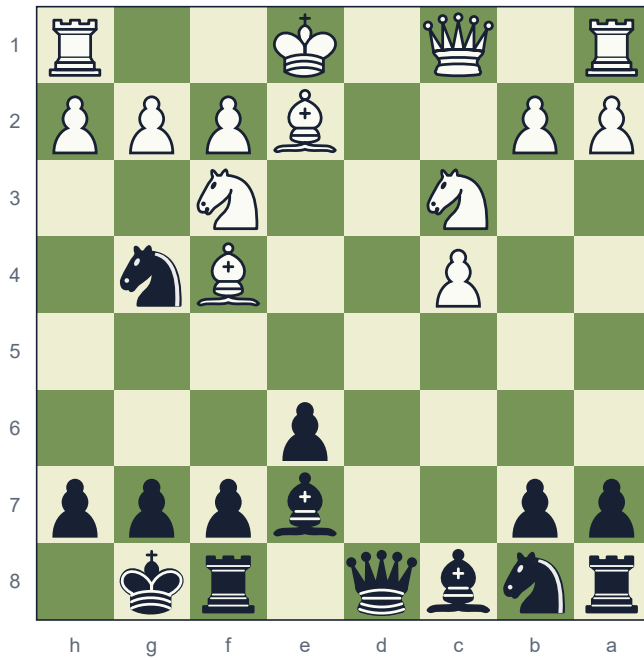
White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position. Decide which parts still apply after the moves already played.

BEFORE PLAYING

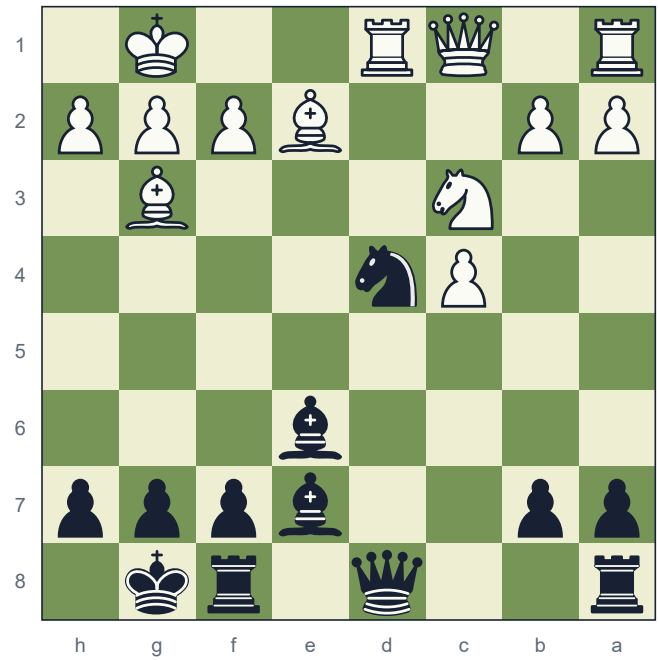
Write a candidate move and a reply for the opponent. Name the pawn break each side would like to achieve. The continuation on the following pages is one checked illustration, not a forced script.

SC-LAB-06 / play and explain 1

11... e5 12. Nxe5 Nxe5 13. Bxe5 Nc6 14. Bg3 Nd4 15. O-O Be6 16. Rd1



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

11... E5

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

13... NC6

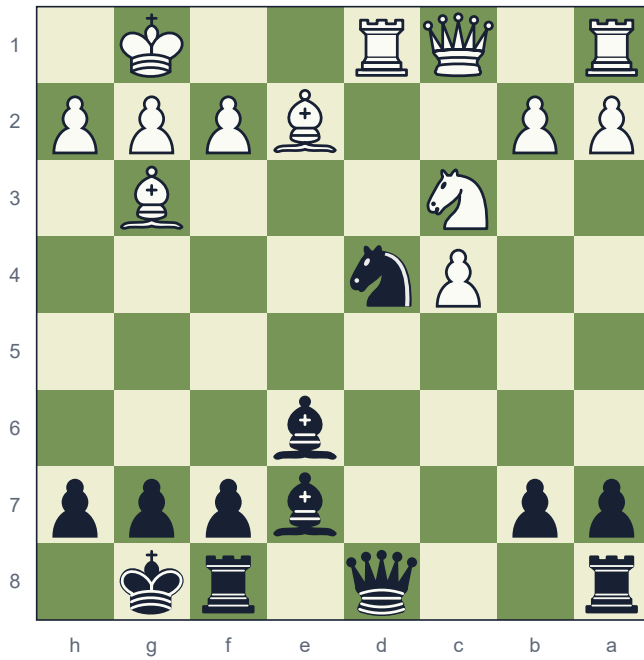
Places the knight on c6, attacking bishop on e5. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

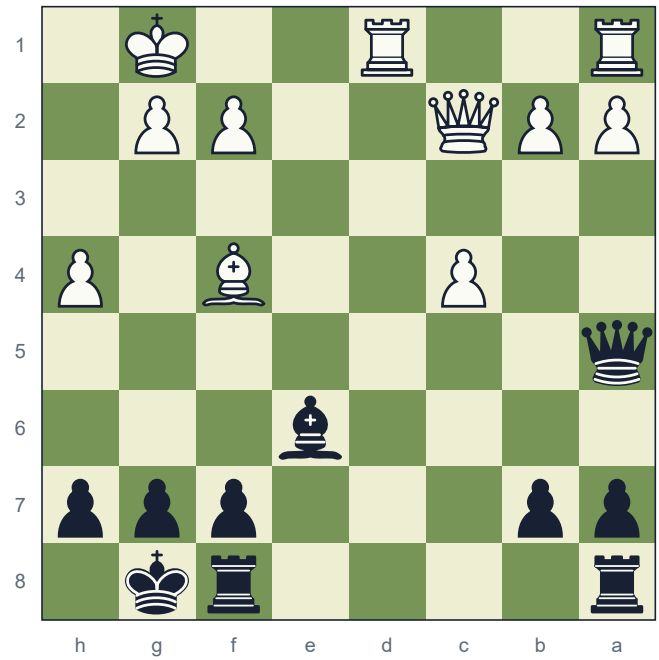
Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-06 / play and explain 2

16... Nxe2+ 17. Nxe2 Qa5 18. Nf4 Bg5 19. h4 Bh6 20. Qc2 Bxf4 21. Bxf4



Before this segment - Black to move



After this segment - Black to move

16... NXE2+

The knight captures a bishop on e2. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

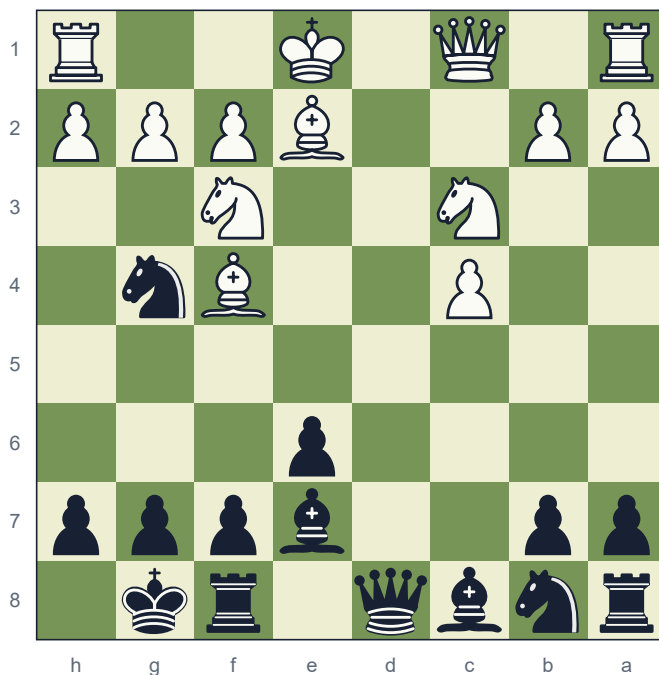
18... BG5

Places the bishop on g5, attacking knight on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

REASSESS

Name the material balance, the most active piece and the next pawn break. If the center changed, explain why the original plan may need to change too.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 1



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

e5 and Nc6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE E5

11... e5 12. Nxe5 Nxe5 13. Bxe5 Nc6 14. Bg3 Bf6 15. O-O Search estimate: -0.59 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE NC6

11... Nc6 Search estimate: -0.70 from Black's perspective.

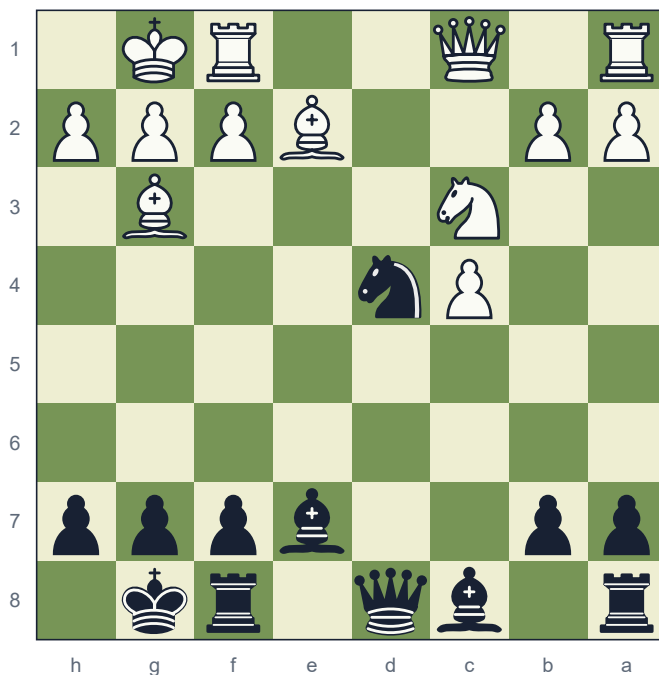
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 2



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Be6 and Bf6. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BE6

15... Be6 16. Rd1 Nxe2+ 17. Nxe2 Qb6 18. Nf4 Bg5 19. c5 Search estimate: -0.53 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BF6

15... Bf6 16. Bd1 Be6 17. Ne4 Be7 18. Be5 f6 19. Bxd4 Search estimate: -0.59 from Black's perspective.

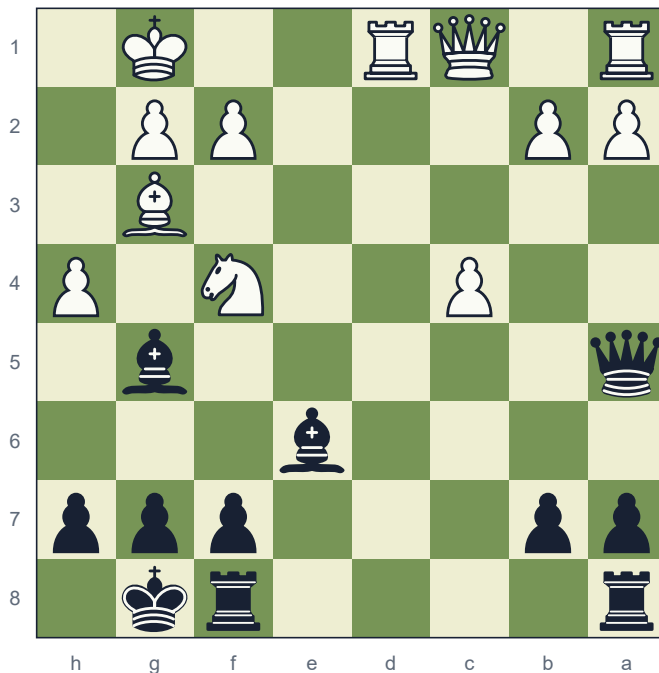
EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on e6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

SC-LAB-06 / decision 3



Black to move

COMPARE CANDIDATES

Bh6 and Bxf4. Before reading the continuations, explain a useful purpose for each and calculate the opponent's most forcing reply.

CURRENT POSITION

White king g1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move.

CANDIDATE BH6

19... Bh6 20. Qc2 Bxf4 21. Bxf4 Rfd8 22. Qe4 Rxd1+ 23. Rxd1 Search estimate: -0.65 from Black's perspective.

CANDIDATE BXF4

19... Bxf4 20. Bxf4 Search estimate: -0.75 from Black's perspective.

EXPLAIN THE PREFERRED MOVE

Places the bishop on h6, attacking knight on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

HOW TO INTERPRET THIS

The scores compare these candidates in one finite search. Close values mean the explanation and practical comfort matter; they do not imply a unique winning move. Replay both lines and identify the first concrete difference.

48 exercises / instructions

THREE KINDS OF QUESTION

Questions 1-24 test opening recall, 25-36 test plans and defense, and 37-48 compare concrete candidates from the laboratories. These are not all tactical puzzles and do not all have one uniquely best move.

WORK WITHOUT THE ANSWER

Use a board and write your answer. Spend two to five minutes on a recall question and five to ten on a candidate comparison. Name the opponent's threat before choosing your own move.

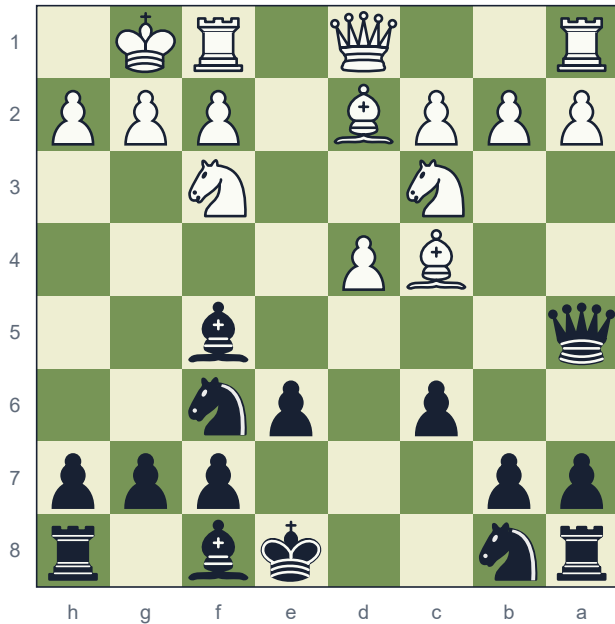
MARKING

Award one point for a legal, relevant choice or plan; one for a clear reason; one for recognizing the opponent's resource; and one for a supporting variation or accurate description of the structure. Maximum: 192. Do not reward memorized notation that you cannot explain.

ANSWERS ARE LATER

The question pages come first, followed by explained answers and sample continuations. In planning questions the sample answer is a guide, not an exhaustive list of reasonable plans.

Exercises 1-2



Black to move

01 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

02 / OPENING RECALL

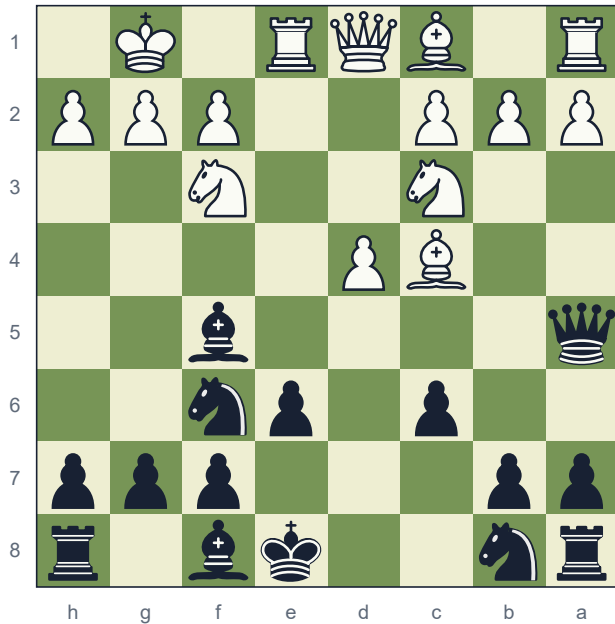
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 3-4



Black to move

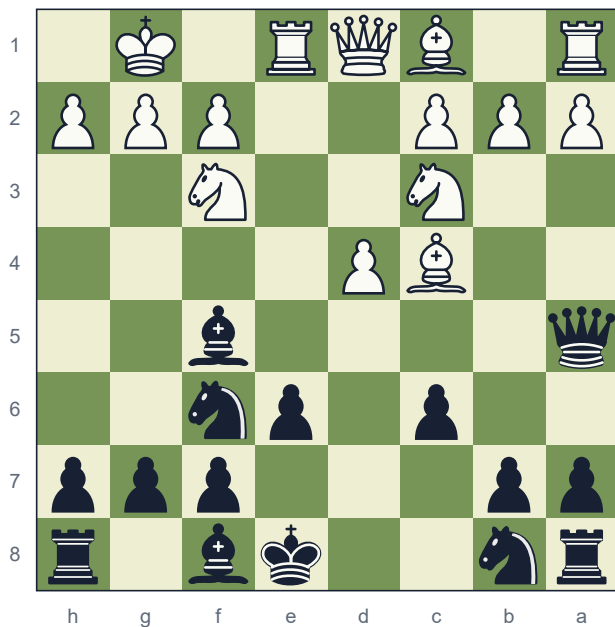
03 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

04 / OPENING RECALL

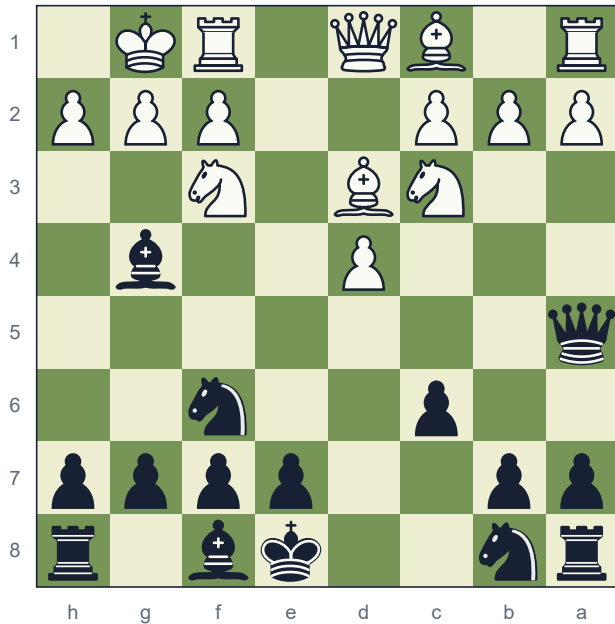
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 5-6



Black to move

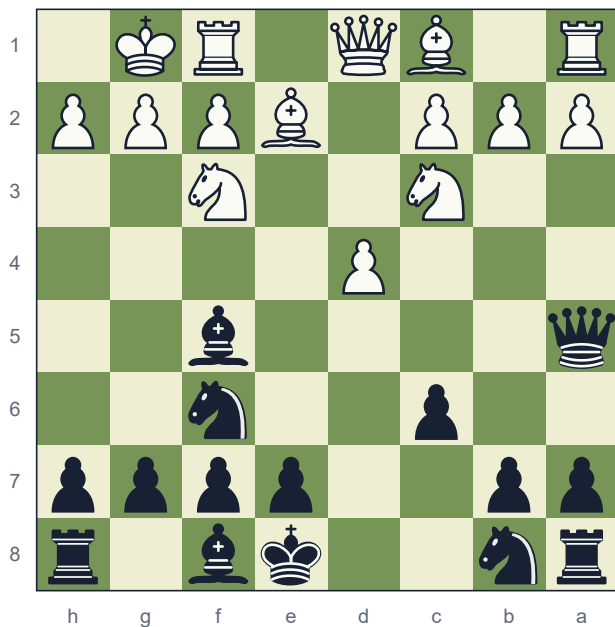
05 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

06 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 7-8



Black to move

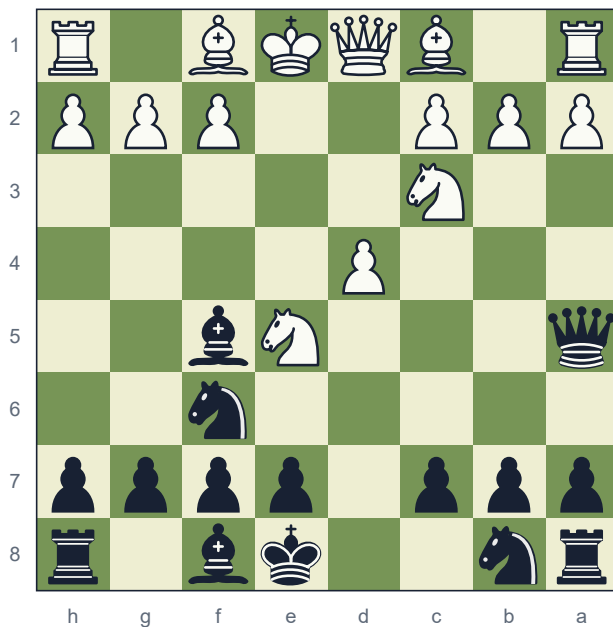
07 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

08 / OPENING RECALL

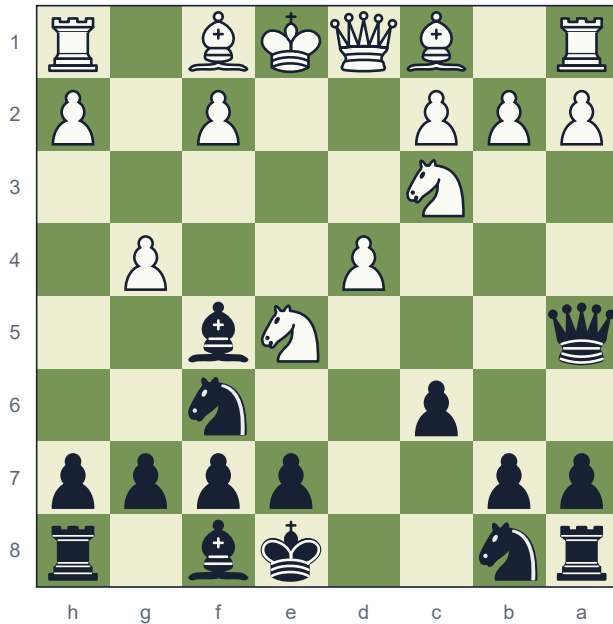
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 9-10



Black to move

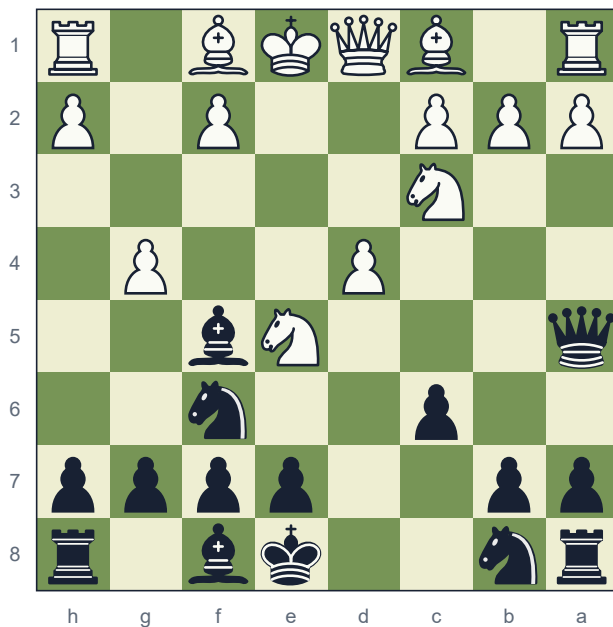
09 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

10 / OPENING RECALL

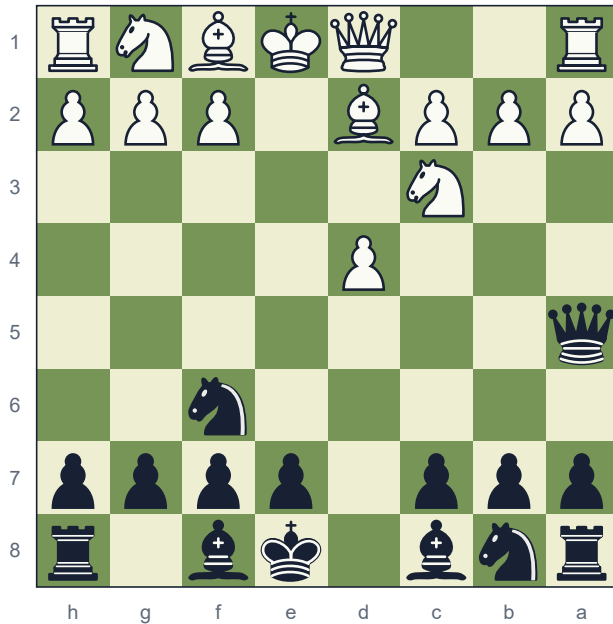
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 11-12



Black to move

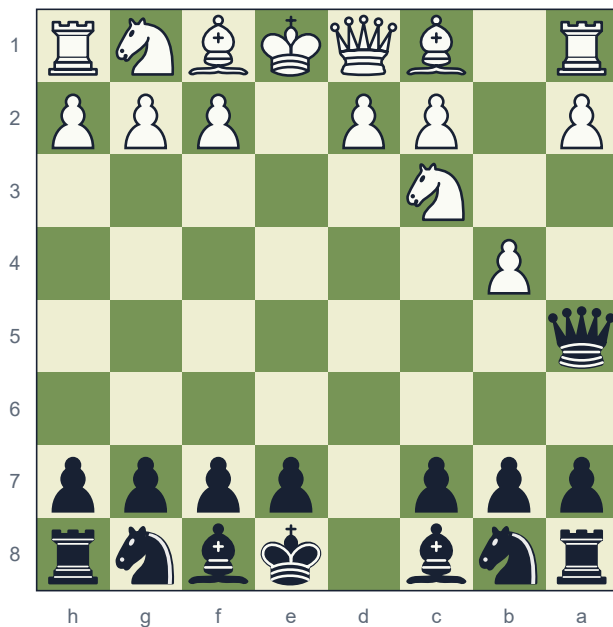
11 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

12 / OPENING RECALL

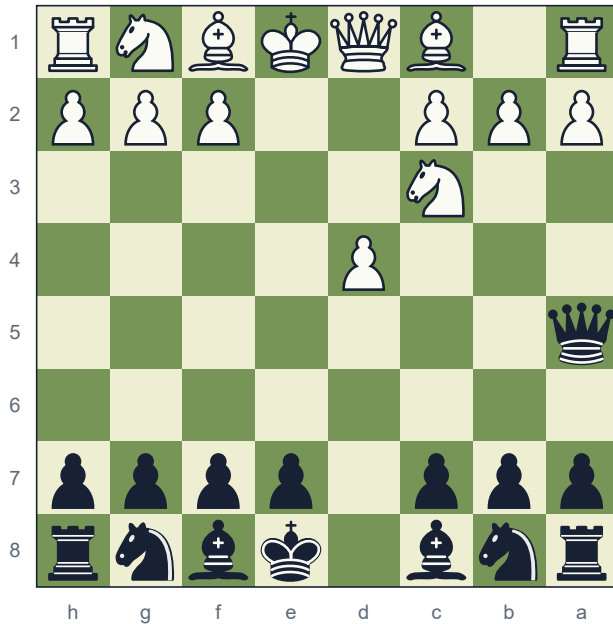
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 13-14



Black to move

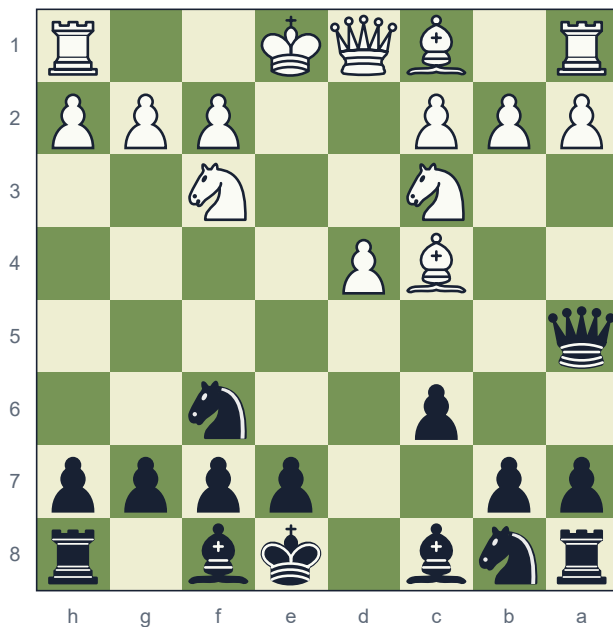
13 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

14 / OPENING RECALL

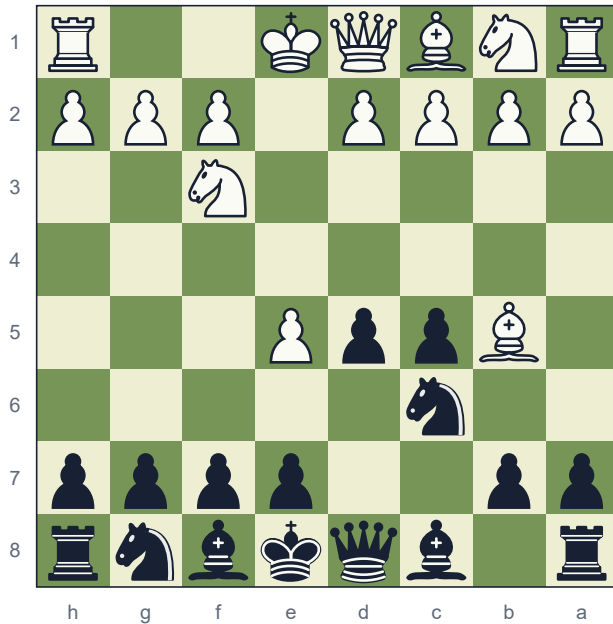
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 15-16



Black to move

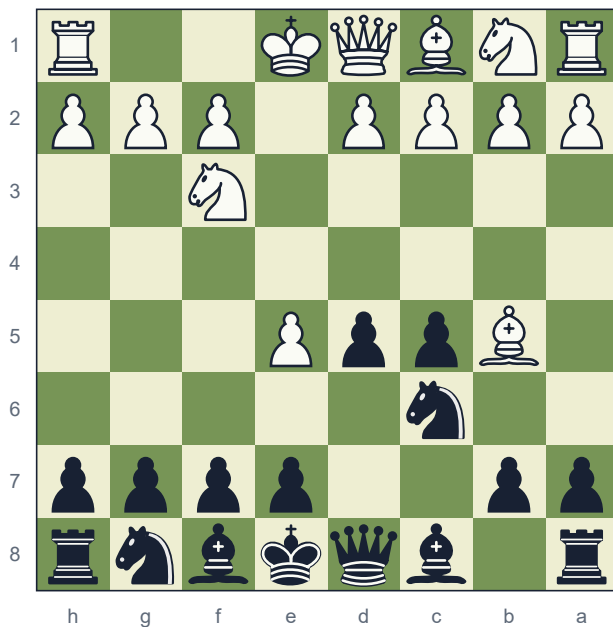
15 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

16 / OPENING RECALL

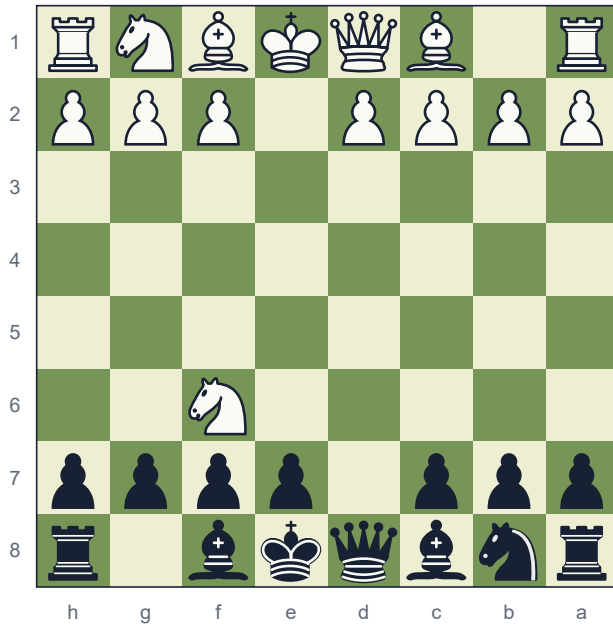
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 17-18



Black to move - in check

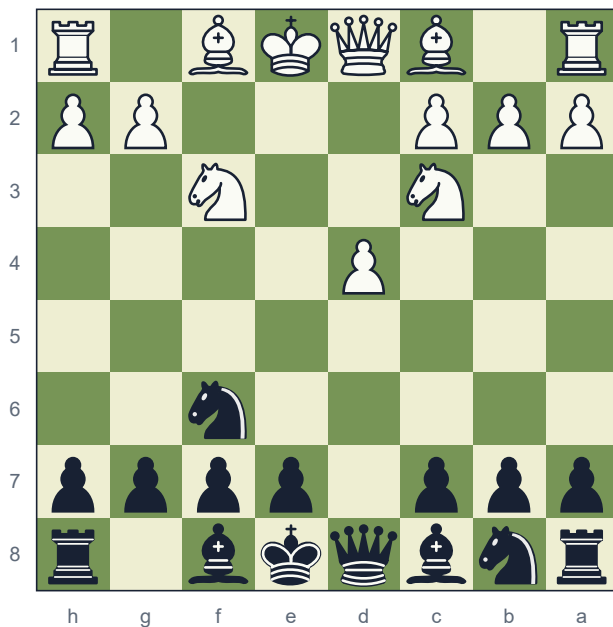
17 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

18 / OPENING RECALL

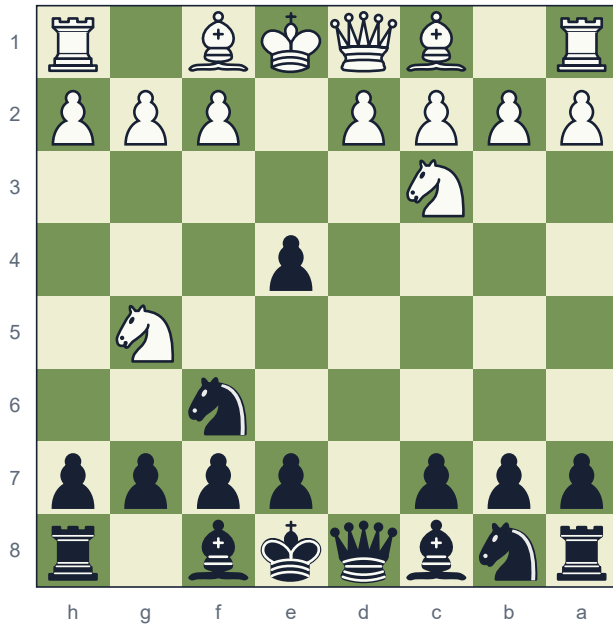
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 19-20



Black to move

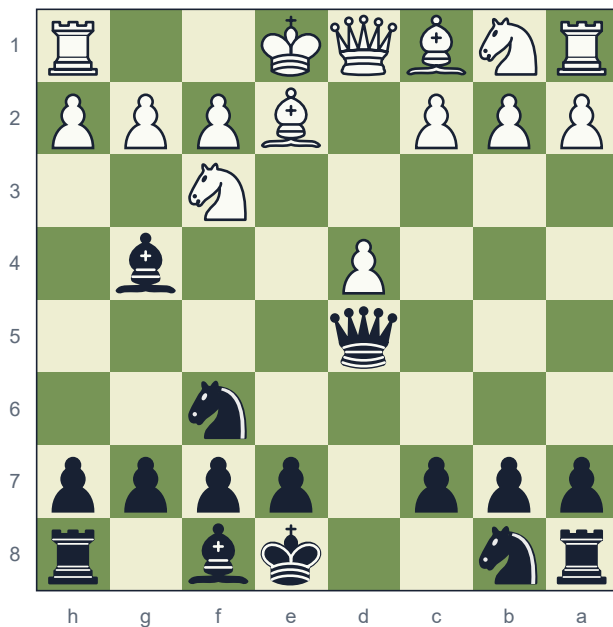
19 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

20 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 21-22



Black to move

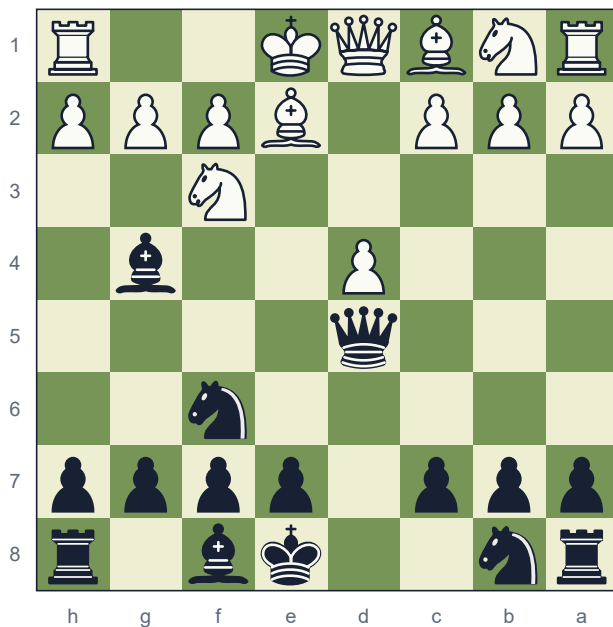
21 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

22 / OPENING RECALL

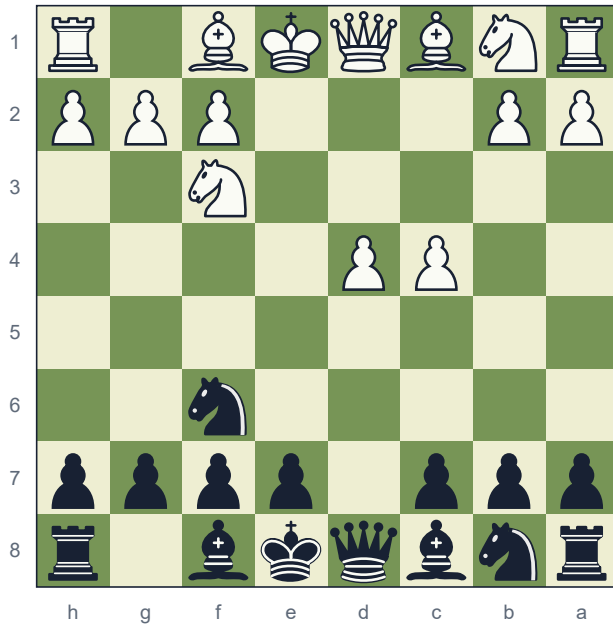
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 23-24



Black to move

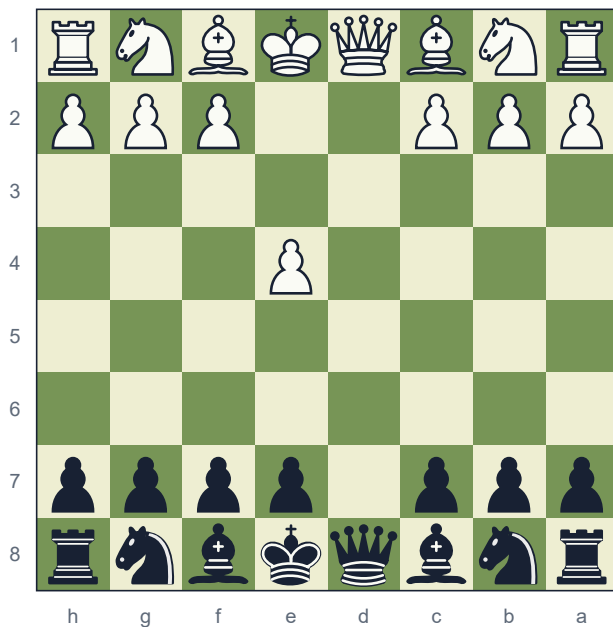
23 / OPENING RECALL

Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

24 / OPENING RECALL

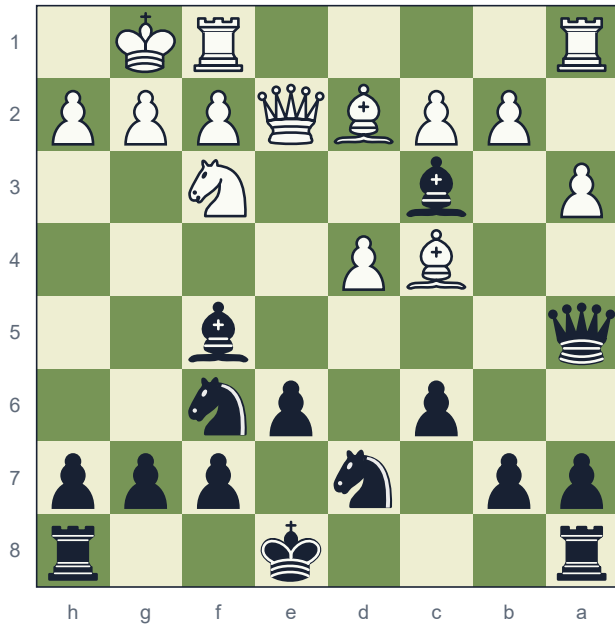
Choose the course move, explain its purpose and name one opposing resource. Other playable moves may exist; this is a repertoire-recall question.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 25-26



25 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



26 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

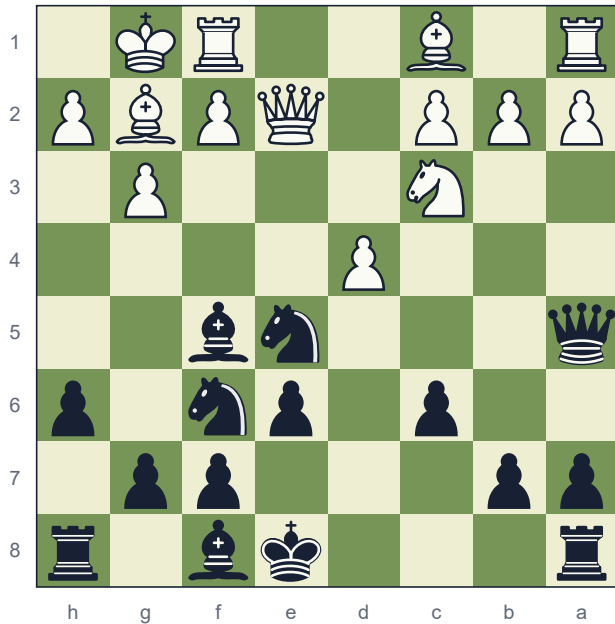
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 27-28



White to move

27 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

28 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

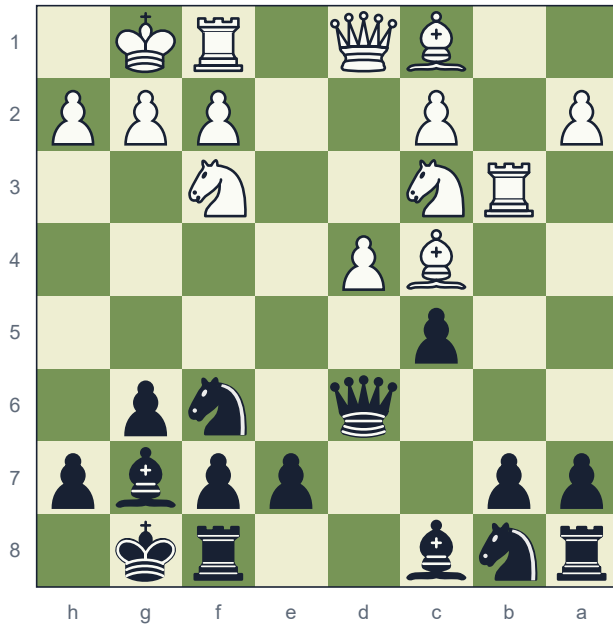
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 29-30



White to move

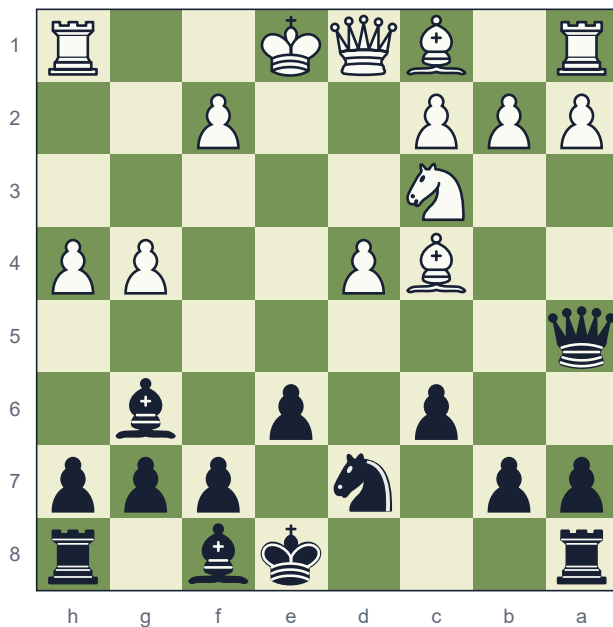
29 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

30 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

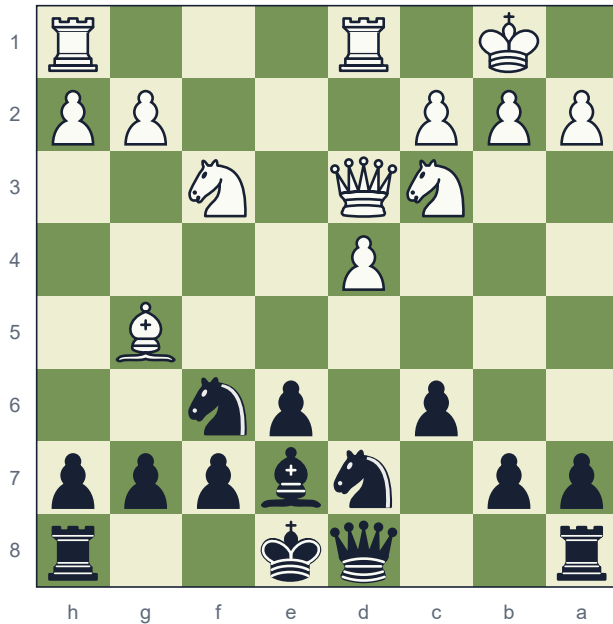
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 31-32



White to move

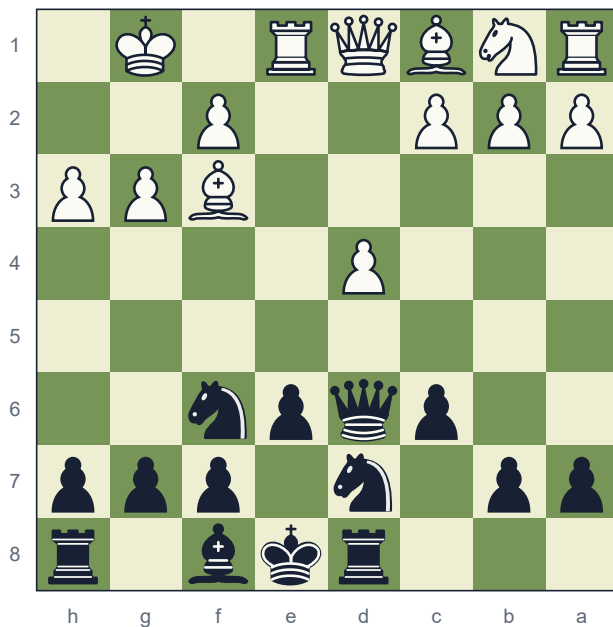
31 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

32 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

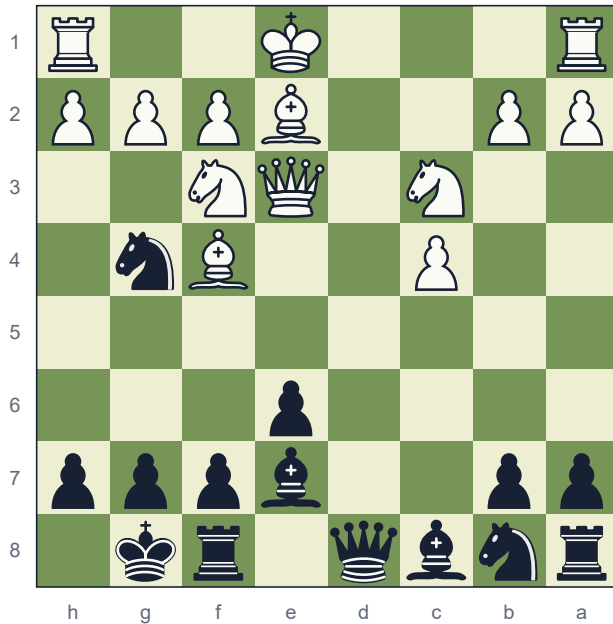
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 33-34



White to move

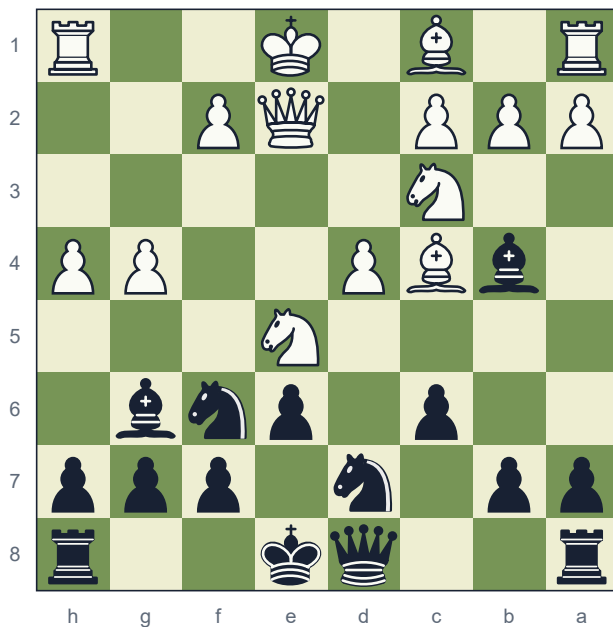
33 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

34 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

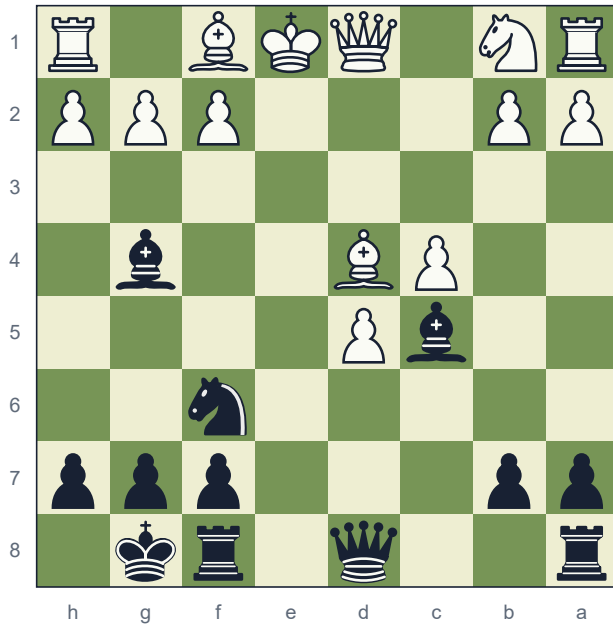
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 35-36



White to move

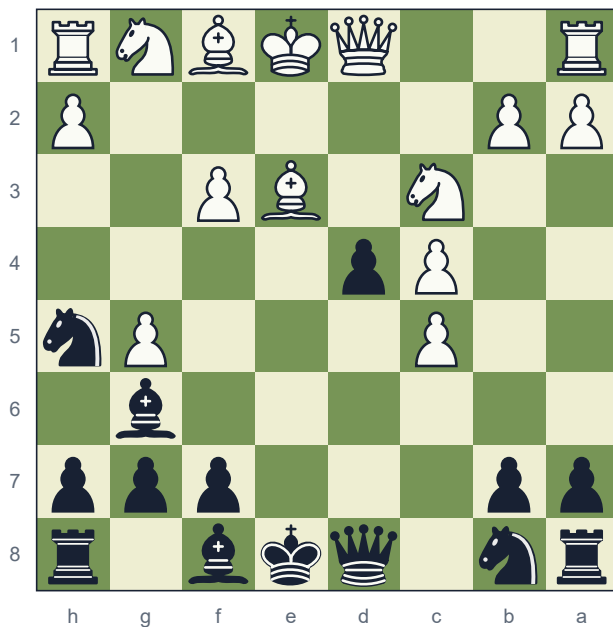
35 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



White to move

36 / PLAN AND DEFENSE

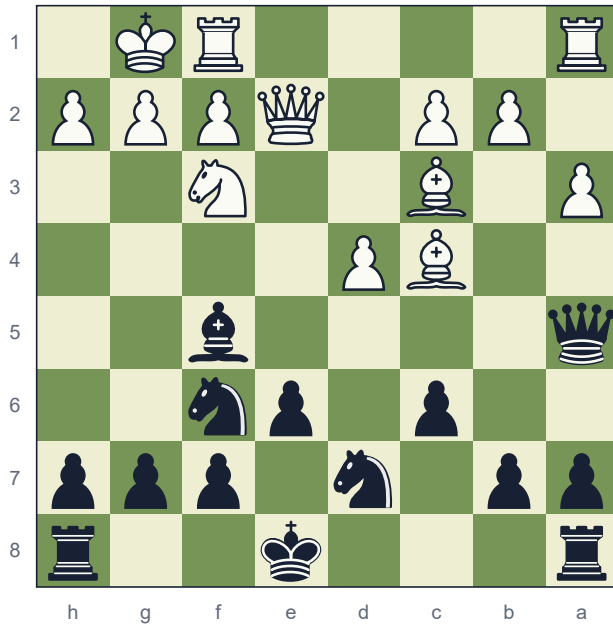
Name the side to move, describe the central structure and give a plan for your course side. Name the opponent's most relevant counterplay. No single move is required.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 37-38



Black to move

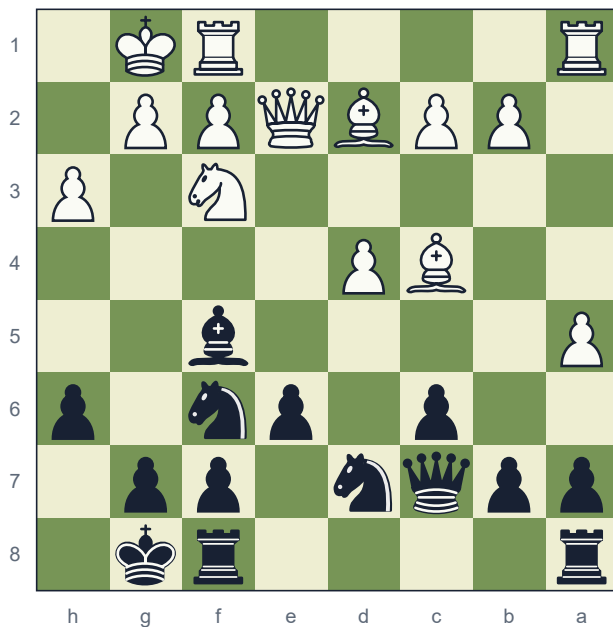
37 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Qc7 with Qd8. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

38 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

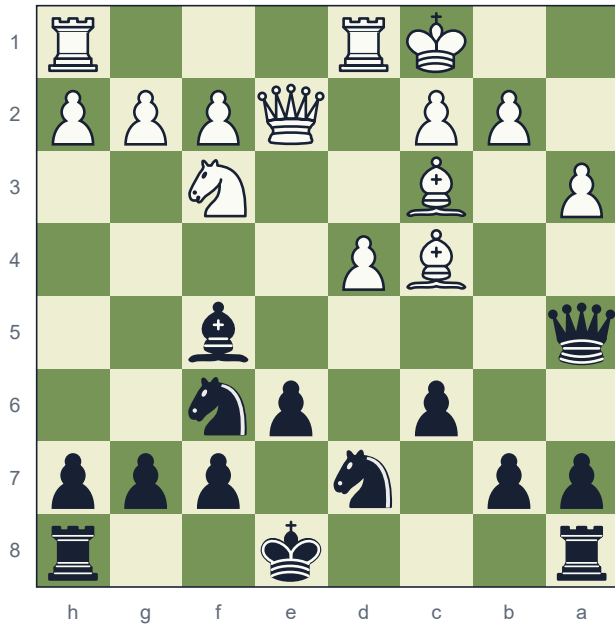
Compare Rfd8 with Rac8. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 39-40



Black to move

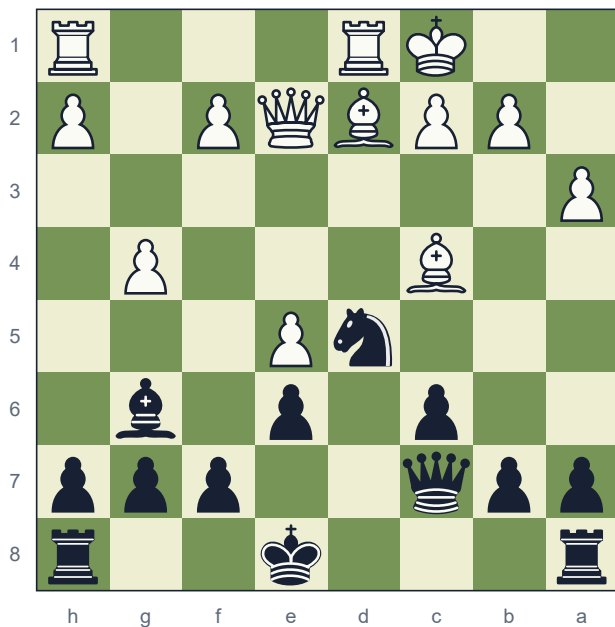
39 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Qd8 with Qc7. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

40 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare h5 with O-O-O. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 41-42



Black to move

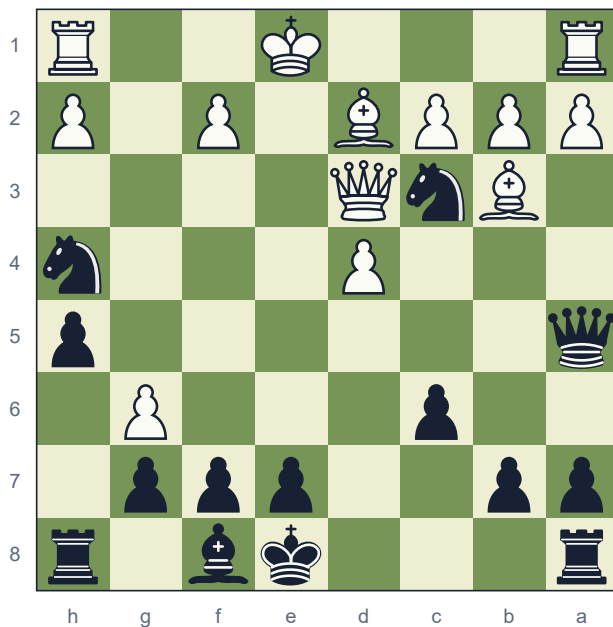
41 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare e6 with h5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

42 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

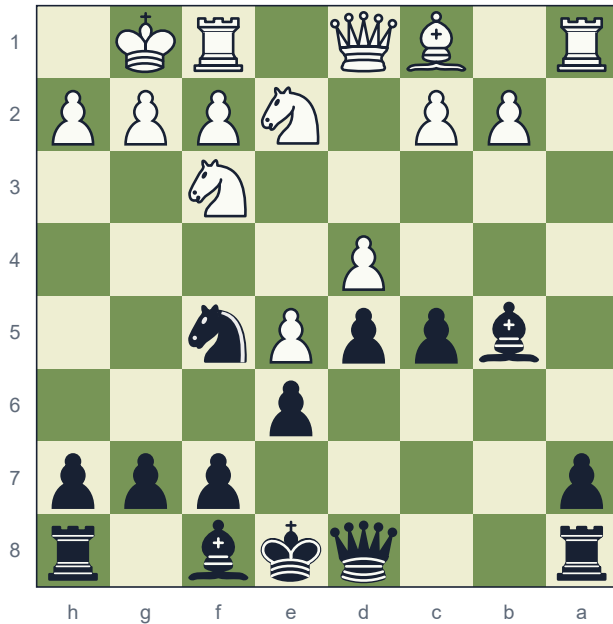
Compare Nxg6 with e6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 43-44



Black to move

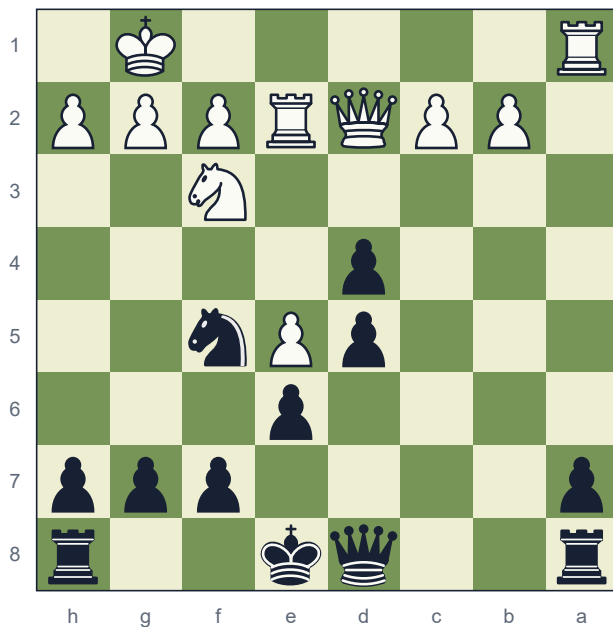
43 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Be7 with cxd4. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

44 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

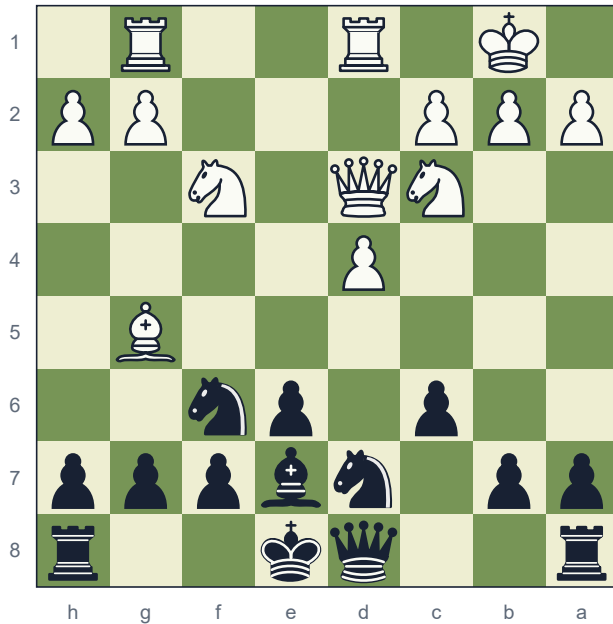
Compare Qb6 with O-O. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 45-46



Black to move

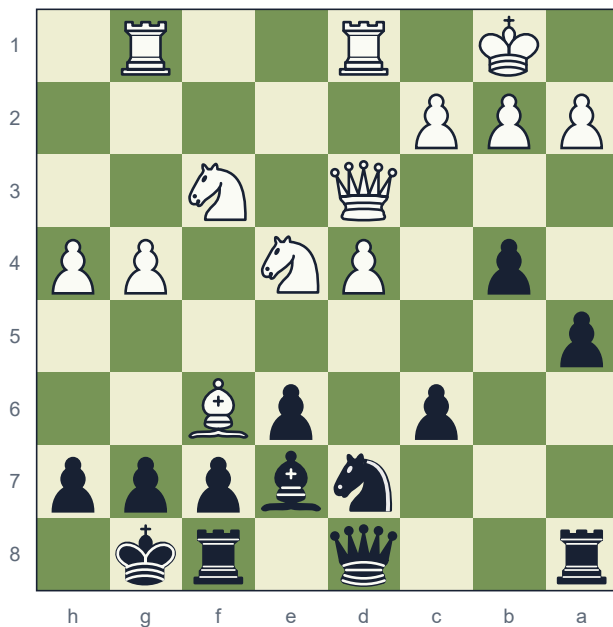
45 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Ng4 with b5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

46 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

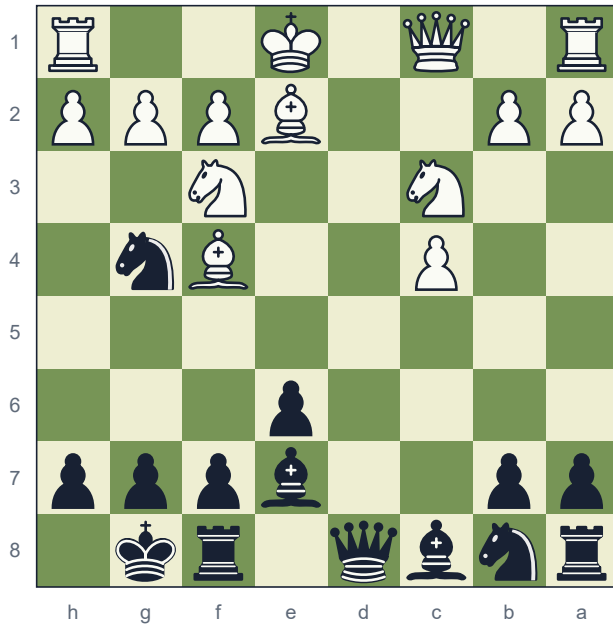
Compare Nxf6 with Bxf6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Exercises 47-48



Black to move

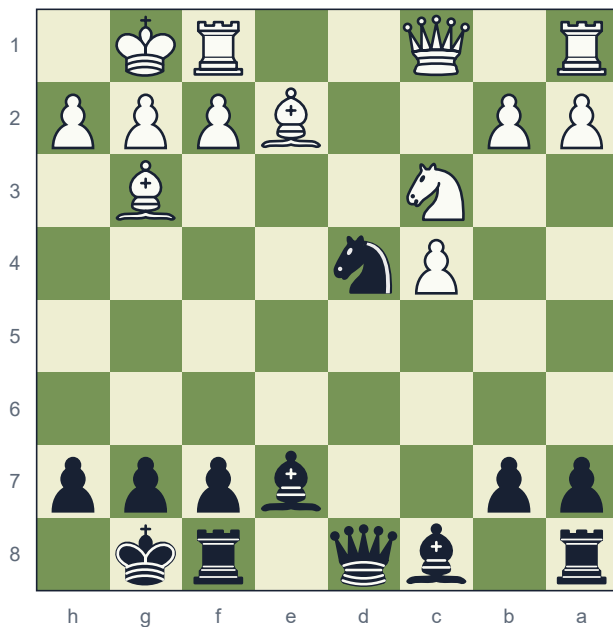
47 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Nc6 with e5. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:



Black to move

48 / CANDIDATE COMPARISON

Compare Be6 with Bf6. Calculate a reply for each, choose your preference and explain it. Similar estimates can support both moves.

My choice or plan:

My reason:

Opponent's resource:

Answers 1-2

01 / SC-01

Course move: 8... Nbd7. Black develops the light-squared bishop before closing the diagonal with ...e6. ...c6 gives the queen c7 as a possible retreat and restrains Nb5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8... Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bb4 10. a3 Bxc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo.

02 / SC-02

Course move: 8... Bb4. Qe2 prepares long castling and increases central pressure. ...Bb4 develops with a concrete relation to the c3 knight rather than immediately making another pawn move.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8... Bb4 9. a3 Nbd7 10. O-O-O Bxc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can play O-O-O and advance the kingside pawns. Opening the center while your own king remains on e8 can be dangerous.

Answers 3-4

03 / SC-03

Course move: 8... Nbd7. Re1 creates pressure on the e-file while Black is still developing. The black king and queen bishop must be coordinated before the center opens.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8... Nbd7 9. Bd2 Qc7 10. Nh4 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

04 / SC-03

Course move: 8... Nbd7. Re1 creates pressure on the e-file while Black is still developing. The black king and queen bishop must be coordinated before the center opens.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

8... Nbd7 9. Bd2 Qc7 10. Nh4 Bg4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it.

Answers 5-6

05 / SC-04

Course move: 7... e6. Bd3 aims at h7 and supports central control. ...Bg4 develops actively against Nf3, reducing one possible supporter of e5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... e6 8. h3 Bh5 9. Bf4 Qd8 10. Re1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Bxh7+ motifs depend on the king position and supporting pieces. Do not create a hook with ...h6 or ...g6 without checking the attacking consequences.

06 / SC-05

Course move: 7... e6. White chooses modest development instead of immediate bishop pressure on f7. Black can complete a sound formation while retaining central counterplay.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... e6 8. Nh4 Bg6 9. g3 Be7 10. Bf3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Quiet development may prepare Ne5 or Nh4. Do not drift into several queen moves just because there is no immediate attack.

Answers 7-8

07 / SC-06

Course move: 7... e6. The g2 bishop puts long-term pressure on the center and queenside. Black should develop while monitoring when the diagonal becomes open.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... e6 8. O-O h6 9. Ne5 Nbd7 10. Qe2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can exchange central pawns and expose b7. A queen on a5 does not defend every queenside target.

08 / SC-07

Course move: 6... c6. ...c6 controls b5 and gives the queen retreat options while White's knight occupies e5. Black must check tactical threats before chasing the knight.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... c6 7. Bc4 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may play g4 against Bf5. The bishop needs a safe square and the queen may become a second tactical target.

Answers 9-10

09 / SC-08

Course move: 7... Be6. Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... Be6 8. Bc4 Nbd7 9. Bxe6 Nxe5 10. Qe2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

10 / SC-08

Course move: 7... Be6. Be6 saves the bishop and avoids the immediate h4 chase that can follow a retreat to g6. The engine comparison favors this retreat in the exact position shown.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

7... Be6 8. Bc4 Nbd7 9. Bxe6 Nxe5 10. Qe2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position.

Answers 11-12

11 / SC-09

Course move: 5... c6. Bd2 creates a potential discovered attack along the d2-a5 diagonal when Nc3 moves. ...c6 supplies a retreat and limits Nb5.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... c6 6. Bc4 Bf5 7. Nd5 Qd8 8. Nxf6+

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Nd5 or Ne4 can be both a central move and a discovered queen attack. A familiar setup does not exempt you from that calculation.

12 / SC-10

Course move: 4... Qxb4. Black can accept the offered pawn, but the queen now faces a series of developing attacks. This is a concrete branch that deserves calculation before practical use.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... Qxb4 5. Rb1 Qd6 6. Nf3 Nf6 7. d4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Rb1, Nb5 and developing bishops may gain tempi. Counting only the extra pawn ignores the cost of the queen's excursion.

Answers 13-14

13 / SC-11

Course move: 4... Nf6. The advanced d-pawn gains space and restricts Black's queen knight. Black must challenge the wedge or develop around it.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... Nf6 5. d5 c6 6. Bd2 Qc7 7. dxc6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can support the pawn and gain further space. A slow sequence of waiting moves may leave Black permanently cramped.

14 / SC-12

Course move: 6... Bf5. The early bishop makes f7 pressure visible sooner, but the position can transpose to the main route after Nf3. Black should recognize the transposition without ignoring immediate checks.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

6... Bf5 7. Ne5 e6 8. g4 Bg6 9. h4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

An early bishop move can combine with a fast queen move. Do not capture an apparently loose central pawn without considering checks.

Answers 15-16

15 / SC-13

Course move: 4... Bd7. White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... Bd7 5. Bxc6 Bxc6 6. d4 e6 7. Nc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

16 / SC-13

Course move: 4... Bd7. White declines the central exchange and gains space. ...c5 challenges the base that White may build with d4, while ...Nc6 adds central pressure.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... Bd7 5. Bxc6 Bxc6 6. d4 e6 7. Nc3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may establish d4 and a French-like space advantage. Capturing e5 before it is safe can leave a piece pinned or a queen exposed.

Answers 17-18

17 / SC-14

Course move: 4... exf6. Black exchanges the central pawn and accepts doubled f-pawns in return for development and open lines. The position has its own structure and is not a ...Qa5 line.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... exf6 5. d4 Bd6 6. Nf3 O-O 7. Be2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can target the f-pawns in an endgame. Do not exchange active bishops automatically while keeping only the structural weakness.

18 / SC-15

Course move: 5... Bf5. White offers a pawn for development and open attacking lines. ...Bf5 develops before ...e6 and makes the extra material easier to defend.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... Bf5 6. Bd3 Bxd3 7. Qxd3 c6 8. Bg5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger.

Answers 19-20

19 / SC-16

Course move: 4... Bf5. Black accepts the central pawn and develops with support for e4. White attacks quickly with knights and hopes to recover material with tempi.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

4... Bf5 5. d3 Bg4 6. Qd2 exd3 7. Bxd3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Nxf7 and threats against the queen can appear. The e4 pawn is not a prize worth losing castling or a piece.

20 / SC-17

Course move: 5... e6. White does not attack the queen immediately. Black develops the knight and bishop, keeping the queen flexible rather than committing to a retreat without a threat.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e6 6. h3 Bxf3 7. Bxf3 Qd6 8. O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can play c4 to chase the queen while supporting d4. Keep safe retreat squares before making a pawn commitment.

Answers 21-22

21 / SC-18

Course move: 5... e6. White postpones Nc3 and c4 while developing. Black can use the time to bring pieces out, but must not assume the queen can remain central forever.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e6 6. O-O Nc6 7. c3 Qd8 8. h3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

22 / SC-18

Course move: 5... e6. White postpones Nc3 and c4 while developing. Black can use the time to bring pieces out, but must not assume the queen can remain central forever.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e6 6. O-O Nc6 7. c3 Qd8 8. h3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

A central queen can be hit by several different pieces. Do not spend the next move on an unrelated wing pawn.

Answers 23-24

23 / SC-19

Course move: 5... e6. The c-pawn move gains a queen tempo but leaves d4 as a possible long-term target. Black retreats safely and develops.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

5... e6 6. Nc3 c5 7. Be2 cxd4 8. Qxd4

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position.

24 / SC-20

Course move: 3... Qxd1+. The early exchange permits a queen trade and removes White's castling rights. With queens gone, the centralized white king is less exposed than it would be in a middlegame.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

3... Qxd1+ 4. Kxd1 Nc6 5. Nd2 Nf6 6. c3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can consolidate with Bd3 and Ke2. Do not overestimate a lost castling right in a simplified position.

Answers 25-26

25 / SC-01

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the f8 bishop, choose a safe king destination and connect the rooks. Watch for a useful ...c5 or ...e5 break after development.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White has more central space and can play Ne5, Nd5 or d5 when supported. A routine pawn move may lose a crucial queen tempo. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

26 / SC-03

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop ...Be7 or ...Bb4 when safe, then castle. Check whether e6 is pinned or overworked before recapturing in the center.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Nh4 against Bf5 and d5 to open lines. Do not treat the e6 pawn as defended merely because the king stands behind it. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 27-28

27 / SC-06

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Place the king bishop and knight, castle safely and contest d5. ...h6 can preserve Bf5 only if its time cost and king-safety effects are acceptable.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can exchange central pawns and expose b7. A queen on a5 does not defend every queenside target. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

28 / SC-08

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Complete development and inspect the center before counterattacking the advanced pawns. Keep the queen safe from discovered attacks as White's knight moves.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White still has space and can attack the bishop or queen with developing moves. A retreat solves the current threat, not the whole position. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 29-30

29 / SC-10

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king g8; central-file pawns c5, e7, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Find safe queen squares and develop quickly. Return the extra pawn if that gets the king safe and prevents the queen being trapped.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Rb1, Nb5 and developing bishops may gain tempi. Counting only the extra pawn ignores the cost of the queen's excursion. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

30 / SC-12

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop ...e6 and ...Nbd7, checking whether a bishop or knight sacrifice on f7 has real support. Castle once the position is ready.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

An early bishop move can combine with a fast queen move. Do not capture an apparently loose central pawn without considering checks. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 31-32

31 / SC-15

White to move. White king b1; central-file pawns c2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Finish development, castle when safe and return the pawn if necessary to neutralize the initiative. Keep f7 and the central files under observation.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Bc4, Ne5 and Qe2 against a slow defense. Greedy pawn grabbing while the king stays central is the main practical danger. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

32 / SC-17

White to move. White king g1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop ...Nc6 or ...Nbd7 according to the center and castle safely. Notice if Nc3 later gains a tempo with a discovered threat.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can play c4 to chase the queen while supporting d4. Keep safe retreat squares before making a pawn commitment. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 33-34

33 / SC-19

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4. Black king g8; central-file pawns e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop the bishops and seek ...c5 or ...Bb4+ when appropriate. Study an isolated d-pawn structure if central exchanges leave White with one.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White has space and easy development. Trying to punish c4 immediately can be worse than accepting a normal position. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

34 / SC-21

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns c2, f2, d4. Black king e8; central-file pawns c6, e6, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Build ...e6 and ...Nbd7, develop the bishop and castle. Seek central counterplay before White converts extra space into a sustained attack.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can use Ne5 or d5 while Black is still developing. The queen's safety alone does not solve the space problem. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 35-36

35 / SC-24

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f2, c4, d5. Black king g8; central-file pawns f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Develop actively and look for central pressure rather than trying to regain the pawn with slow moves. Compare this risk with the direct queen-recapture repertoire.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White can consolidate extra material. A gambit is not justified by development alone if no concrete pressure follows. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

36 / SC-25

White to move. White king e1; central-file pawns f3, c4, c5. Black king e8; central-file pawns d4, f7. Compare the pawn contacts and opened files before choosing a move. Branch plan to reassess: Calculate central blows and develop rapidly. The bishop retreat must preserve activity while the d5 pawn remains unresolved.

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

White may hold the pawn and build a powerful center. Treat this as advanced optional material after mastering the main repertoire. Check which threats remain possible in this exact diagram.

Answers 37-38

37 / SC-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Qd8 (-0.39 from Black's perspective), compared with Qc7 (-0.42 from Black's perspective). Places the queen on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Qd8 12. b4 Be4 13. a4 O-O 14. a5 b5 15. Bd3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Qc7 12. Nh4 Bg6 13. a4 a5 14. Rfd1 Nd5 15. Bd2

38 / SC-LAB-01

The finite search prefers Rfd8 (-0.48 from Black's perspective), compared with Rac8 (-0.48 from Black's perspective). Places the rook on d8. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Rfd8 16. Rfc1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Rac8 16. Rfc1 c5 17. a6 b6 18. Bb5 Rfd8 19. dxc5

Answers 39-40

39 / SC-LAB-02

The finite search prefers Qc7 (-0.60 from Black's perspective), compared with Qd8 (-0.86 from Black's perspective). Places the queen on c7. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... Qc7 12. Ne5 Nxe5 13. dxe5 Nd5 14. g4 Bg6 15. Bd2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Qd8

40 / SC-LAB-02

The finite search prefers h5 (-0.28 from Black's perspective), compared with O-O-O (-0.31 from Black's perspective). Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... h5 16. h3 O-O-O 17. f4 hxg4 18. hxg4 Rxh1 19. Rxh1

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... O-O-O

Answers 41-42

41 / SC-LAB-03

The finite search prefers h5 (-0.26 from Black's perspective), compared with e6 (-0.27 from Black's perspective). Creates a wing or central pawn contact and changes king shelter. Calculate captures and the opponent's central counterplay before extending the advance.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... h5 12. g5 Nd5 13. Bxd5 cxd5 14. O-O Nh4 15. g6

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... e6 12. Bd2

42 / SC-LAB-03

The finite search prefers Nxg6 (-0.27 from Black's perspective), compared with e6 (-0.49 from Black's perspective). The knight captures a pawn on g6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Nxg6 16. bxc3 Rd8 17. Rg1 Ne5 18. Qh3 Nd7 19. O-O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... e6 16. Bxc3

Answers 43-44

43 / SC-LAB-04

The finite search prefers cxd4 (+0.40 from Black's perspective), compared with Be7 (+0.20 from Black's perspective). The pawn captures a pawn on d4. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... cxd4 12. Re1 Bb4 13. Bd2 Bxe2 14. Rxe2 Bc5 15. Ba5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Be7

44 / SC-LAB-04

The finite search prefers Qb6 (+0.23 from Black's perspective), compared with O-O (+0.23 from Black's perspective). Places the queen on b6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Qb6 16. b3

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... O-O 16. Nxd4

Answers 45-46

45 / SC-LAB-05

The finite search prefers b5 (+0.52 from Black's perspective), compared with Ng4 (+0.34 from Black's perspective). Places the pawn on b5. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... b5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Ng4 12. Bxe7 Qxe7 13. Rde1 O-O-O 14. a3 h6 15. Qe2

46 / SC-LAB-05

The finite search prefers Nxf6 (+0.57 from Black's perspective), compared with Bxf6 (+0.08 from Black's perspective). The knight captures a bishop on f6. Calculate the best reply before assuming a recapture, then recount material and opened lines.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Nxf6 16. Nxf6+ Bxf6 17. g5 Be7 18. Ne5 Rc8 19. Qe2

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Bxf6 16. g5

Answers 47-48

47 / SC-LAB-06

The finite search prefers e5 (-0.59 from Black's perspective), compared with Nc6 (-0.70 from Black's perspective). Places the pawn on e5, attacking bishop on f4. A legal capture may still be unsound if the target is defended.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

11... e5 12. Nxe5 Nxe5 13. Bxe5 Nc6 14. Bg3 Bf6 15. O-O

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 11... Nc6

48 / SC-LAB-06

The finite search prefers Be6 (-0.53 from Black's perspective), compared with Bf6 (-0.59 from Black's perspective). Places the bishop on e6. Compare its activity and safety with its previous square, then use the branch explanation to connect the move to a plan.

SAMPLE CONTINUATION

15... Be6 16. Rd1 Nxe2+ 17. Nxe2 Qb6 18. Nf4 Bg5 19. c5

RESOURCE OR COMPARISON

Alternative line: 15... Bf6 16. Bd1 Be6 17. Ne4 Be7 18. Be5 f6 19. Bxd4

A 12-week course you can repeat

WEEKLY WORKLOAD

Aim for four study sessions of 30-45 minutes and two slow practice games. If that is too much, stretch each week to two weeks. Consistency and review matter more than finishing on a deadline.

A 35-MINUTE SESSION

Spend 5 minutes recalling yesterday's position, 10 minutes learning one decision, 15 minutes calculating or playing a position, and 5 minutes writing the lesson. Keep the answer hidden during recall.

USE A MASTERY GATE

Move on when you can reconstruct the main branch, explain its plan and name the opponent's counterplay on two different days. If not, repeat the decision with a changed opposing reply.

DO NOT STUDY EVERY BRANCH EQUALLY

Prioritize the first line of each family and the lines your opponents play. Optional alternatives are comparison material after the main repertoire is stable.

Weeks 1-3

WEEK 1 / BOARD SKILLS AND THINKING ROUTINE

00 foundations; practice coordinates, legal moves, notation and the blunder check. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 2 / FIRST OPENING FAMILY

01 family 1. Learn its main route, then two alternatives. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 3 / SECOND OPENING FAMILY

01 family 2. Compare the opponent's central choices. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 4-6

WEEK 4 / THIRD OPENING FAMILY

01 family 3. Add common deviations and one warning position. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 5 / FOURTH FAMILY AND BOUNDARIES

01 family 4. Distinguish the main repertoire from optional branches and bridges. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 6 / PAWN STRUCTURES

02 strategic lessons 1-4. Identify the correct break from the actual center. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 7-9

WEEK 7 / DEFENSE AND TACTICS

02 remaining lessons and calculation audits. Practice checks, captures and opponent resources. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 8 / FIRST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 1-3. Play each starting position from both sides. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 9 / LAST THREE LABORATORIES

03 laboratories 4-6. Compare candidates before revealing the engine lines. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Weeks 10-12

WEEK 10 / ENDGAME TRANSITIONS

02 endgames. Analyze one legal exchange sequence from your own game. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 11 / FULL RETRIEVAL TEST

04 questions 1-48. Write explanations before looking at answers. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

WEEK 12 / CONSOLIDATE YOUR OWN REPERTOIRE

Repair recurring errors and build a small personal file of the positions you actually meet. Play two practice games and save one critical position. End the week by explaining a decision without the book.

REVIEW LOOP

Revisit new positions after 1 day, 3 days, 7 days and about a month. A failed recall is useful information: shorten the line and rebuild the reason for the move.

Pocket reference / 1

THE ...QA5 CORE REPERTOIRE

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

SC-01 The classical development route

Develop the bishop before locking it in.

SC-02 White uses Qe2 and long castling

The king choice changes the race.

SC-03 White castles short early

An open e-file is a development deadline.

SC-04 White puts the bishop on d3

Respect the bishop diagonal before weakening king cover.

SC-05 White develops quietly with Be2

Use the quiet phase to finish development.

SC-06 White fianchettoes

Long diagonals become dangerous when the center clears.

Pocket reference / 2

ACTIVE WHITE SYSTEMS AND QUEEN SAFETY

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

SC-07 White attacks Bf5 with Ne5

Two attacked pieces can turn a pawn push into a tactic.

SC-08 White pushes g4 against the bishop

Compare the bishop's whole escape route.

SC-09 An immediate Bd2 hits the queen

Every c3-knight move may uncover a queen attack.

SC-10 The b4 pawn offer

Queen safety can be worth more than retaining a gambit pawn.

SC-11 White advances d5 early

A wedge must be challenged or blockaded deliberately.

SC-12 White plays Bc4 before Nf3

Compare exact piece positions before calling a transposition.

Pocket reference / 3

WHITE AVOIDS THE MAIN ROUTE

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

SC-13 White advances with 2.e5

The Scandinavian queen plan belongs to the exchange structure.

SC-14 White defends with 2.Nc3

A structural concession needs active pieces in return.

SC-15 White offers the Blackmar-Diemer

Against a gambit, make the extra pawn easy to live with.

SC-16 White plays 2.Nf3

Defend with development when possible.

SC-17 White recaptures space with 3.d4

A queen needs an escape route even before it is attacked.

SC-18 White chooses 3.Nf3

Use the time White gives you to develop.

SC-19 White attacks the queen with 3.c4

A pawn tempo also changes the pawn structure.

SC-20 White uses 2.d3

Queenless king safety is a different calculation.

Pocket reference / 4

OPTIONAL QUEEN AND KNIGHT RECAPTURES

Use this card after studying the full explanations. It is a reminder, not a replacement for calculating the current position.

SC-21 Optional ...Qd8 repertoire

A safe queen still leaves a development debt.

SC-22 Optional ...Qd6 repertoire

The queen's square determines which knight jumps matter.

SC-23 Optional 2...Nf6: recover with a knight

Different recapture, different development plan.

SC-24 Against 3.c4 after ...Nf6

Choose a gambit knowingly, with a follow-up.

SC-25 Portuguese-style development

Provoking a weakness is useful only if you can use it.

SC-26 Warning: the queen blunder

A check does not suspend the opponent's legal captures.

A practical game-analysis worksheet

GAME DETAILS

Date: _____ Opponent: _____ Time control: _____ Result: _____

FIRST UNFAMILIAR POSITION

Move number: _____ Relevant line ID: _____

What did the opponent's last move threaten? Write the FEN or save the position in your chess program.

MY CANDIDATES

Candidate A and a reply: _____

Candidate B and a reply: _____

Why did I choose the move I played?

DIAGNOSIS

Was the main error opening recall, missed tactics, the wrong pawn break, king safety, an exchange decision or time management? Choose the earliest cause that explains the later problem.

REPAIR

Write one concrete rule tied to the position. Add a short legal variation and schedule the next review. Do not add twenty engine moves that you cannot explain.

Glossary

ANCHOR

The authored move sequence defining a branch; later printed moves may be an illustrative continuation.

COMPENSATION

Activity, king pressure or structural advantages that may offset a material deficit.

COUNTERPLAY

Active threats or pressure that make the opponent address your ideas.

EN PRISE

A piece is available to be captured; check whether the capture is actually safe.

FIANCHETTO

Developing a bishop to b2, g2, b7 or g7 behind a moved b- or g-pawn.

INITIATIVE

The ability to pose threats that influence the opponent's replies.

ISOLATED PAWN

A pawn with no friendly pawn on either adjacent file.

Glossary / continued

MINORITY ATTACK

A pawn advance by fewer pawns against a larger pawn group to create weaknesses.

OUTPOST

A useful supported square for a piece, often difficult for enemy pawns to challenge.

PROPHYLAXIS

A move that anticipates and reduces the opponent's useful plan.

TEMPO

One move of time; useful tempi are gained when threats force helpful replies.

TRANSPOSITION

Different move orders reaching the same position with the same side to move and relevant rights.

ZWISCHENZUG

An intermediate move, often forcing, played before an expected recapture.

Sources and attribution

OPENING NAMES AND ROUTES

Lichess chess-openings is a CC0 reference for established names and entry move orders. The course commentary, study routes and practice curriculum are original. Some Hippo routes use descriptive teaching labels because opening-name databases use that term inconsistently.

<https://github.com/lichess-org/chess-openings>

ENGINE AND LEGAL-MOVE TOOLS

Stockfish 18 supplies finite tactical comparisons and illustrative continuations. python-chess 1.11.2 validates moves, positions and PGN.

<https://stockfishchess.org/download/>

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/>

PIECE ARTWORK

The Cburnett piece designs are by Colin M. L. Burnett, as distributed by python-chess. Adapted SVG sources, attribution and the GPL-2.0 license are included in Artwork_Credits_and_Sources. The palette and PDF drawing scale are adjusted; the original piece silhouettes are retained.

<https://python-chess.readthedocs.io/en/latest/svg.html>

Research scope and verification

SCANDINAVIAN CONTEXT

Public opening references distinguish the immediate queen recapture and 2...Nf6, with ...Qa5, ...Qd8 and ...Qd6 among the queen routes. The detailed repertoire explanations here are original.

<https://www.chess.com/openings/Scandinavian-Defense>

WHAT WAS CHECKED

All 130 course anchors across the five courses were legally replayed. Repertoire-side decisions after the opening commitment received 80,000-node best-move and played-move comparisons; apparent losses above 1.00 were rechecked at 600,000 nodes. Flagged choices were revised. Warning lines deliberately contain mistakes and are marked.

ILLUSTRATIONS AND LIMITS

Short anchors were extended to about move ten using 140,000-node searches. Endpoints used 400,000 nodes; laboratory positions used 500,000 nodes per search. These are finite checks, not proofs of equality or exhaustive modern theory. Optional gambits and full Hippo formations retain practical and strategic risks.

WHAT THE NUMBERS MEAN

Laboratory estimates are expressed from your course side's perspective, so higher is better for that side. They are not literal pawn counts or guaranteed winning probabilities. Close candidate values should be treated as comparable, and deeper analysis may change the ordering.

PUBLICATION CHECKS

PDF text, page geometry, board legality and PGN replay are checked. Every combined-volume page is rendered for visual review. The supplied verification manifest records the final page counts and file hashes.